

ANATOLY TORKUNOV

THE WAR IN KOREA 1950-1953

Its Origin, Bloodshed
and Conclusion

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*Anatoly Torkunov. The War in Korea 1950–1953.
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Contents

Preface	vii
Part I. The Origin	15
Part II. The Bloodshed	69
Part III. The Conclusion	131
Afterword	192

Preface

Fifty years have passed from the moment when persistent confrontation along the 38th parallel demarcation line on the Korean peninsula turned into a big war. Relations between Pyongyang and Seoul were characterized by antagonism and military tensions long before the actual beginning of the war on June 25, 1950. Their origin goes back to the end of 1945 when two military hostile regimes started to emerge in the North and the South under direct influence and supervision of the USSR and the USA.

A full-scale war with the participation of tens of thousands of men, hundreds of tanks, planes and other military equipment and consequently with heavy human losses, tragic sufferings of civil population put to an end hopes for an early establishment of interKorean peace and pushed two Koreas to decades of hostilities and confrontation.

The Korean war has not only become a lasting burden for the two states existing on the Korean peninsula, but has also determined to a large degree the direction of international relations.

Now, after so many years, contemporary analysts have a better understanding of the logic and motives of the both voluntary and involuntary participants of the conflict, they see more clearly the depth of its repercussions for Korea and the entire Far East. And yet, it seems that the Korean war is still full of riddles and its lessons are relevant today as in the past.

A number of key problems can be addressed in this connection. The first one is general international context of the beginning and development of the conflict.

Debates have been going on for decades about who was the first to start the Cold War. The debates are useless.

To pinpoint the first shot in the whirl winding events of the post-war era is impossible anyway, but, more importantly, it does not really matter. This war was inevitable.

The Soviet Union had the Yalta conference mandate to reconstruct Eastern Europe and embarked upon its implementation. Initially Stalin did not have hopes to create there Soviet-style communist regimes. However, resistance on the part of East

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Europeans, vigorously supported by the United States and Western Europe, led Moscow to increasingly radical moves.

Kremlin leaders felt the USA obstructed their drive to establish a security zone along Soviet borders in the West. Besides, according to Moscow's views, Washington refused to recognize the Soviet Union as a great power and winner of the war. As for strategists in the White House they saw in Moscow's actions an unfolding communist expansion in Eastern Europe and strategy aimed at the communization of the entire European continent. Combination of the motives of national security, ideological hostility and great-power ambitions ignited a mutual confrontation of the USSR and the USA in Europe.

A separate Cold War front emerged in the Far East, which was as much inevitable as the one in Europe.

Initially Moscow and Washington did not wish to collide in China. It is a known fact that the two powers reacted an understanding to keep China under Chang Kai-shek's guomintang party. Stalin tried to convince Chinese communists not to challenge the status-quo in the country. They did not listen being eager to topple the corrupted guomintang and to develop China along socialist (communist) lines.

When the Chinese communists won, Stalin naturally could not ignore the victory and promoted cooperation with the new government. The Cold War had already reached a high level and both confronting camps competed for every additional ally.

The United States equally was not able to reconcile itself with the communist victory in China and turn its back to the anti-communist guomintang which fled to the island of Taiwan.

The Korean war flared up soon after the events in China. Both sides—the pro-Soviet North and pro-American South—could not tolerate the thought of a divided nation and were ready to fight for the destruction of the ideological and political opponent. Kim Il Sung continuously begged Stalin to allow him to unite the country by military means. Stalin was against it, not wishing to break agreements with the USA and to create another tension spot.

However, by 1950 the mood in the Kremlin changed. The Cold War had already exceeded all limits and agreements of the victorious powers were nullified. Besides, the balance of power in

the Far East clearly shifted in favor of the Soviet camp. Chinese communists had won and promised to help North Koreans if necessary. Moscow arrived at the conclusion that Koreans of the South would welcome communists while Washington, as in the case of China, would accept defeat.

As for Washington, a Northern advance to the South was received there as one blow too many. The White House decided: if Korea becomes the next domino after China a chain reaction would follow and the Communists would sooner or later "eat up" the entire Asia. The United States threw for defense of South Korea a considerable portion of its military might ensuring as well support in the UN. The United States doubled and tripled its military presence in the Pacific region and managed to woo many countries of the area into defense alliances.

To be sure it would not be correct to call Pyongyang and Seoul simple hostages in a game between two great powers. Both Korean sides were intensely preparing for a war. Doing so they did not plan to be pawns serving global ambitions of Moscow and Washington. The basis of their policies was nationalistic and power ambitions, and we can confidently say that the Korean war right from the start was a civil one with a peculiarity: the country's division along the 38th parallel determined the division of confronting political forces. At the same time intolerance and uncompromising stand of the participants were reinforced by the global Cold War.

Unfortunately concrete facts concerning South Korean American preparations for the war are less known since many relevant documents have not been declassified yet by Seoul and Washington. Nevertheless there are no doubts that Seoul was getting ready for the war and was trying to convince Americans of its inevitability.

As for the North Korean preparations for the war, they can be adequately appraised on the basis of recently declassified Soviet archives. For instance, a comprehensive analysis of the USSR Foreign Ministry titled "On the Korean war, 1950-1953 and armistice negotiations" says that after withdrawal of foreign troops from two parts of Korea "Kim Il Sung and other Korean leaders resolutely set upon the course of military unification of the country, not paying enough attention to then existing possibilities of

The War in Korea 1950—1953

peaceful unification under conditions of broad development of a democratic movement in the South”

According to the same source, by the beginning of the war the ratio of armed forces between South and North Korea was: in land-based forces 1:2; artillery pieces 1:2; stationary large-caliber machine guns 1.7; machine guns 1.13; tanks 1:6,5; planes 1:6 in favor of North Koreans.

The study of the Korean war history clearly reveals serious doubts of Stalin about advisability of the war. At the first meeting with Kim Il Sung in the spring of 1950 Stalin, responding to the guest's proposal “to feel out the South with bayonets”, recommended to think everything over once again and present a concrete plan of actions. Stalin did not want an American interference on the South Korea's side fearing a global conflict. However, certain Soviet politicians and military figures convinced Stalin in the possibility of a quick victory. The Soviet leader still demanded Mao Zedong's approval of the plan and allowed its implementation only upon a positive response from China.

By the end of May, 1950 the strategy of a general assault on the South was designed. At first the strategy seemed to work as North Korean armed forces occupied 95% of South Korea in the span of several weeks.

However, hopes of the North Korean leadership were soon crashed as a result of a direct American intervention. Acting under the cover of the UN Security Council resolution, adopted in the absence of the Soviet representative on June 27, 1950, the United States and its allies entered the Korean war. In the strategic area of Pusan-Tegu Americans quickly managed to concentrate armed forces two times larger than weakened and cut from a reliable rearguard 70 thousand men strong army of the Northerners.

On September 18, 1950 Pentagon executed in the Inchong region a large-scale landing operation of 50 thousand men forces equipped with tanks and big cannons and supported by a Navy and Air Force (up to 800 planes). North Korean army was virtually encircled and soon the front line approached Yalu river on the North Korea China border.

Archival materials testify that Stalin was determined to avoid a direct Soviet involvement in the conflict because the main Cold

War theatre was in Europe. Immediately before the war Stalin recalled majority of Soviet advisers attached to North Korean military units. He was afraid that Soviet military specialists might be captured which would create complications for Moscow. Stalin was against appointing to Korea Malinovsky, the Commander-in-Chief of the Far Eastern military district. The Soviet leader equally opposed sending Soviet tank crews to the Korean peninsula. Khrushchev in his memories wrote in this connection: "If Kim received one or, at most, two tank corps he could speed up his advance to the South and capture Pusan" At the same time the archival documents show that Stalin interfered in the war activities, examined various concrete questions and gave direct orders.

While opposing involvement of the Soviet land forces in the war, Stalin gave "green light" to the participation of the Soviet Air Force. 70 thousand Soviet flyers took part in the Korean conflict. They shot down approximately 1200–1300 adversary planes though Soviet losses were also considerable. Thanks to the Soviet pilots North East China received an "air defense umbrella". Soviet ambassador to the DPRK, two-star general Razuvaev served as well in the capacity of the chief military adviser to the North Korea China armed forces. Together with Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai ambassador Razuvaev directed war actions. There were many other senior Soviet officers working in the military command.

In the second part of October, 1950 Chinese troops disguised as volunteers entered the war. Their numbers soon reached 1 million men. Approximately as many soldiers were sent to Korea to transport military supplies. North Korean army by the end of 1951 had just 337 thousand soldiers and officers.

On the South Korean American side over 700 thousand men participated in the war, including 260 thousand Americans, not counting Navy and Air Force based near coastlines of Korea. Chinese-North Korean troops, under the Soviet air cover, managed to push the adversary to the south of the 38th parallel. In early January, 1951 Chinese units captured Seoul. Nevertheless the war situation changed to a kind of prolonged strategic stand-off. Neither side was able to change the tide of the war in its own favor. It was in this stalemate situation when general Macarthur,

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Commander-in-Chief of the UN forces, insisted on delivering a nuclear strike against China.

Those were critical days as the world community got on the verge of a nuclear catastrophe. Besides Soviet Air Force fighting in Korea, five Soviet tank divisions were poised on the border with the DPRK and Soviet Pacific fleet was also on full combat alert.

And yet sober minds prevailed in Washington, Moscow, Beijing, Seoul and Pyongyang. Those who favored a peace dialogue and armistice. On July 27, 1953 after almost two years of intensive diplomatic struggle, already after Stalin's death, an armistice agreement was reached, which put an end to a senseless bloodshed on the Korean soil. During over three years of bloody fighting more than 400 thousand South Koreans, 142 thousand American, 17 thousand other UN army soldiers were killed. Overall American expenditures for the war reached \$83 bln.

The DPRK and the PRC armed forces sustained much larger casualties: according to various estimates from 2 to 4 mln. men. Soviet losses were also considerable. Air units lost 335 planes and 120 pilots. Official overall losses reached 299 men, among them 138 officers and 161 sergeants and privates. We must note however that there are contradictory figures on the Soviet losses. Kim Il Sung while talking in Pyongyang in February 1968 to Soviet Communist Party Central Committee Secretary Ponomarev pointed out that the USSR lost in the Korean war 62 generals and colonels (not counting others).

North Korean economy was devastated in the war under constant bombardments by American planes. 88700 industrial plants, 600 thousand apartment houses, many thousands of schools, hospitals, cultural centers were destroyed in the war.

So what are the lessons and long term consequences of the Korean conflict?

History testifies that both camps in the Cold War were prudent enough to avoid a head-on collision bound to turn into a nuclear disaster. At the same time if one of the superpowers felt that it could expand its sphere of influence without risking a global conflict it rushed to do it.

Such situation evolved in Korea, where local communists and their anti-communist opponents were anxious to overpower the

other side and sought support and blessings by Moscow or Washington. Stalin finally allowed North Korean communists "to finish revolution", feeling that Americans won't interfere.

The Soviet leader miscalculated and lives of millions of men have become the price of the Stalin's mistake. It has to be noted, however, that the South Korean side was equally eager to fight hoping to be aided by the USA.

Raging for three years the Korean war negatively influenced the entire environment in the Asian Pacific region as well as in the world at large. It became one of the contributing factors to the intensification of the Cold War, stimulating formation of opposing military blocks, provoking new political-ideological conflicts, encouraging one superpower to ruthlessly suppress democracy as "the Trojan horse" of the West while the other to adamantly oppose national liberation movements and social and political progress in the Third World. The Korean peninsula itself remains up to now "a hot spot"

The Korean war had negative consequences for interests of many countries, including the USSR. Because of this war Moscow fully and for a long time spoiled relations with Washington. The war created tensions in the Soviet-Chinese alliance. Beijing was offended that the Kremlin had convinced it to fight on the peninsula while staying on the side and collecting payments for Soviet arms supplies. Some other aspects of the conflict also contributed to mutual irritation of the allies.

The conflict firmly shut the door to the normalization of Moscow-Seoul relations and made it necessary for the USSR to tolerate American military presence in the South of Korea and other key areas of Asia and the Pacific throughout the entire post-war history. Moscow could not as well establish normal, mutually advantageous ties with the majority of other regional states. The United States not only limited Moscow's activities, but created from the Eastern direction a growing security threat to the USSR. Washington used the opportunity to achieve military-political hegemony in the Asian-Pacific region, which still remains in force.

The consequences of the Korean war were even more unpleasant for China. It got into a strong isolation in the world arena. The PRC was denied an access to the United Nations. China was encircled with American military bases while Chinese island Tai-

The War in Korea 1950—1953

wan was turned by Washington into an “insinkable aircraft carrier” aimed against the mainland. Beijing had no choice but to lean to the Soviet side and agree to the role of a “junior brother” This unequal alliance triggered the Soviet-Chinese quarrel and later extremism in Beijing’s internal and external policies.

As for the two Koreas, the present internal crisis state of the DPRK is a logical result of the war’s heritage. Confrontation with the North and the pretext of a possible “aggression” by Pyongyang postponed for decades democratic development in the South, made South Koreans suffer police and military-bureaucratic regimes.

To be sure these are not the only results of the Korean war. Let us hope, however, that the said above may serve to some extent as a warning against repetition of tragic mistakes in the Asian-Pacific region.

Part I

The Origin

After the liberation of Korea in 1945 and up to the end of 1949 Stalin not only did not plan any war on the Peninsula, but he was increasingly worried that the opposing side might break the peace and launch an attack on the North. As in the case of Germany before World War II, the Soviet dictator did everything to avoid provoking the United States and Seoul and to safeguard the status quo in Korea.

The following are some of the documents from the Soviet archives, which illustrate the mood in Moscow at that time concerning Korea.

On May 12, 1947 Soviet representatives in North Korea Kirill A. Meretzkov and Terentii F. Shtykov sent Stalin an urgent request:

"In accordance with the decision of the USSR government of July 26, 1946 in our coded message N 15327, December 16, 1946 we brought to your attention a proposal to bring 82 Soviet specialists to help North Korea in the rehabilitation and development of industry and the railroad system.

However, up to now not one specialist has come to Korea... Without the assistance of Soviet or other foreign specialists, industry and the railroad system of North Korea will not be able to work. It is absolutely necessary to send Soviet engineers and technicians to the North to prevent its collapse and also to strengthen our positions and influence in Korea in the future.

If before the unification of North and South Korea and creation of the Provisional Korean government Soviet specialists don't arrive in North Korea, then the Korean Provisional Government... will inevitably invite American specialists. It will harm our state interests and strengthen American influence in Korea"¹

Stalin put his resolution on the cabled "Give them 5-8 Soviet specialists, who can make Koreans work harder themselves. We should not be too involved in Korea"²

On January 17, 1949 Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young talked to Soviet Ambassador Shtykov. The Ambassador reported to Moscow: "Referring to the desire, expressed earlier by Kim Il Sung,

¹ Coded message N 121973, 12 May 1947. The 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Soviet Armed Forces, P 4-6.

² Ibid, P 4.

to sign the friendship and cooperation treaty with the USSR, I explained that in the present situation, when the country is divided into two parts, the conclusion of such a treaty is not advisable. It could be used by South Korean reactionary forces against the government of the DPRK in order to perpetuate the division of the country. It will also complicate relations between the USSR and the United States”

This thesis provoked a certain confusion for Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young. Kim Il Sung not very confident but attempted to press for the conclusion of the treaty, saying that if it is somehow impossible, then a secret agreement about Soviet assistance to Korea should be concluded.

After my additional explanations Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young agreed that at this moment it is not timely to raise the issue of conclusion of the friendship and cooperation treaty”³

On January 27, 1949 Shtykov put the Kremlin on alert: “Lately, during the last 10 days (January, 15—25), the number of violations of the 38th parallel by the South Korean police and army has increased.

According to intelligence information of the North Korean police, units of the South Korean army have been moved closer to the 38th parallel. A concentration of troops is being conducted at the main operational directions Kosong-Tongduchon-Namchonjom-Haeju. According to the information of police, in the area of Kaesong the first brigade of 11 thousand personnel has been concentrated, at other directions there are 3—5 thousand personnel in each place. As agents arriving from South Korea report, gossip is being actively spread there that the South Korean Army is preparing an offensive against the North. South Korean officers are presumably saying that they must start the offensive first and get the initiative in their hands.

North Korean authorities have undertaken necessary measures to reinforce protection of the 38th parallel and to raise vigilance.

Conclusions: I think that the offence of the South Korean Army at the present moment is of a low probability, because

³ Shtykov's cable to the Foreign Ministry. January 19 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

neither the internal, nor the external situation allows this offensive.

It cannot be dismissed that they've moved the troops to the 38th parallel and concentrated them at main directions... in order to cover Seoul from the Northerners, because the South always expects an attack by the North.

Lately South Korean intelligence has also increased sending terrorist groups to the North. 80 persons have been arrested in total.

In Haeju a group of 14 was detained with 5 explosive packets, 6 bottles of liquid explosives and a bucket of gasoline. They had an assignment to burn warehouses, schools and kill local leaders"⁴

In February 1949 the Soviet embassy in Pyongyang gets more worried. On February 3, 1949 Ambassador Shtykov informs Foreign Minister Molotov:

"Situation on the 38th parallel is very unstable. South Korean police and troops daily cross the parallel and attack police posts of North Korea. The 38th parallel is guarded by two brigades of North Korean policemen. These brigades are armed only with Japanese rifles. There are only from 3 to 10 bullets for each rifle. There are no machine-guns. As a result. North Korean policemen are not able to resist attacks, and, sometimes having used all their bullets, they get captured by South Korean police.

By the decision of the Soviet government, Soviet weapons are designated for these two brigades.

According to the order of the Ministry of the Armed Forces of the USSR these weapons are to be provided by the Maritime military region.

My numerous conversations with the command of the region concerning speedy supply of the weapons have not produced positive results.

... I also ask you to take into consideration the fact that according to the above mentioned decision of the Soviet government Koreans have formed a rifle division and a brigade, but their

⁴ Shtykov's cable to the Foreign Ministry, January 27, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 47-49.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

armaments have not arrived as yet... I ask your urgent interference in the matter”⁵

On February 4, 1949 Shtykov informs Moscow about a major assault by South Korean police on the North. “After heavy fighting, attacks and counterattacks, says the Soviet Ambassador in his cable, the violators captured a hill 200-300 meters to the north of the parallel. Close to it, immediately to the South of the parallel, a battalion of South Korean troops has been concentrated”⁶

The topic of tensions on the 38th parallel was raised during Stalin’s reception of Kim Il Sung and the North Korean delegation in Moscow on March 5, 1949.

“Kim Il Sung: There are still American troops in the South and the provocations of reactionary forces against North Korea are getting more and more intensive. And though we have ground troops, we lack almost completely the seashore defense. We need assistance in this matter from the USSR.

Stalin: How many troops do Americans have now in South Korea?

Kim Il Sung: Up to 20 thousand soldiers.

Stalin: Do they have a national army in the South?

Kim Il Sung: Yes, about 60 thousand soldiers.

Stalin: Does this figure include police?

Kim Il Sung: No, just the regular army

Stalin: Are you afraid of them?

Kim Il Sung: No, we are not afraid, but we would like to have navy units.

Stalin: Which army is stronger, yours or theirs?

Park Hon-young: Our army is stronger.

Stalin: We can help you with the navy; you should also have military planes.

Do you penetrate inside the South Korean army? Do you have your people inside that army?

Park Hon-young: Yes, but these people keep a low profile there and don’t do anything.

⁵ Shtykov’s cable to the Foreign Ministry, February 3, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 6-7

⁶ Ibid, February 4, 1949, P 11-12.

Stalin: It is correct. They must not do anything now. Southerners probably also send agents to the North, so you must be vigilant.

What happened recently on the 38th parallel? Is it true that Southerners attacked and captured a number of points and that later you took those points back?

Kim Il Sung: ... There was a clash in the province of Kangwondo near the 38th parallel. Our police were not armed well. But later regular forces arrived and we chased the Southerners away.

Stalin: Did you chase them away or they left themselves?

Kim Il Sung: We defeated them, threw them out of the country

Stalin: The 38th parallel should be peaceful. It is important”⁷

The Kremlin's alarm sharply rose in April 1949. On April 17, 1949 Stalin warned his Ambassador in Pyongyang:

“According to the available information in May the withdrawal of American troops from South Korea to the nearest islands of Japan is planned. The purpose of the withdrawal is to give freedom of action to the South Korean Army. By that time the UN Commission will also leave Korea.

In April-May the Southerners must concentrate their troops near the 38th parallel. In June the Southerners will start a sudden attack on the North in order to finish the total destruction of the Northern army by August.

As of April 10 Southerners concentrated in the area of Kaesong up to 8,000 soldiers (a brigade) and in the area of Uijongbu up to 10,000 soldiers (probably the 3rd brigade). In Tongduchon on April 10 three tanks were unloaded.

Take urgent measures to verify the information and inform us”⁸

On April 20, 1949 the Soviet Ambassador reported to Stalin that his order was being implemented and simultaneously he expressed profound worries about the level of combat capabilities of the North Korean Army:

⁷ Stalin's conversation with the DPRK's government delegation, headed by Kim Il Sung, March 5, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-11.

⁸ Stalin's cable to the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang, April 17, 1949, P 25.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

“The combat preparedness of the Korean People’s Army has considerable shortcomings:

1. The North has managed to train only 8 fliers. Training of other fliers is impeded by the absence of UT-2 training planes and the lack of aviation fuel.

2. So far most Soviet advisers to the armed forces have not arrived. The chief adviser Smirnov has very poor military qualifications; he is also rude and not respected by Koreans.

3. Decision of the Soviet government to help production of weapons and ammunitions has not been implemented.

4. Until now the seashore defense has not been organized”⁹

On the same day Ambassador Shtykov reported to Stalin on the situation between the North and South:

“After withdrawal of our troops from North Korea, violations of the 38th parallel by ‘the Southerners’ have acquired a provocative and systematic character. During the last month these violations have become more frequent.

In total, in the period from January 1 to April 15, along the entire 38th parallel 37 violations have been committed, among them 24 violations took place from March 15 to April 15...

... In all instances the initiative of opening fire was instigated by ‘the Southerners’

Simultaneously with the aggravation of the situation on the 38th parallel, ‘the Southerners’ in the course of March and April have moved a portion of their ground troops to the 38th parallel.

... We cannot exclude the possibility that ‘the Southerners’ will initiate new provocations against troops of the North Korean government with the introduction of more sizable forces.

Taking into account this fact, we consider it necessary to recommend that the North Korean government take required measures to respond to a possible new, larger scale provocative attack by ‘the Southerners’”¹⁰

⁹ Shtykov’s cable to the Foreign Ministry, April 20, 1949, Archives of the President of Russia, P 27-28.

¹⁰ Marshal Aleksander M. Vasilevsky and Ambassador Shtykov’s cable to Stalin, April 20, 1949, N 17064, P 1-2.

On May 2, 1949 Ambassador Shtykov gives a detailed report on the above mentioned request of Stalin (April 17, 1950) to find out if the South is preparing an assault on the North:

"... According to the dispatches of our agents and broadcasts of Seoul Radio, at the present time American and South Korean authorities are conducting negotiations about the withdrawal of American troops from South Korea.

In connection with plans for military intrusion into the North, South Korean authorities are increasing the size of the Army of National Defense. According to the reports of our agents, the South Korean Army has increased from 53,600 soldiers as of January 1, 1949 to 70,000 as of the end of March.

Special attention is paid to the technical, mechanical and special troops, which have grown by 2—4 times. Measures have been taken to purge the army of 'unreliable' soldiers and officers. Military units are being reinforced by representatives of reactionary-minded youths. Americans are supplying the South Koreans with considerable quantities of various types of weapons and ammunition. South Korean authorities take measures to receive weapons in much larger quantities. This is the main purpose of the mission of Cho Byung-ock to Washington.

South Korean authorities massed troops in the areas adjoining the 38th parallel. According to the received information, the total number of troops in this area has reached 41,000 persons. The main focus is given to the Pyongyang direction.

According to the report of the commander of a South Korean battalion, who is connected to the intelligence of the North, the number of troops at the Pyongyang direction will be increased to 30,000. Plans for the attack on the North have been approved and in the first brigade they have been already passed to the battalion commanders. The military campaign will be launched in January. In this connection the South Korean authorities have taken decisive measures to suppress uprisings in the South and to defeat completely the democratic movement.

Agents of the South have set up in the North, in every province, terrorist and subversive groups which are ordered to recruit new members, to conduct espionage, to draft plans for uprisings. From the South, these groups receive grenades, guns and, as arrested persons confess, in May the groups will receive addi-

tional weapons. Such groups have been uncovered in Pyongyang (2), Haeju (1), and Sinuiju (1).

... Measures have been taken to raise vigilance, strengthen the army and police of North Korea"¹¹

On May 27, 1949 Kim Il Sung told the Soviet Ambassador that battalions of the South Korean army have already started military actions in the area of Seowonri, 45 kilometers to the south from the city of Kosong. As Ambassador Shtykov reported to Moscow, according to Kim Il Sung, two other battalions are preparing to attack the North, capturing a number of hills beyond the 38th parallel. Kim Il Sung also said that the Southerners moved units to the 38th parallel, which had participated in the suppression of an uprising on Chejudo Island"¹²

On June 5, 1949 Ambassador Shtykov quoted Kim Il Sung as saying that the South is preparing an attack because it is afraid of peaceful unification. Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young stressed in a conversation with the Ambassador: "If you hold universal elections in the whole of Korea under free conditions the leftist and socialist organizations will be victorious. In North Korea they'll get 80% of the vote, in South Korea they'll get 65-70% of the vote. That's why Americans and South Koreans are looking for a military solution"¹³

On June 18, 1949 the Soviet Ambassador continued to develop the thesis of an imminent attack from the South: "The withdrawal of American troops untie the hands of South Korean reactionary forces, which intend to solve the problem of unification of the country through military means. Such a position is advocated by Syngman Rhee, Lee Born-sok, Shin Sung-mo and leadership of "the National Democratic Party." They differ only on the timing of the war. Shin Ick-hee, Lee Ung-jun and others believe that before attacking the North it is necessary to reinforce the rear-guards. Kim Sug-won and others, who are close to the military circles, demand an immediate implementation of the war plan.

¹¹ Shtykov's report to Stalin, May 2, 1949, P 41-44.

¹² Shtykov's cable to Gromyko, Shtemenko, May 28, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

¹³ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 2, 1949, Archives of the President of Russia, P 5.

In connection with the withdrawal of the American troops, the Southern army is being concentrated in the vicinity of the 38th parallel. Our agents inform us that only one battalion is left on Chejudo Island; few troops are left in Kwangju, Hoengsong and Taegu. According to the same sources, the Southern army will attack the North three days before the official announcement of the completion of the withdrawal of American troops”¹⁴

On June 22, 1949 Ambassador Shtykov complained that North Korea was totally unprepared to resist an assault from the South:

“We don’t have enough North Korean force at the Pyongyang direction. In case the South launches an attack, it will certainly choose the Pyongyang direction for the main strike. They’ll concentrate two or three divisions there... As for the parallel itself, it is guarded by only two police border brigades, consisting of 6 battalions each. Units of these brigades are stretched along the front, and when the South starts the attack, the brigades won’t be able to put up a serious resistance. These brigades don’t have enough weapons, and those that they possess are of mixed origin - both Soviet and Japanese. There is almost no Japanese ammunition... North Korea has just 11 pilots, capable of flying and hopefully conducting combat activities.

The air force is not ready to put up resistance to the aggressor... Production of armaments and ammunition is not as yet organized in North Korea... 4 formations of the people’s army and 2 police brigades are not fully ready for defensive activities”¹⁵

On August 3, 1949 Stalin again sent to the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang an intelligence report that “very influential figures in the South Korean government insist on intrusion into North Korea”¹⁶ Not to provoke the adversary and to distance the USSR from the war in case it starts Soviet leadership decides to liquidate the Soviet navy base in the port of Chongjin and air force

¹⁴ Shtykov’s cable to Stalin, June 18, 1949, Archives of the President of Russia, P 65-66.

¹⁵ Shtykov’s cable to Stalin, June 22, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 69, 72.73.

¹⁶ Stalin’s cable to the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang, August 3, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 88-89.

offices in Pyongyang and Kanggye. "Politically, says a Kremlin document, it would be advisable to withdraw the military facilities now in order to demonstrate to the world our intentions, psychologically disarm the adversaries and to prevent our participation in the possible war against Southern aggression"¹⁷

On July 13, 1949 Ambassador Shtykov provides fresh evidence to Moscow of the aggressive intentions of the South: "On July 12 at the Ongjin direction (40 kilometres to the west of Kaesong) three South Korean soldiers were captured...

The captives... said that their commanding officer during the month of July often explained to them that the North wants to attack the South and in order to preempt the North the South Korean army must deliver a sudden strike against the North and before August 15 (Korean Liberation Day) it must complete capture of North Korea.

... According to reports from our agents, Syngman Rhee said at a secret meeting that... the offensive will start in July. Now the South Korean army is being regrouped. The civilian population is being evacuated from the areas adjacent to the 38th parallel"¹⁸

On October 30, 1949 Stalin lashes out at the Soviet Ambassador for "provoking North Koreans to start local offensive operations against South Koreans" The Soviet leader says: "Such provocations are very dangerous for our interests and can induce the adversary to launch a big war. Your actions are totally irresponsible"¹⁹

Shtykov promptly denied the accusation:

"... I sternly warned our adviser at the Ministry of Interior of North Korea Colonel Bodyagin, to watch carefully so that the Northerners don't violate the 38th parallel... I have not given any recommendations to the North Korean government to start active moves against the South Koreans"²⁰

¹⁷ Recommendations on Korea, August 2, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

¹⁸ Shtykov's report to Moscow, July 13, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-3.

¹⁹ Stalin's cable to Shtykov, October 30, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 2-4.

²⁰ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, October 31, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

Moscow was not satisfied with the explanation. A cable to Ambassador Shtykov from the Kremlin was harsh:

"Here are the instructions of the Central Committee.

The explanation, presented by you is totally unsatisfactory. It demonstrates that you don't follow the orders that you were given in Moscow.

Instead of strictly and invariably implementing the order not to permit any tensions on the 38th parallel, not to provoke the South in any way, you got engaged in a discussion of this issue. In reality you have failed to fulfill the instructions"²¹

On January 6, 1950 Ambassador Shtykov gave another confirmation of the aggressive mood prevailing in the South. In a cable to the Kremlin, he said:

"According to the received information, on January 1950 the State Council of the puppet government of Syngman Rhee held a meeting devoted to the political situation of South Korea. Here are the excerpts of some speeches at the meeting.

"... Shin Sung-mo: America does not provide us adequate assistance either for war or peaceful unification of Korea. We must solve these issues ourselves. Relying on our forces we must deliver the last, decisive strike...

Syngman Rhee:... Let's say unify Korea with a single military blow. Nevertheless, the situation in Korea might get aggravated if the Japanese issue is not solved in our interests... Later we must with Japan and America widely launch the anti-communist movement"²²

In the atmosphere when both Pyongyang and Moscow expected an attack from the South Kim Il Sung reversed his position and decided to press for an offensive strategy against the South.

In August, 1949 just before Soviet Ambassador Shtykov's departure for a vacation in Moscow, North Korean leaders resumed their pressure requesting the military solution to the Korean problem.

²¹ Stalin's cable to Ambassador Shtykov, November 20, 1949. Archives of the President of the USSR, P. 107.

²² Shtykov's cable to Moscow, January 1, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P. 1-2.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Twice, on August 12 and 14, they met Shtykov to give their reasons for an advance on the South. On August 12, Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young said to Shtykov:

"Now that it is clear that the Southerners have rejected the proposals of the United Democratic Fatherland Front concerning peaceful reunification, the North has no choice but to get prepared for an offensive against the South. It will certainly be accompanied by the eruption there of a large-scale popular uprising against the regime of Syngman Rhee.

If we don't launch an offensive against the South, the Korean people will not be able to understand. We'll lose confidence and support of our nation and will lose the historical chance to return the Motherland. Comrade Stalin, who has always supported and helped Koreans, will certainly understand our feelings"²³

The Soviet Ambassador reported to the Korean leaders:

"Comrade Stalin gave his position during talks in Moscow on March 11. Its essence is that the Northern army has not achieved a clear superiority over the adversary. Besides, there is an agreement between the USSR and the USA on the 38th parallel. The offensive can be justified only if the South attacks the North first"²⁴

Kim Il Sung disputed this point. According to the Soviet Ambassador, he said that from his point of view the demarcation line along the 38th parallel had some meaning as long as American troops were stationed in the South. But now they've left the Korean peninsula, so the obstacle of the agreement on the 38th parallel has been, in fact, removed. The line meant the zone of deployment and control of the Soviet and American armies. Now they don't control anything in Korea. Why should the line be in place and be observed?

The question of the counterattack, the North Korean leaders stressed, had to be addressed anew as well. It looks like the Southerners postponed the overall offensive against the North. Instead they decided to build a strong defensive line along the 38th parallel, something like the Maginot Line before World War

²³ Memorandum of Ambassador Shtykov's Conversation with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young. August 12, 1949, Archives of the President of Russia, P 4-5.

²⁴ *Ibid*, P 6.

II in France. Because of this the Korean People's Army lacked the opportunity to wage the counterattack and comrade Stalin recommended they stick to this tactic²⁵

In his memorandum on conversation with North leaders Ambassador Shtykov continued:

"North Korean leaders also pointed out that in the course of previous numerous skirmishes along the border the Korean People's Army demonstrated a clear advantage over the troops of South Korea. They insisted that the North Korean armed troops were able to quickly overrun the defenses of the adversary

I again responded to the Korean leaders in light of what comrade Stalin had stated in the conversations with Kim Il Sung in March 1949. Concluding, I expressed doubts that the plans of the North Korean leadership could be implemented. I pointed out that the appraisal of the situation by Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young was not precise. It was over-optimistic and idealistic.

Such a position was a bit unexpected for Kim Il Sung. He looked offended, but then raised another question, concerning the creation of a liberated zone in the area of the coal mines in Samchok in Kangwondo, adjacent to the 38th parallel.

I responded that such a move could be made only after a thorough preparation and analysis of the situation"²⁶

In the memorandum of conversation with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young on August 14, 1949 Ambassador Shtykov wrote:

"Kim Il Sung raised again the issue of attacking the South, claiming that there was no choice but to solve the Korean issue through this method.

After I repeated our arguments, Kim Il Sung agreed that the operation had to be carefully prepared. First of all, the DPRK needed urgent supplies of additional Soviet equipment and armaments. The North Korean army, Kim Il Sung said, needs from two to three full sets of ammunition for the armed forces. Second, Kim Il Sung raised the question of starting the offensive against the South with a local operation. The prime target of the attack would be the Ongjin peninsula in the territory of South Korea. If it were taken it would result in a reduction of the length

²⁵ Ibid, P 6-7.

²⁶ Ibid, P 7.

of the land border of the DPRK along the 38th parallel by 120 km. Then North Koreans would need fewer forces to guard the line. The Ongjin peninsula would also serve as a springboard for further advance. I repeated that any actions could be taken only after a thorough appraisal of our capabilities and the overall situation”²⁷

On August 27, 1949 Shtykov presented to Stalin the above cited memorandums of his conversations with the North Korean leaders on August 12 and 14 followed by his own comments. The main conclusion of Shtykov was that the offensive on the South was not possible now for these reasons:

“1. At the present moment there are two states on the Korean peninsula, and South Korea has been recognized by the USA and other countries. In case of the beginning of military activities by Northern initiative, Americans may interfere, by not only supplying the South with weapons and ammunition, but also by sending to its support Japanese troops.

2. Invasion of the South can be used by the USA for launching a wide hostile campaign against the USSR.

3. In the political sense the advance to the South can be supported by a majority of the population in both Korean states, but in a purely military sense the Korean People’s Army (KPA) does not have as yet overwhelming superiority over the Southern army

4. South Korea has already created a rather strong army and police”²⁸

Shtykov, however, supported Kim Il Sung’s proposal to create a liberated zone in Kangwondo province. He added:

“I find it militarily advisable to take over the strategically important Ongjin peninsula. However, the Southerners may have enough strength to counterattack, and then the fighting can take on a prolonged character”²⁹

²⁷ Memorandum of Conversation of Ambassador Shtykov with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young. August 14, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

²⁸ Shtykov’s report to Stalin, August 27, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia.

²⁹ Shtykov’s report to Stalin, August 27, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia.

For the first time Kim Il Sung officially asked for Stalin's permission to attack the South in their conversation on March 7 in the Kremlin. The memorandum of this conversation states the following:

"... Kim Il Sung: Comrade Stalin, we believe that the situation makes it necessary and possible to liberate the whole country through military means. The reactionary forces of the South will never agree on a peaceful reunification and will perpetrate division of the country until they feel themselves strong enough to attack the North.

Now is the best opportunity for us to take the initiative into our own hands. Our armed forces are stronger, and in addition we have the support of a powerful guerrilla movement in the South. The population of the South, which despises the pro-American regime, will certainly help us as well.

Stalin: You should not advance to the South. First of all, the Korean People's Army does not have an overwhelming superiority over the troops of the South. Numerically, as I understand, you are even behind them. Second, in the South there are still American troops, which will interfere in case of hostilities. Third, one should not forget that the agreement is in effect between the USSR and the United States on the 38th parallel. If the agreement is broken by our side, it is more of a reason to believe that Americans will interfere.

Kim Il Sung: Does it mean that there is no chance to reunify Korea in the near future? Our people are very anxious to be together again and to cast off the yoke of the reactionary regime and their American masters.

Stalin: If the adversary has aggressive intentions, then sooner or later it will start the aggression. In response to the attack you'll have a good opportunity to launch a counterattack. Then your move will be understood and supported by everyone"³⁰

The Soviet charge d'affaires in the North Korean capital Grigori I. Tunkin reported to Moscow on September 3, 1949:

³⁰ Conversation between Stalin and governmental delegation of the DPRK headed by the Chairman of Cabinet of Ministers of the DPRK Kim Il Sung March 7, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 3-4.

"On September 3 I was visited by the personal secretary of Kim Il Sung, Moon Il (a Soviet Korean). On the order of Kim Il Sung he said that they had received reliable data that Southerners intend to occupy, in the near future, a portion of Ongjin peninsula, situated to the north of the 38th parallel as well as to shell a cement plant in the city of Haeju.

In this connection, Moon Il said, Kim Il Sung asks permission to launch military operations against the South with the aim of taking over the Ongjin peninsula as well as a portion of territory of South Korea to the east of the Ongjin peninsula, approximately up to Kaesong in order to shorten the line of defense.

Kim Il Sung believes, Moon Il said, that if the international situation permits then they are ready to move farther in the Southern direction. Kim Il Sung is sure that they are capable of occupying South Korea in two weeks, at the maximum, it will take two months.

I asked him to tell Kim Il Sung that this issue is a big and serious one; it is necessary to think it over carefully and that I strongly recommend Kim Il Sung not be in a hurry and not make any decision on the issue as yet.

It is possible that Kim Il Sung will raise the same question in the following days"³¹.

Stalin paid attention to this request from Kim Il Sung and immediately ordered the Soviet Embassy in Pyongyang to gather relevant information on the situation in Korea. On September 12, 1949 a cable went to the Embassy from the Kremlin:

"You must meet Kim Il Sung as soon as possible and try to find out from him the answer to the following additional questions:

1. How do they appraise the South Korean army, its size, armaments and its combat capability?
2. The state of guerrilla movement in South Korea and what real assistance they hope to receive from guerrillas.
3. What will be the reaction of public opinion and people to the fact that the Northerners will start the offensive first? What real aid can be provided by the population of the South to the army of the North?

³¹ Tunkin's cable to the Kremlin, September 3, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia. P 1-3.

4. Are there American troops in South Korea? What measures, from Kim Il Sung's point of view, will Americans take in case of an offensive by the North?

5. How do Northerners appraise their capabilities including: state of the armed forces, their armaments and combat capabilities?

6. Give your view of the situation and how real and advisable our friends' proposition is"³².

Tunkin had detailed discussions with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young on September 12 and 13 and immediately informed Moscow on the essence of the talks:

"Concerning the essence of questions, raised in your cable, Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young had the following comments.

1 ... The officer corps of the South Korean army has a low level of training. The program of training in the army is systematically not fulfilled. In general Kim Il Sung considers the combat capability of the South Korean army as rather weak, judging from the local battles which have taken place on the 38th parallel.

The North Koreans have agents in all units of the Southern army, but what these people can do to destroy the army from within in case of a civil war is hard to say, Kim Il Sung stressed.

2. According to Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young, they have in South Korea about 1,500–2,000 persons in guerrilla units. Lately the guerrilla movement has become a bit stronger. Kim Il Sung thinks, however, that one should not count on much help from the guerrillas.

Park Hon-young, as a Southerner, expresses a different opinion — he believes that help from the guerrillas will be considerable. In any case, they hope that guerrillas will help through their activities at communication systems of the adversary. It is desirable that guerrillas occupy main ports of South Korea, but they are hardly capable of this in the initial stage of the military campaign...

3. Concerning reaction of public opinion and the people to the fact that the Northerners started the civil war, Kim Il Sung has doubts. During our conversation on September 12 he defi-

³² Stalin's cable to the Soviet charge d'affaires in Pyongyang, September 12, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1.

nitely said that if Northerners started the war, it would leave a negative impression on the people and politically it is not profitable to initiate the hostilities. Kim Il Sung mentioned the fact that Mao Zedong, talking to the North Korean representative Kim Il in the spring of this year, said the Northerners should not start the war now because, first of all, it is not profitable politically, second, Chinese friends are busy at home and they won't be able to extend to North Korea any serious assistance. The essence of Kim Il Sung's thought was that the North should wait until the end of major military operations in China.

In a conversation on September 13 Kim Il Sung, already under the influence of Hegai (Huh Gai) (a Soviet Korean, secretary of the CC of the Workers' Party, was present at the second meeting as an interpreter), stated that the people will welcome an armed intervention by the Northerners and if the North initiates the hostilities it won't lose politically. Later in the course of the conversation Kim Il Sung said that if the civil war drags on then the North will find itself in a politically uncomfortable situation. "And because we cannot hope for a quick victory, Kim Il Sung stressed, I don't propose to launch a civil war, I only propose to occupy the Ongjin peninsula and a portion of South Korean territory to the east of this peninsula, approximately up to Kaesong"

They believe that in case of a civil war, the population of South Korea will display sympathy to the Northern army, and when the army enters the South, the population will help it. In case of successful military actions, the Northerners hope to organize a number of uprisings in South Korea.

4 ... If the civil war breaks out in Korea, Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young feel Americans can send Japanese and Nationalist Chinese to help South Koreans; Americans themselves will extend cover from the sea and from the air by their own means, American instructors will participate directly in the organization of combat activities.

5 ... Kim Il Sung feels that the Northern army is superior to the Southern Army on a technical level (tanks, artillery, planes), discipline, skills of soldiers and officers as well as in moral-political respect.

In the Northern army there are a number of shortcomings' a shortage and weak training of aviators, a shortage of military vessels, a shortage of ammunition, unpreparedness of large-calibre guns for combat activities.

The proposal of Kim Il Sung is as follows' at first strike on South Korean army in the Ongjin peninsula, destroy two regiments located there, occupy the territory of the peninsula and territory to the east of it, approximately up to Kaesung, and then stop and look around. The South Korean army can get demoralized after the above-mentioned strike. In this case continue to move farther down South. If the South Korean army is not demoralized after the Ongjin operation, then get secured at the occupied frontiers, cutting by this the line of defense by $\frac{1}{3}$.

It is necessary to hurry up the Ongjin operation. It is advisable to wait until additional amounts of armaments arrive from the USSR. Meanwhile reinforce defense in other sections of the 38th parallel.

Kim Il Sung does not exclude turning the Ongjin operation into a civil war, but he hopes that it won't happen, because Southerners, according to his opinion, won't dare to advance in other sections of the 38th parallel"³³

In the end of his cable Tunkin gives his own appraisal of the situation, which differs drastically from the one presented by Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young:

"A local operation, proposed by Kim Il Sung, can and almost certainly will lead to a civil war between North and South. There are quite a few advocates of civil war in the ruling circles of both North and South Korea. That's why starting this local operation one must take into account that it might become the beginning of a civil war.

Is it sensible for the North to initiate a civil war now?

We believe that it is not sensible.

The Northern army is not strong enough to conduct successful and fast operations against the South. Even taking into account assistance which will be provided to the Northern army by guerillas and the population of South Korea one can not count on

³³ Tunkin's cable to the Kremlin, September 14, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-6.

quick success. Meanwhile an extended civil war is not favorable to the North both in the military and political sense.

First of all, extension of the war will give Americans an opportunity to provide adequate assistance to Syngman Rhee. After their defeat in China, Americans will probably interfere in Korean affairs more decisively than they did in China and, surely, will do their best to save Syngman Rhee.

It is also predictable that in case of a prolonged civil war, victims, suffering and difficulties connected with the war, may provoke negative feelings among the people towards initiators of the war.

Besides, an extended civil war in Korea can be used by Americans for agitation against the USSR and for further escalation of the war hysteria.

That's why it is not advisable for the Northerners to start a civil war now. Under present internal and external conditions a decision to advance to the South could only be correct if the Northerners might hope to finish the war quickly, but there are no preconditions for this.

But even if the above mentioned local operation was successful and did not lead to a civil war, still even in such a case the North, having won strategically, would have lost politically in many respects. This operation could be used for accusations against the North for their intention to launch a brother-slaughtering war. It could also be used as an excuse to escalate interference in Korean affairs by Americans and the international community in the interests of the South.

We believe that under such conditions it is not advisable to start the operation proposed by Kim Il Sung"³⁴

In addition to the above-cited cable, the Soviet Embassy in Pyongyang presented to Stalin personally a lengthy and detailed analysis of the political and economic situations in North and South Korea. Among other things the analysis stated the following:

"Political and Economic Situation in South Korea.

Since the liberation of Korea from the Japanese, the political situation in the South' is characterized by a sharp political struggle between leftist and rightist parties and organizations...

³⁴ Tunkin's cable to the Kremlin, September 14, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 7-8.

... Americans and South Korean reactionary forces, after being convinced that they cannot create in Korea an 'anti-democratic' government and seeing that the leftists enjoy a strong influence among the people, launched an active struggle against the Workers Party, which is the vanguard of all leftist parties and organizations... As a result of terror and persecution the leftists had to go underground... Consequently the Workers Party of the South by the end of 1948 got reduced from 900,000 members to 240,000 members... However, leftist organizations are still capable of implementing some actions. There are still 2,000 guerrilla fighters in the South, who organized during 1949 over 2,000 operations... the population assists the guerrillas by providing them with food and clothes, informing them about concentrations of the army units and police.

... Serious difficulties in the guerrilla movement are connected with the shortage of experience in the warfare cadres and a big shortage of armaments and ammunition. The CC of Workers Party has taken measures to overcome these shortages. Command cadres and instructors are being trained; measures have been taken to acquire Japanese and American weapons and ammunition... According to our friends, all conditions and prerequisites for further growth of the guerrilla movement exist, and they take appropriate measures to widen the guerrilla movement.

The political situation for the Southern government is very tense. The struggle it wages against the leftists as well against guerrillas is extremely unpopular among people and creates considerable discontent.

Syngman Rhee has not managed up to now to unite even the rightist camp around the government. In the rightist camp itself the struggle continues for power and influence of parties in the government.

... the Workers Party and its allies skillfully use disagreements in the rightist camp... and attract to their own side a number of centrist and rightist parties, unhappy with the policy of the government. Some of the representatives of these parties have moved to the North...

...People are convinced that the National Assembly and the government pass only those laws which are favorable to Americans and the government: tax laws, unequal treaties etc.

The economic situation in the South is equally difficult.

A majority of industrial plants don't function due to the lack of electrical energy and raw materials... Unemployment is constantly rising... Agriculture is being reduced with every passing year... As a result the government cannot cover the requirements of the population for foodstuffs... This difficult economic situation of the workers and peasants creates among them pessimism and dissatisfaction with the government...

The Americans, understanding the weakness and low prestige of the South Korean government among wide circles of the population, take some measures to bolster the government... It can be seen that Americans are interested in Korea not only economically, but also as a strategic springboard to the continent...

The condition of the South Korean army.

... The total number of the army is 85,000 personnel... Combat and tactical training is not sufficient... In a moral-political sense units adjacent to the 38th parallel are strong; during skirmishes along the parallel only a few surrendered voluntarily... However, our agents are quite successful in decaying the South Korean army from inside. A group of officers and soldiers was recruited and in May 1949 two battalions were transferred to the North...

The political and economic situation in the North.

The political situation in the North is characterized by a continuous growth of the prestige of the authorities and political enthusiasm of peoples' masses in the struggle for restoration and development of economy and national culture. Organs of political power and the government enjoy the support and love of the whole nation.

All reforms, conducted by the government in the political and economic spheres, are very successful...

The economic situation has been improving from year to year. The 1948 quotas for development of all branches of the economy have been fulfilled... Big successes have been achieved in the raising of national culture and the arts.

However, there are a number of difficulties in North Korea, which the Popular-Democratic government has to overcome... Resistance of hostile elements... still takes place... Among those unhappy with the existing political system are first of all former

landlords,... persons, who have received education in Japan (they are, as a rule, representatives of the bourgeois-landlord circles)...

... During 1949, compared with 1948, there has been growth of political criminal acts... It is explained, on one side, by withdrawal of Soviet troops from Korea: reactionary forces have become bolder. On the other side, it is explained by the intensification of penetration by South Korean spies, terrorists and subversive elements.

... Activities of hostile elements don't present a big threat to the existing political system, but the government and leadership of the Workers Party of Korea are taking necessary measures to fight against all groups of political criminals.

The reasons inducing Northerners to raise the question of advancing on the South.

Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young believe that the question of the unification of the country through peaceful means is impossible under the present situation. Americans and South Korean reactionary forces won't agree to unite the country peacefully. Attempts to solve the Korean issue during the work of the Joint Soviet-American Committee and then at the General Assembly of the UN have not been successful. Creation of the Patriotic Front from the representatives of the South and North Korea (leftist, centrist and a portion of rightist parties of South Korea) also does not guarantee unification of the country through peaceful means. The call of the Patriotic Front to unify the country peacefully has been rejected by South Korean reactionary forces. Consequently, they are confronted with the question of what to do about unification of the country

The Northerners presume that an overwhelming majority is for unification of the country, for liquidation of the 38th parallel.

When the American troops were deployed in the South, the explanation was given to the people that unification was prevented by the American presence in the South. At the present time there are no American troops in Korea. Consequently this obstacle to unification is eliminated. People, naturally, ask what, after all, obstructs unification of the country? In the South reactionary forces are conducting agitation against the democratic government and against communists, accusing that they are the obstacle in the way of unification of the country

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young, it seems, take into account the situation and they don't want to be responsible for a delay in the unification of the country. Not seeing any possibility to unify the country through peaceful means, they've come to think of unification of the country through armed struggle against the South Korean government. They believe that in this endeavour they'll be supported by people both in the North and in the South of the country. They, perhaps, take into account the fact that if unification is not achieved now at least by military means, then the question of unification will drag on for years. South Korean reactionary forces will manage to strangle the democratic movement in the South and defeat and destroy the leftist organizations. Simultaneously South Korean reactionary forces will use this time for the creation of a stronger army and will be able to attack the North in order to destroy everything that has been built in the North during all these years.

In conversations Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young refuse to allow the thought that Korea should remain divided for an uncertain time.

I don't exclude that Kim Il Sung, wishing to launch an offensive against the South, hopes to receive assistance both from the USSR and the Chinese Communist Party. He, perhaps, thinks that because Koreans participated in the fighting against Guomindang troops, consequently they, Koreans, must be helped by the Chinese.

My conclusions and my proposals.

As I underlined in my notes, I still believe that the internal political situation both in the South and the North of the country favors our friends. Prestige of the leftist democratic forces, struggling for unity and independence of the country, is strong among the people and their activities are supported by wide circles of Korean people.

However, it is necessary to consider the complicated international situation, when the beginning of the offensive of People's Army will be used by reactionary imperialist states against the USSR. I don't exclude that Americans will interfere in this conflict and they'll be actively supporting Southerners. I also feel that the size of the People's Army and its material level - at the present

time - don't guarantee the full defeat of the Southern army and occupation of South Korea.

I believe it is possible and advisable that our friends develop and extend full support and leadership of the guerrilla movement in South Korea.

A local operation to take over the Ongjin peninsula and the area with the city Kaesong can be conducted under favorable conditions. For this purpose one can use provocations of the Southerners at the 38th parallel. In order to punish them for violating the 38th parallel, the Ongjin peninsula and the area with Kaesong city can be taken over and the front line will be shortened"³⁵

On September 24, 1949, the Politburo of the Central Committee of the All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik) passed a decision on the Korea issue, barring a Northern attack on the South: "An order to the USSR Ambassador in Korea.

Comrade Shtykov is ordered to meet with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young, and strictly adhering to the following text, to say:

In connection with the questions raised by you, I am authorized to express to you the opinion of Moscow on the issue. Your proposal to launch an offensive of the Korean People's Army to the South makes it necessary to give a precise appraisal of the military as well political facets of this issue.

From the military point of view one cannot say that the People's Army is prepared for such an offensive. An offensive, which is not prepared adequately, can turn into a prolonged military operation. It not only will not lead to a defeat of the adversary, but it will create considerable political and economic difficulties for North Korea, something which cannot, of course, be allowed. Due to the fact that at the present time North Korea does not have the necessary advantage in armed forces over South Korea, we cannot but admit that a military offensive against the South is now absolutely premature and therefore it is not admissible from the military point of view.

³⁵ Embassy's analysis of the political and economic situation in South and North Korea, September 15, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-21.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

From the political point view the military offensive on the South has not been prepared by you as well. We, of course, agree with you, that people are waiting for unification of the country, and in the South people, in addition, are waiting for liberation from the exploitation of the reactionary regime. However, up to now very little has been done in order to raise wide masses of people in South Korea to an active struggle, to develop the guerrilla movement throughout South Korea, to establish liberated areas there and to organize forces for the national uprising.

Meanwhile, only under conditions of an operative and really expanding popular uprising, undermining the foundations of the reactionary regime, a military advance to the South could play a decisive role in the toppling of South Korean reactionaries and guarantee implementation of the task of the unification of Korea into a unified democratic state. Because at this time very little has been done to expand the guerrilla movement and prepare for national uprising in South Korea, we cannot but admit that from the political point of view the offensive that you propose, is not well prepared.

As for a local operation of taking over the Ongjin peninsula and the area of Kaesong, as a result of which borders of North Korea will be moved almost up to Seoul, this operation cannot be regarded in any other way, but as the beginning of a war between North and South Korea. And North Korea, as it was said above, is not prepared for this war either politically or militarily

Besides, it is necessary to take into consideration that if military actions start on the initiative of the North and take on an extended character it may give Americans a pretext for all kinds of interference into Korean affairs.

In the light of that, it should be admitted that unification of Korea demands concentration of maximum forces for, first of all, expansion of the guerrilla movement, creation of liberated areas and preparation for national armed uprising in South Korea with the purpose of toppling the reactionary regime and for a successful solution to the task of unification of all Korea, and, secondly, further and decisive strengthening of the People's Army of Korea"³⁶

³⁶ Decision of the Politburo of the CC of the All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik). No. P71/191, Question N 191, September 24, 1949.

It is interesting to note that in the various drafts of the Politburo's decision on Korea (September 24, 1949, No. P 71/191), prepared by Foreign Minister Andrei Gromyko and Defense Minister Nikolai A. Bulganin, there were additional arguments against invasion by the North of South Korea.

The pre-final draft, dated September 23, among other things, said:

"Such an offensive on the initiative of the DPRK can be used by the reactionary circles for denunciation of the Northern government in the eyes of public opinion for aggressive intentions and desire to drag the country into a civil war.

From the military point of view, to hope for a success is hardly realistic. First of all, the people of South Korea are not sufficiently prepared to accept and support such an offensive. It is not known how widely Southern Korean people will rise in support of the People's Army. It is also necessary to understand that the guerrilla movement in the South is not sufficiently developed and consequently one can hardly count on significant aid from the guerrillas.

Second, it has to be taken into account that Southerners have a bigger ground army. Besides, they have navy forces. Though the South Korean army is badly prepared militarily, however, remembering its social composition, it can be said that it will strongly resist the People's Army. Third, though the People's Army is better equipped and trained with tanks and planes, and though it has a high political and moral spirit, it is smaller numerically and it does not have the naval forces. Consequently it cannot fulfil such a big task alone, as we see it. One should also consider the fact that the People's Army has not finished as yet organizational restructuring: the mechanized brigade is not yet provided with equipment, formation of the aviation division is not yet completed, and there are absolutely not enough pilots.

Fourth, advance of the People's Army to the South can give Americans a pretext to raise this issue at the UN session, to blame the government of the DPRK for aggression and get the consent of the General Assembly for the introduction into South Korea of American troops. As to the introduction of American troops into the territory of South Korea, it can bring about a

The War in Korea 1950—1953

long-term occupation of the Southern part of the country and consequently postpone the unification.

On the second question of a local operation aimed at taking the Ongjin peninsula, it will definitely bring about the same consequences as the overall advancement...

... The guerrilla movement should be helped and promoted. Such a movement can weaken the existing regime in the South and may induce the South Korean government to agree on a discussion of proposals about peaceful unification of the country or may even create conditions for toppling the South Korean government.

The attention of Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young must be attracted to the fact that they are far from having used all possibilities for peaceful unification of the country. An important and politically convenient document for them, the "Call of the Fatherland Front to unite the country peacefully" has not been used by them fully for raising a wide movement of people on the Korean issue for this purpose"³⁷

In the draft, signed by Gromyko and Bulganin on September 21, 1949, we find other interesting ideas later dropped by the Politburo:

"In the military sphere you have absolutely no superiority over the South. Moreover, the size of the Southern army is bigger, and in equipment your advantage is not significant. Meanwhile, war experience, especially of offensive operations, show that the offensive side, at least in the initial stage of the war, must have double or even triple superiority in troops and equipment. Only in such a case can one hope for a successful offensive and a quick victory.

... Up to now you have paid very little attention to cause the people of the South to rise up against the Southern regime. And very little has been done in this respect.

... Americans will certainly move their troops into South Korea, and you not only cannot stop this, you cannot even defeat the South Korean army.

³⁷ Archives of the President of Russia, P. 11-13.

... The task of the People's Army now is to build up its numbers, provision of additional quantities of military hardware and raise its military skills.

... To be sure, you must always be ready, in case the South starts an offensive against the North, to defeat the Southern army and unite the country under the leadership of your government"³⁸

When this draft got to Stalin, in his own writing he changed the last paragraph. Stalin wrote:

"In case the South starts an offensive against the North; you must be ready and then act according to the situation"³⁹

Obviously Stalin did not want to give Pyongyang the illusion that it could defeat the South and did not want to give Kim Il Sung a pretext to start the war anyway (as a counterattack).

On October 4, 1949 Soviet Ambassador Shtykov executed the Kremlin's orders, explaining the USSR's position on "the liberation" of South Korea to Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young. On the same day Shtykov informed Stalin about their reaction to the Soviet instructions:

"Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young took the information coolly Kim Il Sung simply said: "O.K." Park Hon-young,... a little bit more precise, mentioned that the logic of Moscow was correct. Koreans had to expand the guerrilla movement in the South.

Further on Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young told me about development of the guerrilla movement in the South. They said that the guerrilla movement was developing there. They sent about 300 persons to lead the guerrilla movement"⁴⁰.

However, the North Korean leadership did not abandon its urge to move to the South. The issue was raised again by them on January 17, 1950, during a dinner hosted by the DPRK's Foreign Minister Park Hon-young. Among those who participated in the dinner, were Kim Il Sung, Kim Du-bong, and some other North Korean officials, as well as the Ambassador and Trade Representative of China.

³⁸ Archives of the President of Russia, P 14-16.

³⁹ Archives of the President of Russia, P 10.

⁴⁰ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, October 4, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

The Soviet Ambassador reported to Stalin concerning this dinner:

"After the meal Kim Il Sung approached Counsellors of the Soviet Embassy Aleksandr M. Ignatiev and Pelishenko and in an excited tone started to say that now when China is finishing its liberation the next order of things is liberation of the Korean people in the South of the country. With this he pointed out:

"People in South Korea trust me to solve the problem. The people of the South know that we possess a good army. Lately I've been feeling very frustrated; I don't sleep at night. I am thinking all the time how to solve the problem of unification of the whole country. If the cause of the liberation of the people of the Southern part of Korea and the unification of the country is postponed, then I can lose the confidence of the Korean people."

After this Kim Il Sung said that when he had been in Moscow, comrade Stalin told him that one should not advance to the South, but if the army of Syngman Rhee advances to the North then one may launch a counterattack on the South. But due to the fact that Syngman Rhee up to now does not start the offensive and consequently the liberation of the Southern part of the country and unification are being delayed, he (Kim Il Sung) believes that he must visit Stalin again and receive his orders and his permission for offensive activities of the People's Army with the purpose of the liberation of the people of South Korea. Further, Kim Il Sung stressed that he himself could not launch an offensive because he is a communist, a disciplined person and orders given by comrade Stalin are law for him.

He also said that if it is impossible to meet comrade Stalin, then he'll try to meet with Mao Zedong, after his return from Moscow. Kim Il Sung underlined that Mao Zedong had promised him to give assistance after ending the war in China...

... Counsellors of the Embassy Ignatiev and Pelishenko evaded the discussion of the topic and switched the subject of conversation. Due to this, Kim Il Sung approached me... and started the following conversation: Can he meet comrade Stalin and discuss situation in the South and the question of offensive actions against the army of Syngman Rhee? Kim Il Sung stressed that their People's Army is now considerably stronger than the army of Syngman Rhee. He added that if it is impossible to meet Stalin, then he'd

like to meet with Mao Zedong, because after visiting Moscow the Chinese leader will have instructions on all issues.

Then Kim Il Sung asked me why I don't allow him to attack the Ongjin peninsula. The People's Army could take it in three days, and in case of a general advance the People's Army could be in Seoul in a few days.

I responded to Kim Il Sung that he had not raised the question of meeting comrade Stalin and if he raises this question then comrade Stalin perhaps will receive him. Concerning the Ongjin peninsula, I explained that it should not be done. Then I cut off the conversation and went home.

... During the whole conversation Kim Il Sung kept repeating that he wanted to have the advice of comrade Stalin concerning the situation in South Korea, because he (Kim Il Sung) thinks all the time about the offensive"⁴¹

By the end of 1949 the North Korean leader received a new, powerful argument to bolster his demands — the full victory of communists in China. If the Chinese Communists "liberated" their country (with the exception of Taiwan), why was Pyongyang not allowed to do the same? Especially now that Beijing could help the North Korean "comrades", as Mao Zedong had repeatedly promised.

In January 1950 Kim Il Sung resumed pressure on the Kremlin, demanding "the green light" for his adventures against the South. Finally, on January 30, 1950 Stalin sends the long-awaited instruction to his Ambassador in Pyongyang to tell Kim Il Sung the followings:

"... I understand the unhappiness of comrade Kim Il Sung, but he must understand that such a big step regarding South Korea, which he intends to undertake, requires thorough preparation. It has to be organized in such a way that there won't be a large risk. If he wants to talk to me on this issue, then I 'll always be ready to receive him and talk to him. Tell this to Kim Il Sung and stress that I am ready to help him in this matter"⁴²

⁴¹ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, January 19, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-5.

⁴² Stalin's cable to Ambassador Shtykov, January 30, 1950. Archives of President of Russia.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On the same day, January 30, 1950, Ambassador Shtykov met with Kim Il Sung. In his report to Stalin about this meeting the Ambassador said:

"... In accordance with your instructions I had a meeting with comrade Kim Il Sung. Referring to the conversation, which had taken place during the dinner, organized by Park Hon-young on January 17, 1950, I passed on with all due precision the contents of your instructions.

Kim Il Sung received my information with great satisfaction. The strongest impression was made on him by your consent to receive him and your readiness to extend aid to him in this matter. Kim Il Sung, obviously trying to get assured once more, inquired if it means that it is possible to meet comrade Stalin on this issue. I responded that from this information it could be derived that comrade Stalin was ready to receive you. Further on Kim Il Sung stated that he would be getting ready for the meeting."⁴³

On February 2, 1950 Stalin sent another set of instructions to Ambassador Shtykov, stressing:

"... Explain to comrade Kim Il Sung that at this point the question he wants to discuss with me must be completely confidential. It should not be shared with anyone even in the North Korean leadership, as well as with the Chinese comrades. This is dictated by the preoccupation with keeping the topic unknown to the adversary... During our talks with Mao Zedong, who is still in Moscow, we discussed the necessity and possibilities to help North Korea to raise its military potential and defense capabilities."⁴⁴

On February 4, 1950 Kim Il Sung himself requested a meeting with Soviet Ambassador Shtykov. According to Shtykov, among other issues, Kim Il Sung raised the following:

"Kim Il Sung asked for my advice about forming three additional ground divisions in order to raise the size of the total armed forces to ten divisions. I answered that this was a big and

⁴³ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, January 31, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁴⁴ Stalin's cable to Shtykov, February 2, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

serious question. Before decision is taken you have to think if you have the necessary material resources. I also need time to think this issue over before I can advise you on this matter.

Kim Il. Sung asked me if he could address comrade Stalin with the request to utilize the credit in 1950, extended by the Soviet government until 1951. Using this credit they would like to buy Soviet weapons for the prospective formation of three ground divisions. I said that I'll inform my government on this issue"⁴⁵

On February 9 Stalin cabled his response to Kim Il Sung's requests of February 4. Stalin's cable instructed the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang to do the following:

"Visit Kim Il Sung and orally tell him that he can go ahead and start forming three additional ground divisions. They should be elitist: staffed with experienced officers, well-trained soldiers and modern armament.

In this connection confirm to Kim Il Sung that we agree to utilize our credit of 1951, during 1950 for the supply of armament for the three ground divisions to be formed"⁴⁶

On the next day Ambassador Shtykov reported to Staling

"Today, February 10, I visited Kim Il Sung and in accordance with your instructions orally passed him answers to his questions of February 4, 1950. Kim Il Sung took my information enthusiastically and a number of times asked me to extend his gratitude to comrade Stalin for the aid"⁴⁷

On March 21, 1950 Ambassador Shtykov reported to Staling "In accordance with your instructions I met Kim Il Sung on March 20. Park Hon-young was also present at the meeting. During this meeting I passed to Kim Il Sung the text of the cable of comrade Stalin.

At the same meeting Kim Il Sung asked me to forward to comrade Stalin his request that he, together with Park Hon-young, would like to meet comrade Stalin in early April.

⁴⁵ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, February 4, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁴⁶ Stalin's cable to Ambassador Shtykov, February 9, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁴⁷ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, February 10, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

The trip to Moscow and the meeting with comrade Stalin they want to have unofficially, in the same fashion as in 1946.

Then Kim Il Sung said that they are finishing preparation of the materials for the trip and intend to raise at the meeting with comrade Stalin the following questions:

1. Ways and methods of unification of the South and North of the country.

2. Economic development of the country.

3. Possibly some party work issues"⁴⁸

On March 23, 1950 Shtykov informed Moscow of a more detailed list of questions, that Kim Il Sung requested to discuss during his meeting with Stalin:

- "1. Ways and methods of unification of the country (South and North). The intention is to conduct unification by the military method.

2. Economic questions.

- a) Prospects of development of national economy of Korea.

What plan and of what duration to draft? 2—3—5 years? How to take South Korea into consideration?

- b) Electrification of railroads of Korea.

- c) Further imports from the USSR of equipment for industry, cars.

- d) Perspectives of the development of agriculture of Korea.

- e) Regarding Soviet specialists (additional requests)...

3. Chino-Korean relations.

- a) About meeting with Mao Zedong.

- b) Concerning a treaty with China.

- c) Koreans living in China and Chinese living in Korea.

4. Concerning the Cominform of the Communist and Workers parties of Asia"⁴⁹

On March 24, 1950 Ambassador Shtykov informed Moscow of the following:

"Today I visited Kim Il Sung and informed him that comrade Stalin was ready to receive him and Park Hon-young.

⁴⁸ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, March 21, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

⁴⁹ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, March 23, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

Kim Il Sung plans to depart from Korea to Moscow on March 30 this year. I consider it advisable to organize travel for Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young to Moscow by special plane. For this purpose I request appropriate instructions about provision of the plane. This plane has to arrive in Pyongyang on March 29. If the plane is not available, departure can be organized by a navy ship from Chongjin to Vladivostok. Then they may proceed by train in a special car from Vladivostok to Moscow.

Kim Il Sung intends to take Moon Il with him to Moscow as an interpreter. Moon was his interpreter during the last negotiations in Moscow. Also he plans to take his personal aide So Jin-diu, who accompanied him on the last trip to Moscow"⁵⁰

Kim Il Sung and his party spent nearly all of April, 1950 in the USSR (from the 30th of March to the 25th). During his stay Kim Il Sung met Stalin three times. The following is a summary of their conversations:

"Comrade Stalin confirmed to Kim Il Sung that the international environment has sufficiently changed to permit a more active stance on the unification of Korea.

Internationally, the Chinese Communist Party victory over the Guomindang has improved the environment for actions in Korea. China is no longer busy with internal fighting and can devote its attention and energy to the assistance of Korea. If necessary, China has at its disposal troops which can be utilized in Korea without any harm to the other needs of China. The Chinese victory is also important psychologically. It has proved the strength of Asian revolutionaries, and shown the weakness of Asian reactionaries and their mentors in the West, in America. Americans left China and did not dare to challenge the new Chinese authorities militarily.

Now that China has signed a treaty of alliance with the USSR, Americans will be even more hesitant to challenge the Communists in Asia. According to information coming from the United States, it is really so. The prevailing mood is not to interfere. Such a mood is reinforced by the fact that the USSR now has the atomic bomb and that our positions are solidified in Pyongyang.

⁵⁰ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, March 24, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

• However, we have to weigh once again all the “pros” and “cons” of the liberation. First of all, will Americans interfere or not? Second, the liberation can be started only if the Chinese leadership endorses it.

Kim Il Sung expressed his opinion that Americans won't interfere. Now that they know that the USSR and China are behind Korea and are able to help it, Americans will not risk a big war. As for comrade Mao Zedong, he always supported our desire to liberate the whole country. Comrade Mao Zedong said on a number of occasions that after the Chinese revolution is completed, China will help us, if necessary, will provide troops. However, we want to rely on our own forces in the unification of Korea. We believe that we can do it.

Comrade Stalin emphasized that a thorough preparation for war was a must. First of all, armed forces have to be elevated to an upper level of preparedness. You have to form elite attack divisions as well as create additional units. Divisions have to have more weapons, more mechanized means of movement and combat. Your request in this respect will be fully satisfied. Then a detailed plan of the offensive must be drawn. Basically it has to have three stages. 1. Troops are concentrated in the designated areas, close to the 38th parallel. 2. The highest bodies of power in North Korea make fresh proposals for peaceful unification. They'll be certainly rejected by the other side. Then, after they are rejected, a counterattack must take place. I agree with your idea to engage the adversary in the Ongjin peninsula as it will help to disguise who initiated the combat activities. After you attack and the South counterattacks it would give you a chance to enlarge the front. The war should be quick and speedy. Southerners and Americans should not have time to come to their senses. They won't have time to put up a strong resistance and to mobilize international support.

Comrade Stalin added that Koreans should not count on direct Soviet participation in the war because the USSR had serious challenges elsewhere to cope with, especially in the West. He again urged Kim Il Sung to consult with Mao Zedong and mentioned that the Chinese leader had a good understanding of oriental matters. Stalin repeated that the USSR was not ready to

get involved in Korean affairs directly, especially if Americans did venture to send troops to Korea.

Kim Il Sung gave a more detailed analysis of why Americans would not interfere. The attack will be swift and the war will be won in three days; guerrilla movement in the South has grown stronger and a major uprising can be expected. Americans won't have time to prepare and by the time they come to their senses, all of the Korean people will be enthusiastically supporting the new government.

Park Hon-young elaborated on the thesis of a strong guerrilla movement in South Korea. He predicted that 200,000 party members will participate as leaders of the mass uprising.

It was agreed that the North Korean army would be fully mobilized by the summer of 1950 and by that time the [North] Korean General Staff with assistance of Soviet advisers, will draw the concrete plan for the offensive"⁵¹

China was actively involved in the process of working out the Communist strategies in Korea in the late 1940s. Basically Mao Zedong supported Kim's desire "to liberate" the South and even promised to help with troops if necessary. However, Mao insisted that Kim wait until the Chinese finished their revolutionary war. Mao consulted with Stalin on the policies in Korea, and was a bit offended when a decision to start the war was taken in Moscow by Stalin and Kim without prior consultation with Beijing. Nevertheless, Mao went along, and again promised the required support.

On May 14, 1949 Kim Il Sung described to Soviet Ambassador Shtykov negotiations in China of Kim Il, a member of the CC, Chief of Politburo of the KPA. Kim Il Sung explained:

"Kim Il was sent to China to establish contacts with the CC of the Chinese Communist Party and to talk about Korean divisions in the Chinese army (staffed with Koreans from Manchuria).

Kim Il... met on April 30 in Mukden with Gao Gang, who connected Kim Il with the CC of the Chinese Communist Party

⁵¹ Report on Kim Il Sung's visit to the USSR, March 30-April 25, 1950. Prepared by the International Department of the CC of the All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik), Archives of the President of Russia.

... Kim Il gave Mao Zedong a letter with a request, if necessary, to transfer Korean divisions to Korea.

Mao Zedong answered that out of 3 divisions two are stationed in Mukden and Changchun, and one is participating in offensive actions. The first two divisions can be given to the Korean government at any time. The third one may be returned from south China only after ending the battles [against the remnants of Chiang Kai-shek's forces], but not earlier than in a month. Mao Zedong warned that the divisions... are not regular, and are weak from a military point of view. He recommended Koreans train officers for these divisions.

Kim Il, referring to the fact that the Korean divisions are equipped with Japanese weapons, asked if the Chinese would help them with ammunition. Mao Zedong confirmed that such ammunition was made in China and could be provided to Korea in any quantity.

... Talking about the situation in Korea, Mao Zedong said that military actions could begin any time there. Kim Il Sung must take it into account and get carefully prepared. The war can be very quick, lightning or prolonged. For you, Mao Zedong said, a prolonged war is not good, because in such a case the Japanese can get into the action and extend aid to the South Korean "government." You should not be worried: the Soviet Union is nearby I we are in Manchuria. If necessary, we can throw in Chinese soldiers for you; all of us are "black," Americans won't tell the difference, Mao Zedong added.

Mao Zedong also said that Kim Il Sung should not advance to the South in the near future. The reasons for this are: the unfavorable world situation; Chinese communists are busy fighting Chiang Kai-shek and cannot extend solid assistance to Pyongyang. Mao recommended a postponement of decisive actions until the Guomindong is defeated, and China is united under the power of the CCP

Mao wanted to know details of Kim Il Sung's visit to Moscow. He also told Kim Il that the CC of CCP received a letter from other communist parties, including Burma, Malaya and Indochina, proposing to establish an "Informburo of Communist parties" of Oriental countries. Mao Zedong said that from his point of view the establishment of an Informburo is premature. There

are wars in China and Indochina; in Korea the situation is tense - and the creation of an Informburo can be perceived as a military union. Mao Zedong expressed a desire to establish closer ties with the CC of Workers Party of Korea...

... Kim Il Sung said that Kim Il got a very warm and friendly reception in China"⁵²

On May 17, 1949 Mao Zedong briefed the Soviet representative on the visit of Kim Il to China. Among other things Mao said:

"As for giving assistance to North Korea with officers and armament, Mao Zedong said, such assistance will be given. In Manchuria they have 1.5 million Koreans from which two Korean divisions (10,000 persons each) have been formed. One of them has combat experience. It took an active part in the fighting against the Guomindang troops in Manchuria. These divisions can be transferred to North Korea at the first demand. Meanwhile, as long as Korean comrades don't need the divisions we'll be training them and providing them with everything. Besides we've trained 200 officers, who can be sent to Korea in a month. If a war breaks out between North and South Korea, we are ready to give everything we can, especially foodstuffs and armament for the mentioned divisions.

Korean comrades believe that American troops will in the near future be evacuated from South Korea, but they are afraid that American troops will be replaced with the Japanese. With the Japanese help. Southerners can launch an offensive against North Korea.

We advised them to counterattack these troops, but always take into account the presence or absence of Japanese troops in the South Korean army. If Japanese units participate, then it is necessary to be on guard and in case of superiority of the adversary and in the interest of preservation of own troops it is better to sacrifice a portion of our territory. It will allow us, under more favorable conditions, to encircle the invaders and defeat them. We advised them to prepare ideologically the party, troops and people that such a situation is possible and will not signify defeat of democratic Korea, but will be simply a strategic maneuver.

⁵² Shtykov's cable to Stalin May 15, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

If Americans leave and Japanese do not come, in this situation we did not advise Korean comrades to start an offensive towards South Korea, but rather wait for a more suitable situation, because during this advance MacArthur may quickly shift Japanese units and armaments to Korea. As for us, we will not be able to extend a substantive support quickly because all our major forces went beyond Yangtse River.

We believe that such a step-advance of North Korea to the South can be undertaken, if the international situation permits it, in the beginning of 1950. Then in case Japanese troops move into Korea, we'll be able to send our elite troops and defeat them.

To be sure, Mao Zedong added, all our steps in this direction will be undertaken only after consultations with Moscow"⁵³

On January 1, 1950 Stalin sent a request to the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang:

"Lin Biao has sent a cable to Mao Zedong, informing him that there are 16,000 Koreans in the People's Liberation Army. Among those, there are purely Korean formations, which include 4 battalions, 27 companies and 9 platoons. In the service of the PLA there are Korean commanding officers, among them two are at division level, five are at the regiment level, 87 at battalion level, 598 company commanders, 1400 platoon commanders and 1900 junior officers.

After movement of the PLA to southern China there appeared disturbances among Koreans, some of them asked to be returned to their Motherland.

In connection with the approaching end of the war, Lin Biao expresses a desire to unite all Koreans into one division or 4-5 regiments and send them to Korea.

Visit Kim Il Sung and find out his attitude towards the intention of Lin Biao"⁵⁴

On January 1, 1950 Kim Il Sung on his own initiative raised the issue. The Soviet Ambassador said in his cable to Moscow:

⁵³ Cable of the Soviet representative in China, Kovalev, to Stalin, May 18, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-3.

⁵⁴ Stalin's cable to the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang, January 1, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 109.

"Kim Il Sung informed me that he received through the Chinese trade representative a letter from the Chinese government, which says that because of the end of military actions Korean units inside the Chinese army are being freed. If the Korean government so desires, they can be transferred to Korea... Kim Il Sung expressed a desire to accept these units. His intentions are:

1) Form from these units one ground division..., two ground regiments and use soldiers to staff a motorcycle regiment and a mechanized brigade.

2) Kim Il Sung intends to ask the Chinese government to leave the division and two regiments until April 1950 in China because of the difficulties to deploy them in Korea"⁵⁵

When Kim Il Sung was in Moscow in April, 1950, the charge d'affaires of the USSR in the DPRK, Ignatiev, sent the following cable to the Kremlin:

"Deputy Chairman of the Cabinet of Ministers of the DPRK informed me of the following:

1) At the end of March, Korean Ambassador in China, Li Ju-yun met Mao Zedong. On the initiative of the Ambassador they discussed the question of a meeting between Kim Il Sung and Mao Zedong.

Mao Zedong accepted the idea and suggested holding such a meeting at the end of April or beginning of May of the current year.

Mao Zedong connected this meeting with the unification of Korea. He pointed out that if there was a concrete plan of unification of Korea, then the meeting should be confidential. If there was no such plan as yet, then the meeting can be official.

The Ambassador did not give any concrete answer as to the timing and contents of the proposed meeting, referring to the fact that Kim Il Sung was undergoing medical treatment at the present time (in reality, as we already mentioned above, Kim Il Sung was in Moscow).

Further, Mao Zedong dwelt on the possibility of a third world war, stressing that if it started Korea could not help but partici-

⁵⁵ Shtykov's cable to Moscow, January 11, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

pate in it. That's why, Mao said, the DPRK must train its armed forces.

In the conversation with Li Ju-yun, Mao Zedong expressed his desire to intensify trade between the P.R.C. and DPRK⁵⁶

On May 3, 1950 Stalin authorized the Soviet Ambassador to tell Mao Zedong the followings:

"... Korean comrades visited us recently I'll inform you shortly about the results of the conversations"⁵⁷

On May 14, 1950 Stalin sent this information to Mao Zedong: "Comrade Mao Zedong!

In the conversation with Korean comrades Philippov [Stalin's pseudonym] and his friends expressed an opinion that due to the changed international situation they agree with the proposals of Koreans to commence unification. With this it was agreed that the final decision on the issue must be made jointly by Chinese and Korean comrades. In case Chinese comrades disagree, the decision must be postponed until new discussion. Korean comrades can inform you about details of the conversation"⁵⁸

On May 12, 1950 Ambassador Shtykov informed Moscow:

"At the request of Kim Il Sung, on May 12, 1950 I met him and Park Hon-young. Kim Il Sung told me that upon his return from Moscow he received a letter from the North Korean Ambassador in China Li Ju-yun. In this letter he briefed him on the meeting with Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai.

During that meeting the necessity of a meeting between Kim Il Sung and Mao Zedong was discussed. Zhou Enlai suggested making this meeting official. Mao Zedong, posing a question as to when the North intended to start unification, without waiting for an answer stressed that if you intend to start the military actions right away then we should not meet officially. The visit then should be unofficial.

⁵⁶ Ignatiev's cable to Moscow, April 10, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁵⁷ Coded message N 2220, the 8th section of the 2nd Chief Directorate, General Staff of the USSR Armed Forces, May 3, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 112.

⁵⁸ The Coded message N 5500, Foreign Ministry of the USSR, May 14, 1950. Archives of the Foreign Ministry of the USSR, P 113.

Mao Zedong added that peaceful unification is impossible, it is necessary to unify Korea with the military means. As for the Americans, one should not be scared of them. Because of such a small territory Americans won't start a Third World War.

Then Kim Il Sung told me that Ambassador Li Ju-yun had not been authorized by the CC to discuss with Mao Zedong a possible meeting between Mao and Kim Il Sung. Because of this the Ambassador was summoned to Pyongyang, where he was reprimanded and received instructions.

On May 10 the Ambassador returned to Beijing and soon met Mao Zedong. Mao agreed to receive Kim Il Sung. Kim Il Sung will fly together with Park Hon-young to Beijing on May 13 in the morning.

He asked me if the plane, especially sent for this purpose, would be ready by that time. I responded that the plane was ready.

Kim Il Sung said that the question of the meeting with Mao Zedong had not been discussed in the Central Committee. He discussed the issue with Kim Chaek (member of the Political Council) only.

Kim Il Sung pointed out that he planned to discuss with Mao Zedong the following questions:

1. To inform him about his intention to unify the country with military means and about results of conversations on the subject in Moscow.

2. To exchange views on the conclusion of the trade agreement between Korea and China. He intends to offer a conclusion of the trade agreement in the near future, and a treaty on friendship to be signed after unification of the country.

3. Inform Mao Zedong about some issues which were discussed in Moscow with comrade Stalin and about establishment of closer ties between the Central Committees of the Workers Party of Korea and the Chinese Communist party

4. Exchange views on some bilateral issues, for example, the electric station at Suiho, Koreans living in China, etc.

Then Kim Il Sung asked my advice on what help he should request from Mao with regard to the planned operation. I declined to answer this question, underlining that he himself knew what he needed best. Kim Il Sung said that originally he had

intended to request ammunition for Japanese and American arms, that the divisions from China have. He also wanted to request some horses. However, after talking to the Chief of the General Staff he decided not to request those things. The army has three sets of ammunition.

In fact, Kim Il Sung stressed, he did not have any requests for Mao Zedong about aid, because all of his requests had been satisfied in Moscow⁵⁹.

The Soviet Ambassador in China, N. V. Roshin, passed the following information to Stalin on May 13, 1950:

“Zhou Enlai on behalf of Mao Zedong, told me:

1. Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young arrived today in China.

2. ... In the conversation with Mao Zedong, the Korean comrades stated the position of Comrade Philippov that the present situation differs from the situation in the past and that North Korea can start to act. However, this question must be discussed with China and personally with comrade Mao Zedong.

3. The Korean comrades will stay in Beijing two days.

... Comrade Mao Zedong would like to have personal explanations of comrade Philippov on this issue, which, according to the previous cable of comrade Philippov, should follow shortly

The Chinese comrades request a speedy answer⁶⁰

On May 14, Soviet Ambassador Roshin delivered a message from Moscow to Mao Zedong concerning recent negotiations between Stalin and Kim Il Sung in the Kremlin.

According to Roshin's cable of the same day to Moscow, “Mao Zedong stated that he agreed with the appraisal of the North Korean leadership of the situation in the North and the South, as well as with their appraisal of the balance of forces between Pyongyang and Seoul. Mao Zedong stressed that he supported a speedy military solution of the Korean problems and was sure of its success. The Chinese leader informed Roshin that he had proposed to sign, after the unification, a treaty of friendship with the Koreans, an alliance and mutual assistance agreement similar

⁵⁹ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, May 12, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P. 3-4.

⁶⁰ Roshin's cable to Stalin, May 13, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P. 1-2.

to the Soviet-Chinese treaty. However, the final decision on the question will be made only after comrade Stalin expresses his opinion”⁶¹

On May 15, Mao Zedong held a detailed exchange of views with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young on the invasion of South Korea. After the negotiations the Soviet Ambassador was briefed by both sides (Zhou Enlai and Park Hon-young) separately and their accounts of negotiations differed on a number of points.

Both sides told Roshin:

“In the talks with Mao Zedong Kim Il Sung described the invasion plan of South Korea, the one, which Stalin and Kim Il Sung had agreed upon earlier in Moscow - in the first stage troops are prepared and concentrated, in the second the North advances proposals for the peaceful unification of the country and in the third, after the proposals are rejected by the South, military operations start. Mao Zedong approved the above mentioned plan completely.

After this Mao made a number of recommendations. He stressed that it was necessary to prepare the KPA well for the forthcoming operation. Concrete assignments must be given to each soldier and each commanding officer. Mao underlined the fact that the KPA must act swiftly, go around big cities not wasting time on their takeover, concentrating their efforts on destroying the armed forces of the adversary.

Then Mao asked Kim Il Sung if Japanese troops could interfere in the conflict. Kim Il Sung called such an eventuality not very probable. However, the North Korean leader admitted that Americans might decide to send to Korea 20–30,000 Japanese soldiers. It could hardly change the situation in a serious way, because Koreans would be fighting in such a case even tougher”⁶²

Then, according to Zhou Enlai, “Mao Zedong warned Kim Il Sung that the presence of Japanese troops might prolong the war. He also warned that it is not so much Japanese, as Americans themselves who could interfere in the war”⁶³ Kim Il Sung, as

⁶¹ Roshin's cable to Stalin, May 14, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁶² Roshin's cable to Stalin, May 15, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 3-4.

⁶³ Roshin's cable to Stalin, May 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Zhou Enlai explained, rejected such a possibility, saying that Americans don't show any inclination to engage themselves militarily in the Far East. They left China without fighting; the same careful approach can be expected in Korea. On July 2, 1950 Zhou Enlai repeated a similar version of the discussion on the American participation in the war in Korea, during a meeting with the Soviet Ambassador⁶⁴

Park Hon-young described the Mao-Kim exchange on the issue in a somewhat different fashion:

"Mao Zedong said that Japanese can hardly interfere in the war now. And if Americans take part in the combat activities, then China will help North Korea with its troops. According to Mao Zedong, for the Soviet Union it is not convenient to participate in combat activities, because it is tied with the agreement with America on demarcation along the 38th parallel. China is not tied with similar obligations and therefore can easily extend assistance to the North"⁶⁵.

On the 15th of May, Mao Zedong gave a dinner in honor of Kim Il Sung. Right before the dinner, according to Soviet Ambassador Roshin, Kim said in the presence of Mao:

"Our negotiations with comrade Mao Zedong went very smoothly. Comrade Mao Zedong completely approved the plan of the liberation. He supported what had been agreed upon in Moscow with comrade Stalin"⁶⁶

On the 16th of May, Stalin sent a cable to Mao Zedong, expressing his approval of the Treaty on friendship, alliance and mutual assistance between the PRC and DPRK. The cable said:

"... As soon as the big cause of liberation and unification of Korea is completed, the treaty should be signed. It will solidify successes of the Korean comrades and prevent foreign interference in Korean affairs"⁶⁷

⁶⁴ Roshin's cable to Stalin, May 2, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁶⁵ Roshin's cable to Stalin, May 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁶⁶ A message from Roshin to Stalin, May 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁶⁷ A cable from Stalin to Roshin for Mao Zedong, May 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

Even before Kim Il Sung received in January, 1950 the first hints from Moscow that Stalin had become more favorable to the war in Korea, the North Korean leader set upon upgrading his military potential. The Kremlin responded positively and after the Stalin-Kim Il Sung talks in Moscow in April, 1950 the war preparations were begun by the two sides jointly and actively

On May 1, 1949 Kim Il Sung sent a request to Stalin to provide additional armament to North Korea. His letter to Stalin said:

“Dear Comrade Stalin!

In connection with the changed situation in Korea it is absolutely necessary to strengthen and to raise the technical level of the Korean People’s Army.

I ask you, comrade Stalin, to satisfy our additional request, connected with organizational activities. We intend to complete the formation of additional mechanized units and other troops, except air force, by May 1949, and the air force by September”⁶⁸

According to Soviet Ambassador Shtykov, Kim Il Sung decided to form the following military units:

1. A mechanized brigade with two tank regiments.
2. A separate tank regiment.
3. Additional artillery units to each division.
4. An air-force division.
5. An engineering battalion.
6. An artillery regiment.

The Ambassador stressed that Koreans wanted to make efforts to train more officers, pilots, and tank operators.

To achieve their aims, they wanted Stalin to satisfy their requirements for armament and ammunition⁶⁹

A long list of required arms and ammunition was attached, which Stalin satisfied up to 90%.

On June 4, 1949 Stalin agreed to the supply of large quantities of weapons and ammunition.

A special protocol was signed between the USSR and DPRK, in which Moscow “agreed to satisfy completely the request of the

⁶⁸ A letter from Kim Il Sung to Stalin, April 28, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁶⁹ Shtykov’s cable to Stalin, May 1, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-4.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

government of the DPRK on the supply to Korea of armament, military-technical equipment”⁷⁰ A long list of armament and military-technical equipment was attached to the protocol. Among other things the list included:

Air Force equipment

Il-10 planes — 30

Wil-10 planes — 4

Yak-9 planes — 30

PO-2 planes — 4

Yak-18 planes — 24

Yak-11 planes — 6

Armored vehicles

T-34 Tank — 87

BA-64 Armored vehicles — 57

SU-76 Self-propelled armored machines — 102

M-72 Motorcycles — 122

Besides, the Soviet Union took on the obligation to deliver to North Korea various kinds of cannons, large-caliber guns, machine-guns, sniper-rifles, engineering equipment, boats, landing ships, explosives, river-crossing equipment, radio stations, telephone lines, torpedo boats, anti-submarine ships and a full set of ammunition for Pyongyang’s armed forces.

The North agreed to pay for the military supplies with exports of rice and other foodstuffs, and metals⁷¹

At the end of 1949 Kim Il Sung again addressed himself to Moscow asking for large quantities of weapons. He requested armament and ammunition in 1950 for 1.12 million rifles in exchange for rare and non-ferrous metals. The request was explained “by the necessity of forming new units in 1950: one motorcycle regiment, deployment of an existing infantry brigade into infantry divisions as well as upgrading of armament of existing units; two ships are needed to enlarge recently established Korean fleet”⁷²

⁷⁰ Archives of the President of Russia, Fund 6, list 9, P 57

⁷¹ A cable to Ambassador Shtykov from the Ministry of Armed Forces of the USSR, June 4, 1949. Archives of the President of Russia, P 53-56.

⁷² Shtykov’s cable to Stalin, January 1, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

On March 14, 1950 Kim Il Sung sent a note to the Soviet government requesting to use the USSR credit allocated for 1951, and then transferred to 1950, for the purpose of buying armament, ammunition and military-technical equipment, listed in the amendment to the note. Kim Il Sung stressed in the note:

"The Government of the DPRK hopes that the government of the USSR, understanding well needs of the young Korean republic, will complete the shipment of all special merchandise in the shortest possible period"⁷³

The amendment contained hundreds of items, including navy, air force, infantry, and tank units armament⁷⁴.

On April 3, 1950, as the Soviet Embassy informed Moscow, the leader of the guerrilla movement in South Korea Kim Dal-sam arrived in Pyongyang. As the Embassy noted, the South Korean press and radio repeatedly claimed that Kim Dal-sam was killed while fighting official troops. In reality, Kim Dal-sam came to the DPRK to work out the plan of development of guerrilla activities in the South⁷⁵.)

On May 12, 1950 Kim Il Sung informed the Soviet Ambassador that "concerning the preparations of the offensive against the South he had already instructed the Chief of the General Staff. The war is already being planned. Kim's desire is to start it in June, but he is not sure they'll be able to finish preparations by that time"⁷⁶

On May 27, 1950 Shtykov reported to Stalin:

"Kim Il Sung informed me on the status of preparations for the offensive. At the present time armament and equipment, about which an agreement had been reached in the April negotiations in Moscow, have already arrived in their majority in the DPRK. Kim Il Sung inspected the newly formed divisions and came to the conclusion that they would be ready for fighting by the end of June.

⁷³ Note of the DPRK government, March 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 133-134.

⁷⁴ Amendment to the above mentioned note, P 135-140.

⁷⁵ Embassy's cable to Moscow, April 10, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁷⁶ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, May 12, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

In compliance with the order of Kim Il Sung, the Chief of the General Staff of the KPA has prepared the overall program for the offensive, which he has reported to Kim Il Sung together with General Vasiliev. The Korean leader has approved the document.

Organizational questions of the armed forces are to be completed by June 1. The army of the DPRK will be totally prepared to conduct combat activities in June.

Kim Il Sung noted that he was prepared to start the advance at the end of June. To postpone it further would be inadvisable because, first of all, data on the military preparations of the KPA may leak to the South, and, secondly, because rain will start in July. Kim plans to begin the movement of troops to the areas of their concentration on 8-10 June⁷⁷

On the same day Shtykov conferred with Soviet Generals Vasiliev and Postnikov and relayed their opinion to Stalin. As Shtykov said in his cable, "Generals Vasiliev and Postnikov did not agree with Kim Il Sung. They preferred to start the war in July, because only by that time would the armed forces be fully equipped and prepared from the cadres' point of view"⁷⁸ "However, Shtykov continued, Vasiliev and Postnikov said that there was no choice but to accept the June deadline due to the weather factor. In this respect Kim Il Sung was correct — to advance in the rainy season was too risky"⁷⁹

On June 11, 1950 the South, Shtykov informed Moscow, "rejected the call of the CC of the All-Korean Democratic United Front about peaceful unification"⁸⁰ Shtykov stressed that "it assures us of the necessity to continue implementing of our plan as scheduled. It involves movement of the troops to the 38th parallel and further calls for the peaceful unification"⁸¹

"On June 12, 1950 — Shtykov informed Stalin on the following day — movement of North Korean troops to the location of 10–15 km from the 38th parallel started. A special meeting was held for commanders of divisions, chiefs of staff and chiefs of artillery

⁷⁷ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, May 29, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁷⁸ *Ibid*

⁷⁹ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, May 29, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁸⁰ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 12, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁸¹ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 12, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

of the divisions of the first echelon. At this meeting specific and concrete assignments were given to each formation. Special stress was put on keeping total secrecy of the preliminary arrangements. The adversary's intelligence must not learn anything through ground operations, or from the air"⁸²

On June 15, 1950 the detailed plan of the offensive operation was ready. Shtykov reported to Moscow on June 16, 1950:

"According to the plan, the advance will start in the early morning of June 25. At the first stage, formations and units of the KPA start at Ongjin peninsula like a local operation and then deliver the main strike along the western coast of Korea to the South. At the second stage, Seoul must be taken and the Han River put under control. At the same time, on the eastern front. North Korean troops will liberate the cities of Chunchon and Kangnung. As a result, the main forces of the South Korean army have to be encircled around Seoul and eliminated. The third stage, the final one, will be devoted to the liberation of the rest of Korea by destroying the remaining enemy forces and seizing major population centers and ports"⁸³

While making final preparations for the war, the North continued its "smoke screen" propaganda campaign. On June 16, 1950 the Supreme People's Assembly of the DPRK directed a proposal about peaceful unification to the National Assembly of South Korea. Shtykov reported to Moscow:

"Korean comrades pay the closest attention to the maximum propaganda reach of these peaceful calls, and negative reaction of the South to them, which is easy to predict"⁸⁴

On June 20, 1950 the Soviet Ambassador requested Moscow to provide ships for landing operations of the KPA. He said:

"These operations are necessary to complete the encirclement of the adversary both along western and eastern coasts of South Korea. The KPA lacks adequate landing sea transports. It will also be advisable if our own navy personnel could be used to operate the landing sea transports, since Koreans lack qualified personnel"⁸⁵

⁸² Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 13, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁸³ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁸⁴ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 16, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁸⁵ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, June 20, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On June 21, 1950 Shtykov passed to the Kremlin the following message from Kim Il Sung:

“Kim Il Sung told me that according to radio broadcast interception and intelligence sources the Southerners have learned details of the forthcoming advance of the KPA. As a result, they are taking measures to strengthen the combat capacity of their troops. Defense lines are reinforced and additional units are concentrated in the Ongjin direction. Because of the developing situation Kim Il Sung believes that the original plan of the offensive has to be adjusted. Instead of a local operation at Ongjin peninsula as a prelude to the general offensive, Kim Il Sung suggests an overall attack on June 25 along the whole front line”⁸⁶

On June 21, 1950 Stalin replied:

“1. We will deliver landing sea transports in required quantities to Koreans. However, Soviet personnel cannot be used on these transports because it may give the adversary a pretext for interference by the USA.

2. We agree with Kim Il Sung’s idea for an immediate advance along the whole front line”⁸⁷

⁸⁶ Shtykov’s cable to Stalin, June 21, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

⁸⁷ Stalin’s cable to Shtykov, June 21, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia.

Part II

The Bloodshed

Throughout the initial stage of the Korean war Stalin was clearly in charge: he made the decision when to start the conflict; he directed Kim Il Sung how to fight; and he kept instructing the Korean command on its every move. The mood of both Stalin and Kim Il Sung though was changing dramatically as the South and the Americans kept on advancing. On July 1, 1950 in a dispatch to the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang, sent through the channels of the General Staff of the Soviet armed forces, Stalin said:

“1. You don’t inform us at all as to what are the plans of the Korean military authorities. Do they think of moving ahead? Or have they decided to halt the advancement? According to our view, the advance must be unquestionably continued and the sooner South Korea is liberated, the fewer chances there are for intervention.

2. Inform us as well about the reaction of the Korean leaders to the American air raids on the North Korea areas. Have they been frightened, or do they continue to stand firm?

3. Doesn’t the Korean government think of expressing on open protest against air raids and military intervention? In our view, it must be done.

4. Requests by Koreans for supplies of ammunition and other military property we’ve decided to satisfy completely by July 10. Tell Kim Il Sung about this”¹

On the next day the reply to the above-mentioned inquiry went to the Soviet capital:

“I am reporting on the political mood of the Northerners in connection with the American intervention.

With the beginning of successful military operations, and especially after liberation of the city of Seoul, the mood of the population was characterized by a strong universal political elevation.

The population of the liberated areas, in its majority, warmly welcomed the People’s Army and in all ways assisted its activities. Throughout the liberated areas, organs of authority are being established — people’s committees, social and political organizations, production and commerce are being organized. At that

¹ Coded message N 34691/sh, July 1, 1950, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Soviet Armed Forces, P 104.

time even reactionary elements did not make any moves against activities of the government of the DPRK and the People's Army

A successful advance of the People's Army induced a more active behavior from the guerrillas. At the present time the guerrilla movement behind the enemy lines is being widely expanded.

However, because of a wide escalation of radio propaganda by the Americans against the DPRK and frequent American air raids over the population centers as well as economic and military targets of North and South Korea, the political mood has somewhat worsened.

The leadership of the DPRK and the People's Army (Kim Il Sung, Park Hon-young, Park Il-wu, Kim Chaek, Choi Young-keun, Kang Keun) makes the correct assessment of the current military-political situation in Korea. It believes in the complete victory and concentrates efforts for a further large-scale advance to South Korea.

Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young understand the difficulties for Korea created by the entrance of the Americans into the war, and take the necessary measures to stabilize human and material resources for the war.

Kim Il Sung asked for my opinion concerning the formation of additional infantry, tank and naval units. There is a plan to introduce in the DPRK the total military draft.

At the same time, some leading figures such as Kim Du-bong, Hong Myung-hee talk about the difficulties of conducting a war against the Americans with purely Korean forces. In a careful manner they tried to learn about the Soviet position from Kim Il Sung (this information was provided to the Embassy by the personal secretary of Kim Il Sung).

Rightist and centrist figures, belonging to the government of the DPRK, support all activities of the government, but they haven't done anything so far to mobilize their parties in the South.

The overall situation continues to remain favorable and allows the continuance of the active offensive operations by the People's Army"²

² Coded message N 405809, July 2, 1950, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Soviet Armed Forces.

On July 3, 1950 the Soviet Ambassador met with Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young. In a cable to Stalin, Ambassador Shtykov said:

"Kim Il Sung complained that the troops act very slowly, especially in the central direction. The water-crossing was not organized well though the Minister of Defense was on the spot. Kim Il Sung expressed dissatisfaction with his work.

Kim Il Sung underlined the seriousness of the situation at the front, in the liberated territories and the danger of penetration of the Americans, landing troops to the rear of the Korean troops either through the ports of North Korea or by airborne forces. To counter the possible moves, Kim Il Sung requested additional armament in large quantities. These weapons are needed to equip two divisions, twelve battalions, and police guards.

Because of the activities of the American air raids on railroad stations in the vicinity of Kanggye, Chongjin, Kim Il Sung asked that these armaments be sent swiftly via Manchuria, Andong-Sinuiju-Pyongyang.

Kim Il Sung added as well that North Korea had started to form reserve regiments and two tank brigades; weapons and tanks were required for them.

Then the North Korean leader asked for advice on how to organize the control of operations better in such a complicated situation. Referring to the fact that his armed forces would have to fight against Americans, Kim Il Sung stressed the necessity for strengthening the military command of North Korea. Kim Il Sung sought Soviet advice on the control of operations and on the organizational structure of the control in order to move the General Staff closer to the troops"³

Soviet Ambassador Shtykov and the Chief Soviet Military Adviser General Vasiliev suggested the followings:

"1. Create two army groups headed by military councils, consisting of the commander-in-chief, member of the military council and chief-of-staff.

Each army group will have under it 4 to 6 formations.

³ Coded message N 405840, July 4, 1950, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Soviet Armed Forces, from Pyongyang, P 1.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

2. Create the front command headed by the front commander, chief-of-staff and member of the front military council.

The front command is to be created on orders from the general staff.

3. The Ministry of National Defense is to remain, because it has a reduced size.

The Ministry must be responsible for providing military forces in action with all the necessities (food, fuel, transport, ammunition) as well as for the training of the reserves, new units and organization of the anti-landing defense in the Northern part of the republic.

4. Appoint Kim Il Sung the commander-in-chief of the armed forces”⁴

As Shtykov told Stalin, “Kim Il Sung accepted the above mentioned suggestions. It was also agreed that the restructuring would not affect the frontline activities.”

Kim Il Sung moved on to the question of the composition of the command. He wanted to know the opinion of the Soviets. Shtykov advised him:

“The left-flank group should be headed by the Deputy Defense Minister in charge of artillery, Mu-jung and the right-flank group by Deputy Chief-of-Staff Kim Woong; as front commander Deputy Chairman of the Council of Ministers and Minister of Industry Kim Chaek should be appointed” (Shtykov added “that Kim Chaek knew military affairs, had participated in the guerrilla movement, served in Khabarovsk in the Chinese brigade, and that he was strong-willed, reasonable and courageous”).

Another recommendation by Shtykov was: “to appoint as Chief of Staff of the front Kang Keun, who served at that time as Chief of the General Staff, as for the Minister of Defense, he could stay in place, taking care of new formations, anti-landing operations, and providing the armed forces with all their needs”

Shtykov mentioned in his cable to Stalin that “Kim Il Sung would assure confirmation of the personnel shift at the military committee right away (on July 4 or 5) and that the front headquarters would be moved shortly to Seoul”

⁴ Coded message N 405840, July 4, 1950, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Soviet Armed Forces, from Pyongyang, P 2-3.

Shtykov requested in the same cable Stalin's approval "to have two Soviet military advisers in the formations of armed forces (an adviser to the formation commander and an adviser to the commander of artillery)." Another request concerned "relocation of Chief Military Adviser Vasiliev and a group of Soviet officers along with the front headquarters to Seoul"

On July 6, 1950 Stalin informed Ambassador Shtykov:

"... 3. Armament, tanks as well as other types of military equipment, we give to you completely for two divisions, two tank brigades and 12 battalions, but we believe that the main thing is not this, but to enlarge the existing divisions and to increase their size to approximately 12,000. It is necessary to have an apparatus attached to divisions for the formation of troops, which could receive recruits, check them, train them and then pass them on to the divisions.

This is the most important thing"⁵

On July 8, 1950, feeling difficulties in waging offensive operations, Kim Il Sung sent an urgent letter to Staling

"... Being convinced in your intentions to help the Korean people get rid of the American imperialists, I am compelled to ask you to allow utilization of 25-35 Soviet military advisers in the front headquarters of the Korean Army and the headquarters of two army groups since national military cadres have not as yet sufficiently mastered the art of leading modern troops"⁶

On July 13, 1950 Stalin informed Kim Il Sung that "London proposed North Koreans withdraw to the north of the 38th parallel as a measure to expedite the peaceful solution of the Korean issue"

Stalin continued:

"The British are asking the Soviet government to express its opinion. We consider such a demand arrogant and unacceptable.

We want to answer that the Korean issue has become too complicated after the foreign military intervention and that such a difficult question can be solved only by the Security Council with the participation of the USSR and China and with the invitation of representatives of Korea to hear their opinion"⁷

⁵ Coded message N 35678, July 6 1950, Stalin to Shtykov.

⁶ Coded message N 405976/sh, 8th Direct, General Staff, July 8, 1950.

⁷ Coded message N 37220/sh, 8th Direct, General Staff, July 13, 1950.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On August 28, 1950 Stalin authorized Soviet ambassador Shtykov to visit Kim Il Sung and tell him the following:

“1. The Central Committee of All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik) hails comrade Kim Il Sung and his friends for the great liberation struggle of the Korean people, which comrade Kim Il Sung is conducting with brilliant success. The CC of the AUCP (Bolshevik) does not have any doubts that in the near future the invaders will be driven out of Korea with disgrace.

2. Comrade Kim Il Sung should not feel embarrassed due to the fact that he does not always achieve successes in the war against the interventionists, that there are delays in advancement and even some local defeats. In such a war one cannot expect endless successes. There was no such phenomenon in the Russian Civil War, and, even to a larger degree, it was not the case in the war against Germany. The biggest success of the Korean people is the fact that it has become the most popular country in the world and has turned into the banner of the liberation movement in Asia against the imperialist yoke. From now on armies of all exploited peoples will learn from the Korean People's Army to deliver decisive blows to American and other imperialists. Besides, comrade Kim Il Sung should not forget that Korea now is not alone, that it has allies, which are helping and will continue to help it. The situation of Russians during the Anglo-Franco-American intervention in 1919 was several times worse than the situation of Korean comrades today

3. Advise comrade Kim Il Sung not to disperse air power, but instead concentrate it on the front. It is necessary that every advance of the People's Army in every section on the front should start with a series of decisive strikes by the attack planes at the enemy troops. The attack planes should to a degree possible defend troops of the People's Army from enemy air strikes. If necessary, we can send additional bombers and attack planes”⁸

Kim Il Sung was very impressed with Stalin's letter of August 28, 1950. Upon hearing the contents of this letter on August 29, 1950 from Ambassador Shtykov Kim Il Sung said:

⁸ Coded message N 75021, 28 August 1950, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Armed Forces of the Soviet Union, P 1-2.

"This is a very good letter... a very important letter. It is necessary to share the contents of this letter with the members of the Political Council of the CC since some its members have a bad disposition. It is useful for these persons to hear the letter"⁹

On the following day Kim Il Sung chaired the Political Council of the CC of the Workers' Party, which adopted an official reply to Stalin:

"We are deeply touched by your care. Let us express, our dear teacher, gratitude for sympathy and advice. In the crucial period of the struggle of the Korean people we received moral support from you.

We are fully determined to gain final victory in the struggle against the American interventionists, who are trying to enslave Korea again.

In the honorable struggle for independence and freedom we constantly feel your fatherly care and assistance"¹⁰

With the situation getting more and more complicated for North Koreans, Stalin, after urgent requests from both Kim Il Sung and Moscow representatives in Korea, consented to station Soviet air force units in the North. An appropriate command was given to the military leadership of the USSR.

On September 21, 1950, Marshal Aleksander M. Vasilevsky reported to Stalin:

"1. Concerning the transfer of the Yak-9 fighter regiment for the cover of Pyongyang, I am informing you of the following: to expedite the transfer... we propose to rely on the potential of N 147 air division..., deployed in the Maritime Province in the vicinity of Voroshilov city... It should be taken into account that during the transfer of the planes air battles are inevitable in the area of Antung-Pyongyang.

... 3. Due to the lack of service personnel in Korea it is necessary beforehand... to move to Pyongyang by railroad via Antung an aviation technical battalion of the above mentioned regiment...

⁹ Coded message N 600037/sh, August 30, 1950, Shtykov to Stalin.

¹⁰ Coded message N 600047/sh, August 31, 1950, From Shtykov to Stalin with the text of the letter from Pyongyang.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Simultaneously ammunition and fuel will be shifted to Pyongyang, if Koreans lack them...

4. Because Koreans don't have the air control and air alert systems, we should provide appropriate facilities. Otherwise our planes at the airfields will be subject to sudden strikes by enemy air raids..."¹¹

On September 23, 1950, Marshal Vasilevsky gave Stalin the final plan for Soviet air participation in the Korean war. The plan stressed the fact that North Koreans did not have service personnel, full ammunition or anti-aircraft equipment necessary to organize an effective air defense of Pyongyang. All these items were to be provided by the USSR.

Vasilevsky asked Stalin to pay special attention to the following fact:

"... work of our pilots near Pyongyang will be inevitably discovered by the Americans immediately after the first battle, because the control of the air battles will be conducted by pilots speaking in Russian on the radio net"¹²

While the Soviets were getting ready to provide the air cover for their North Korean allies, their situation was becoming desperate. Soviet General Matveev, who was sent by Moscow to appraise the development of events at the front, reported to Stalin on September 27, 1950:

"Situation at the western (Seoul) and southeast (Pusan) directions remains very difficult for the People's Army

Striving to encircle and destroy the main forces of the People's Army, the Americans have concentrated in the general direction of Yaju major efforts of its troops, landed in the area of Inchon, and troops advancing from the area to the north and northwest of Taegu.

With the support of the air force, which absolutely dominates the air and has created an "air scare" both at the front and in the rear of the People's Army, the Americans have managed to advance from Suwon to the east and southeast for 25–30 km, to the north and northwest of Taegu, using portion of the force to take over Sangju and Andong.

¹¹ Coded message N 1172 ss, September 21, 1950.

¹² Vasilevsky's report to Stalin, September 23, 1950.

According to information, which needs verification, tank units of the Seoul group of the adversary's army continued to advance to Yaju. It creates a danger of encirclement of the first army group.

Troops of the People's Army, incurring heavy losses, first of all from the adversary's air force, having lost almost all its tanks and much artillery, are conducting difficult restraining battles. The troops suffer from lack of ammunition and fuel. In some units they have none. Control over availability of arms and ammunition is unsatisfactory. Troop control at all levels is really bad. Communication systems work only sporadically due to the destruction by the enemy air activities. Radio communication does not function because of a lack of qualified radio operators and the lack of fuel for radio stations. Human communication methods are rarely used.

... On September 25, 1950 at 19:00 hours. Kim Il Sung gave an order to the Seoul group and 2nd army group, acting in the northern sector of the southeast, to do its best to stop the adversary and organize a defense.

Troops of the 2nd army group, acting in the central and southern sectors of the southeast are to start retreating to the areas of Hamchang, Taejon, Poun for the subsequent straightening of the front along the line of Seoul, Yaju, Paju, Wollung.

On September 26, 1950 our group was received by Kim Il Sung.

As a result of this meeting Kim Il Sung decided to concentrate in his own hands the responsibilities of Commander-in-Chief and Defense Minister.

At the present time, the fortification of six infantry divisions in the North is conducted. The formation of nine divisions of South Koreans has been ruined by the advance of the adversary.

Kim Il Sung agreed to move all available human resources from the South at once in order to use them for fortification of military units in the North or at least to deny an opportunity for South Korea.

Because Chinese railroads are jammed with transports moving to Korea, it is desirable to give first priority to the shipments of arms and ammunition for the six divisions being formed.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

After meeting with Kim Il Sung we set upon solving the following tasks:

- 1) the organization of good troop control;
- 2) putting in order issues of material and technical supplies, transportation and road service;
- 3) preparation of defense lines.

Koreans don't have drivers. Maybe Kim should ask Chinese to send 1500 drivers?"¹³

On September 27, 1950, the Politburo of the CC of Stalin's Communist Party officially approved a directive to the Soviet Ambassador in Korea, Shtykov and Chief Soviet Military Adviser in Korea, Matveev. The directive was written and signed by Stalin personally:

"During the last few days the situation at the front has become serious (both near Seoul and in the southeast). It is a consequence of major mistakes on the part of the front command, the command of army groups and army formations in the sphere of troop control and especially in the field of tactics of their combat utilization.

Soviet military advisers are even more guilty of these mistakes. Our military advisers have not been able to implement precisely, and in a timely fashion the order of the chief commander concerning withdrawal of four divisions from the principal front to the vicinity of Seoul, though a full possibility to achieve it at the moment of the decision did exist. As a result, seven days were lost and the Americans got control of Seoul — a large tactical advantage. If those divisions were withdrawn on time, it could drastically reverse the situation around Seoul.

The battalions and regiments being sent to the Seoul front, separately and unprepared for fighting, could not be effective due to the lack of coordination and communication with the headquarters. The division, which had arrived from the southeast, in disorganized fashion was being put into action immediately in small units. Thus the adversary was helped in beating it to pieces. Instead, as we had instructed you earlier, you had to deploy this division for fighting in the area to the northeast and east from Seoul, had to put it there in order to give it at least a

¹³ Coded message N 600262/sh, September 27, 1950.

day's rest, ready it for the battle and only after that introduce it into action in an organized fashion"¹⁴

Stalin lashes out at "the wrong and absolutely inadvisable tactics of using tanks in battles." Stalin notes:

"Lately tanks have been put into action without preliminary artillery shelling for cleaning up the field for tanks. Because of this our tanks are easily destroyed by the adversary. Our military advisers with their experience of the Great Patriotic War must know that such ignorant utilization of tanks brings nothing but losses"¹⁵

With each paragraph, Stalin's denunciations get more and more devastating. He continues:

"What comes to attention is the strategic ineptness of our advisers, as well as their blindness in the field of intelligence. They have not understood the serious meaning of the adversary's landing at Inchon, but have ignored the serious meaning of the landing. As for Ambassador Shtykov, he even recommended putting on trial the author of the article in Pravda about the American landing operation. This blindness and lack of strategic experience caused doubts about the necessity for moving troops from the south to the Seoul region. The movement itself dragged on and slowed down, thus we lost seven days to the joy of the adversary.

The performance of our military advisers in helping Koreans in such fields as communications, troop control, organization of intelligence and combat activities is also bad. Assistance was so abysmally weak that the troops of the Korean army are practically unmanageable; they fight blindly and cannot coordinate with each other. This may be bearable in the case of a successful advance, but it is absolutely unbearable when there are complications at the front.

Explain to Soviet military advisers, first of all to Vasiliev, how to help the Korean command conduct an orderly withdrawal of the troops from the southeast and quickly organize a new front of defense to the east, south and north of Seoul.

¹⁴ Politburo of the CC of All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik), Decision of September 7, NP 78/73, Extract from the minutes N 78 of Politburo meeting. 73. Questions of Korea, P 1.

¹⁵ *Ibid.*

1. Withdrawal of the main forces has to be conducted under cover of a strong rear guard, gathered from divisions capable of standing up seriously to the adversary. For this purpose the rear guard has to be headed by experienced combat commanders. The rear guard must be reinforced by the army first of all, anti-tank artillery, field engineers and, where it is possible with tanks.

2. The rear guard must fight from one defensive line to another defensive line, widely putting up obstructions, using mines and tools at hand.

The rear guard must be decisive and active in order to win time for the withdrawal of main forces.

3. The main forces of divisions, if possible, have to be moved not separately, but in a compact manner. They must be ready to fight their own way out. The main forces must have strong vanguards with artillery, and when possible with tanks as well.

4. Tanks must be used only together with ground troops and after preparatory artillery shelling.

5. Vanguard units must occupy and control bridges, crossings, summits, ridges and important road intersections until the main forces follow.

6. During withdrawal of troops, special attention must be paid to intelligence gathering as well as to maintaining communications among troops.

7 While organizing defensive lines, stretching out the forces along the front must be avoided. The main directions must be well covered and strong reserves are to be created for offensive operations.

8. While organizing communications with troops under the Korean command the radio cipher equipment must be utilized.

... Measures must be taken to prevent capture of any military advisers (as had been ordered earlier)"¹⁶

And yet the North Korean army continued to plunge into an abyss. On September 29, 1950 Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young invited Soviet Ambassador Shitykov and briefed him on the situation at the front. Kim Il Sung, according to Shitykov, said:

"The adversary occupied the Sorak mountain range and penetrated to the rear of the 2nd army group. As a result the situation

¹⁶ *Ibid.*

has become grave. Earlier we hoped to retreat in an organized fashion, but because of the bad discipline and non-implementation of orders, the adversary cut the 1st army group and is advancing to Mungyong and Koesan cutting the 2nd army group.

The situation in Seoul is also unclear.

Despite our insistence, Choi Yong-keun does not report anything to us though communications lines with him are open"¹⁷

After this, Shtykov, according to his cable to Moscow, replied to Kim Il Sung:

"I cannot advise anything since I am not aware of the condition of the North Korean army and its exact location. However, I deem it urgent for Kim Il Sung to organize defense at the 38th parallel...

Kim Il Sung asked me if I thought that the adversary would cross the 38th parallel.

I said that it was still unclear, but the defense at the 38th parallel must be quickly organized.

Kim Il Sung emphasized his previous point that they want to unify the country relying on their own forces, that they want to form 15 divisions and continue the struggle, but it won't be clearcut if the adversary crosses the 38th parallel. If the adversary crosses the 38th parallel, then they won't be able to organize new troops and they won't have the means to put up a serious resistance.

In this connection they want to ask for advice about sending a letter to comrade Stalin. I said that on this issue I could not advise them. They explained that the letter contained a request to help North Korea with aviation, a similar theme sounded in a letter they just sent to Mao Zedong.

My opinion is that Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young are very nervous. In the present difficult circumstances one can feel the growing confusion and pessimism of Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young.

The situation has become increasingly complicated.

... Seoul fell. There are no troops which are capable of putting up a serious resistance to the adversary who is swiftly moving to the 38th parallel.

¹⁷ Coded message N 60080/sh, September 30, 1950.

... Political situation also gets more and more complicated. The enemy has intensified sending paratroopers to the territory of North Korea, trying to identify supplies from the USSR and to organize terrorist acts. Reactionary forces raise their heads in North Korea as well"¹⁸

On the same day Shtykov complained to Moscow that "because of the American air raids most enterprises of North Korea have been demolished and don't operate." Shtykov asked for permission to send back to the USSR most Soviet advisers and Embassy employees "without whom the work can be continued"¹⁹ Moscow replied that "in order not to increase panic in Pyongyang it should not be done"²⁰

Meanwhile the North Korean leadership prepared a letter to Stalin, in which it admitted that it could not continue without direct Soviet intervention. The letter, approved and dated September 29, 1950, was delivered to the Soviet Ambassador on September 30 and that same day forwarded to Moscow

The letter said:

"To the deeply respected Iosif Vissarionovich Stalin:

On behalf of the Korean Workers' Party we express to you, liberator of the Korean people and the Supreme leader of the working people of the whole world, deep appreciation for sympathy and assistance, which you constantly extend to our people, who are fighting for the liberty and independence of our Motherland.

In this letter we would like to brief you about the situation developing at the front of the liberation war of our people against the American aggressors.

Before landing operations in the area of Inchon the situation could not be described as unfavorable to us.

The adversary, losing one battle after another, was chased into a small territory of the Southern tip of South Korea and we had a big chance to win the last decisive battles.

Such a tendency sharply weakened the military prestige of the U.S.A. That's why the U.S.A. in order to restore its prestige and

¹⁸ *Ibid.*

¹⁹ N 182/sh, A. Gromyko's note to Stalin, September 30, 1950.

²⁰ A cable to Shtykov, September 30, 1950.

to achieve its old plans of taking over Korea and turning it into a military strategic springboard, has mobilized almost all their ground, navy and air forces deployed in the Pacific Ocean. On September 16, 1950 they executed a landing operation and moved considerable quantities of troops and equipment into the area of Inchon. Having seized Inchon, the adversary is engaged now in street fighting directly in the city of Seoul. The situation has become threatening.

Units of our People's Army are fighting heroically against units of the adversary. However, we consider it necessary to report to you about extremely unfavorable conditions for us.

The enemy's air force, possessing about one thousand planes of various kinds, is not encountering any resistance from our side, and has full control in the air. It conducts bombing at the front and in the rear daily, around the clock.

At the front motorized units of the adversary, under cover of hundreds of planes, freely maneuver, inflicting considerable losses to our soldiers and hardware. At the same time enemy planes freely destroy railroads, highways, telegraph and telephone lines, transportation means and other facilities. It prevents a normal supply of fighting units and impedes the actions of our troops, making it impossible for them to make timely maneuvers. These difficulties are encountered on all fronts.

The adversary... has a real possibility to seize completely the city of Seoul.

As a result units of the People's Army, deployed in the southern part of Korea, are blocked by the adversary from the north. The units located in the South are cut to pieces and cannot get ammunition, arms and foodstuffs. Some units have no communication among them, and parts of them are encircled by the adversary.

After seizing Seoul, the adversary, it is evident, will continue to advance to North Korea. Therefore we believe that if the unfavorable conditions persist for us, then the American aggression will achieve success.

To provide the troops with all their needs, we first of all need to have an adequate air force. But we don't have trained cadres.

Dear comrade Stalin! We are full of resolution to overcome all difficulties facing us in order not to allow turning Korea into a

colony and a military springboard for American imperialists. For independence, democracy and the happiness of the people we'll be fighting till the last drop of our blood. Therefore, we use all our energy to form and train numerous new divisions. We try to utilize over one hundred thousand troops mobilized in South Korea at the most promising operational directions, and we try to arm the whole population to make it prepared for a long war.

Notwithstanding all this, if the adversary does not give us time to execute the planned activities and, taking advantage of an extremely difficult situation, speedily advances to North Korea, then we won't be able to rely on our forces to stop the adversary.

Therefore, dear Iosif Vissarionovich, we cannot help but ask for your special assistance. In other words, at the moment that the enemy troops cross the 38th parallel we'll be in dire need of direct military assistance from the Soviet Union.

If for some reasons it is not possible, then provide us the assistance to create international volunteer units in China and in other democratic people's countries to provide military aid to our struggle.

We ask for your instructions concerning our above mentioned proposal.

With respect, the CC of the Workers' Party of Korea

Kim Il Sung, Park Hon-young

September 29, 1950²¹

The reply to the Ambassador's cable was approved by the Soviet Politburo on September 30, 1950. It said:

"We consider correct decisions taken by Kim Il Sung in the talk with you concerning concentration in the hands of Kim Il Sung the responsibilities of Commander-in-Chief, and Defense Minister, creation of the General Staff under the Commander-in-Chief, formation of six divisions and the withdrawal from South Korea of human reserves.

Formation of the six divisions must be expedited. Armament, ammunition and other equipment will be delivered in the period between October 5 and 20.

²¹ Coded message N 600308/sh, September 30, 1950.

As for the advisability for Kim Il Sung to ask Chinese comrades to send drivers to Korea, you can give such advice, but without reference to Moscow”²²

Realizing that the situation is desperate in Korea, Moscow has started to act in the following directions:

1) giving constant tactical advice to North Koreans; 2) withdrawing Soviet representatives from Korea; 3) working out a plan of evacuation for the North Korean communist regime and troops from the Korean peninsula; 4) training their troops for the future revanchism; and 5) putting pressure on the Chinese to enter the war.

Let’s illustrate the activities of Moscow at the four mentioned directions, with documents (the fifth direction-the Chinese one-will be handled in the following chapter).

1) tactical advice:

On October 2, 1950 a cable went from Moscow to the Chief Military Adviser in Korea, General Matveev

“We constantly emphasize the extremely important significance of withdrawing units from the encirclement. Consider the task of moving units from the South to the North as being of the paramount importance.

In the present situation, it is necessary to give immediate instructions to the remaining soldiers in the South, and especially commanding officers, to use any method to go back to the North, by groups or separately. There is no steady front line. They are on our territory. The population has sympathy for them and will be helping them. Let them forget about heavy weapons and move at any cost, and quickly, to the North, using the cover of night and areas unoccupied by the adversary. In such a way, you have an opportunity to move the main asset-cadres out of encirclement.

Take all measures to fulfill this task”²³

2) withdrawing Soviet representatives:

²² Decision of the PB of the CC of All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik), N P 78/118, September 30, 1950.

²³ A cable from Defense Minister Bulganin to General Matveev, October 2, 1950.

Here, the position of Moscow drastically changed in October compared with September. On October 5, 1950 the Politburo in Moscow made the decision to evacuate a portion of the specialists and personnel of Soviet organizations in Korea²⁴

On the next day, however, a much more dramatic decision was adopted. Replying to the urgent and panicked request of Ambassador Shtykov of October 5, the Politburo instructed him:

— About returning back to the USSR Soviet specialists and personnel of Soviet organizations in Korea, we gave you instructions in our N 18909 on October 5, 1950;

— The question of evacuation of families of Soviet Koreans you must decide yourself in connection with the situation;

— All Soviet air command personnel as well as families of Soviet military advisers must be evacuated from the territory of Korea;

— We agree with your proposal that in case of necessity all Soviet citizens, including Soviet Koreans, must be evacuated to the territory of the USSR and/or China²⁵

3) evacuation of Kim Il Sung's regime:

On October 13, 1950 Stalin sent a cable to Kim Il Sung:

"We consider that continuation of the resistance is hopeless. Chinese comrades refuse to get involved militarily.

Under these circumstances you must prepare for total evacuation to China and/or the USSR. It is of the utmost importance to take all the troops and military equipment. Draw a detailed plan of activities in this connection and follow it meticulously. The potential for further struggle against the adversary must be preserved"²⁶

On the same day the cable was read by Ambassador Shtykov to Kim Il Sung and Park Hon-young. According to Shtykov, "the contents of the cable was unexpected for Kim and Park. Kim Il Sung said that for them it is difficult, but because there is such advice they'll implement it.

²⁴ The Politburo of the CC of the AUCP (B), N P 78/168, October 5, 1950, 1304/sh, N 18909.

²⁵ Coded message to Ambassador Shtykov, N 1405/sh, October 6, 1950.

²⁶ Stalin's cable to Kim Il Sung, October 13, 1950.

²⁷ Shtykov's cable to Stalin, October 14, 1950.

... Kim Il Sung asked us to provide assistance in working out the plan of activities in this regard"²⁷

On November 2, 1950 Kim Il Sung reported to Stalin:

"Under an agreement with Chinese comrades, Korean reserves of the People's Army for future battles are being taken to the territory of Manchuria: nine infantry divisions, an officers' school, training tank regiment, aviation division with a training aviation regiment; and six combat divisions will be upgraded and prepared in Korea.

I strongly request from you, dear comrade Feng Si [Stalin's pen name], to retain Soviet military advisers for the training of the mentioned formations..."²⁸

By November 11, 1950, according to the report of the Soviet Defense Ministry, the Korean People's Army had the following disposition:

a) in the territory of Manchuria:

— 6th Army (infantry divisions 18th, 68th, 36th), each division with 10,000 personnel;

— 7th Army (13th, 32th, 37th infantry divisions), each division with 10,000 personnel;

— 8th Army (42nd, 45th, 76th infantry divisions), each division with 10,000 personnel;

— officers' college (for all services) — 15,000 personnel;

b) in the territory of North Korean:

— 1st Army (8th, 46th, 47th infantry divisions, 17th motorized) 10,000 personnel in each;

— 3rd Army (1st, 3rd, 15th infantry divisions, 26th infantry brigade, 105th tank division) — 10,000 each for the divisions, 6,000 for brigade;

— 4th Army (41st infantry division, marine brigade, independent infantry regiment and tank regiment) — 10,000 each for the divisions, 6,000 for brigade, and 3,000 for regiment;

— 5th Army (6th, 12th, 38th and 24th infantry divisions) — 10,000 each;

— four separate divisions (2nd, 4th, 5th, 7th), altogether about 20,000.

c) left in the rear of the adversary

²⁸ Coded message N 600603/sh, November 2, 1950 from Shitykov to Stalin.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

– 2nd Army (31st infantry division, 27th infantry brigade, separate infantry regiment).

Total:

army – 8	marine brigade – 1
infantry divisions – 25	separate infantry regiments – 2
infantry brigades – 3	separate tank regiment – 1
tank division – 1	officers' college – 1
mechanized division – 1	

4) training North Korean troops for future revanchism:

On October 9, 1950 Kim Il Sung, admitting that “the American aggressors will not stop at anything now in order to seize all of Korea and turn it into a military-strategic springboard for future aggressions in the Far East,”²⁹ underlines that “the struggle of our people for independence, liberty and state sovereignty ... will be prolonged and very difficult”³⁰

Kim Il Sung continues that to fight against Americans Korea “needs to urgently train pilots, tank-operators, communications specialists and officers of the engineering service.” Kim Il Sung requests:

“1) to allow training of 200-300 pilots from the students, studying in the USSR;

2) to train from among Soviet Koreans 1000 tank-operators, 2000 pilots, 500 communications specialists, 500 officers of the engineering service”³¹

On the next day the North Korean Ambassador paid a visit to Deputy Foreign Minister A.Gromyko and requested that all North Korean students, studying in the USSR (669 men and 89 women), be transferred to the fliers' school (with the exception of those studying in the communications institute – they must go to the military radio school)³²

On October 20, 1950, A. Gromyko reported to Stalin that the North Koreans made two different requests to the Soviet government: one through the North Korean Ambassador asking to

²⁹ Coded message N 600382/sh, October 9, 1950. A cable from Shtykov to Stalin with a letter from Kim Il Sung.

³⁰ *Ibid.*

³¹ *Ibid.*

³² A.Gromyko with Ju Young-ha, October 10, 1950.

transfer Korean students to fliers' and military radio schools, the second through Shtykov did not mention the radio school. The North Korean Ambassador said to follow the request through Shtykov. It is being already done³³

General Zakharov reported to Moscow on November 2, 1950 that by November 1 an air force regiment was formed out of 29 trained Korean pilots. "On November 18 planes of this regiment for the first time went on a combat assignment in the area of Anju. They shot down two planes — a B-29 and a F-51 Mustang. Two Korean pilots on Yak-9 have not come back from the assignment... Control of the mixed division of Koreans in Antung has been formed. It is headed by general Li Da (?)"³⁴

On November 13, 1950 North Korean Ambassador Ju Young-ha made an additional request to train radio operators from among Korean students studying in the USSR. He also informed Soviet Foreign Ministry officials that "Kim Il Sung had already approached the Soviet government with a request to train groups of pilots, tank-operators and radio-operators from among Soviet Koreans. Kim Il Sung requests to speed up solution of this problem"³⁵

On November 20, 1950 Stalin agreed to train Korean fliers, proposing the following plan:

"1. Training of 200–300 fliers from among Korean students to be organized in the territory of Manchuria in the already functioning pilots' school in Yangtse... Soviet instructors will be provided.

2. Training of fliers for two jet-fighter regiments can be organized at one of our divisions in Manchuria. They may be trained in Mig-15s. After training, Mig-15s will be provided for Korean fliers.

As for bomber pilots, it is more convenient to train them in the USSR — in the Korean school in the Maritime province. Tu-2s will be provided for the bombing regiment..."³⁶

³³ A Note from Gromyko to Stalin, October 20, 1950, N 255-GE.

³⁴ Coded message N 26416, November 11, 1950. From Zakharov to Stalin.

³⁵ Memorandum of conversation of acting Chief of a Department at the Soviet Foreign Ministry, E. Kurdumov and North Korean Ambassador Ju Young-ha (^M), November 13, 1950.

³⁶ Coded message N 75835, November 20, 1950, Stalin to Kim Il Sung.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

As we mentioned earlier, China supported the offensive in Korea. However, quite soon Beijing felt distressed and offended by the fact that North Koreans did not consult with them and did not heed their advice. Moscow tried to console its Chinese ally

Soviet Ambassador in China, Roshin, informed Moscow on July 1, 1950 about Chinese reaction to the war in Korea. In a conversation Zhou Enlai said to the Ambassador:

“... Notwithstanding assistance from Americans, South Korean puppets are suffering a complete defeat. The power of North Korea has surpassed the expectations of Americans. Orders of Truman about military intervention in Korea are not acts of state wisdom, but gestures of desperation. Suffering a defeat in the Far East, the U.S.A. has started to express worries about its positions in the Middle and Near East, as well as in Europe. All this demonstrates that the U.S.A. is not ready for a serious military confrontation with the camp of peace and democracy, headed by the USSR”³⁷

On July 2, 1950 Zhou Enlai gave the Soviet Ambassador a Chinese appraisal of the situation in Korea. In a cable to Moscow, the Soviet Ambassador reported:

“According to the Chinese, the Americans can throw into Korea 60,000 troops out of 120,000 strong Americans from the occupation army in Japan. These troops can land in the ports of Pusan, Masan, Mokpo and then move to the north along railroads. Because of this, the KPA must speed up its advance to the South in order to seize those ports.

Mao Zedong believes that simultaneously, for covering Seoul, it is necessary to create a strong defense in the area of Inchon, because American troops can land there.

When I asked Zhou Enlai if it is true that a Japanese corps is being prepared for Korea, the Chinese representative said Beijing did not have such information.

Zhou Enlai also stressed that if Americans cross the 38th parallel, then Chinese troops, disguised as Koreans, will take action using the volunteers against them. For this purpose Chinese leadership has already concentrated in the area of Mukden three armies numbering 120,000 personnel. Zhou Enlai inquired if it

³⁷ A cable from Roshin to Stalin, July 1, 1950.

would be possible for the Soviet air force to provide air cover for these troops.

Zhou Enlai, talking about the developing scenario of the Korean conflict, stressed that North Koreans had underestimated the possibility of American military interference, ignoring Mao Zedong's warnings to this effect back in May of 1949 and 1950"³⁸

On July 5, 1950 Stalin cabled Beijing:

"To Roshin, responding to your N 1112-1126, pass Zhou Enlai the following information:

... 2. We consider it right that you immediately concentrate 9 Chinese divisions on the Chinese-Korean border for volunteer activities in North Korea in case of crossing by the adversary of the 38th parallel. We'll try to provide the air cover for these units"³⁹

On July 8, 1950 Stalin sent the following instructions to the Soviet Ambassador in China: "Tell Mao Zedong that Koreans complain that there is no Chinese representative in Korea. They should quickly send a representative in order to have a communication line and solve problems faster, if, of course, Mao Zedong believes it is necessary to have communications with Korea"⁴⁰

On July 13, 1950 Stalin sent the following cable to Beijing:

"Soviet Ambassador.

Pass the following to Zhou Enlai and Mao Zedong:

"... 2.. We don't know if you have decided to deploy nine Chinese divisions on the border with Korea. If you've taken such a decision then we are ready to give a division of 124 jet fighter-planes for covering these troops.

We plan, with the assistance of our fliers, to train Chinese fliers over two-three months and then give all the material equipment to your fliers. We want to do the same thing with the aviation division in Shanghai"⁴¹

On July 13, 1950 Soviet Ambassador Roshin passed intelligence information to Moscow, provided by the Chinese govern-

³⁸ Roshin's cable to Moscow, July 2, 1950. Coded message N 1112-1126.

³⁹ Coded message N 3172, July 5, 1950, Stalin to Zhou Enlai.

⁴⁰ Coded message N 3231, July 8, 1950, Stalin to Mao Zedong.

⁴¹ Coded message N 3805, July 13, 1950, Stalin to Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai.

ment. It concerned the opinions of the foreign diplomats in Beijing about the Korean War. Among other things it contained the following statement of British consul Brian:

"Brian came to the conclusion that the conflict in Korea was launched by the USSR with the special purpose of preventing China from seizing Taiwan and becoming a strong power. Brian stressed that it looks like the U.S.A. and USSR act in union, taking measures to prevent China from completing the civil war"⁴²

On August 6, 1950 Moscow told Ambassador Roshin in Beijing to tell the Chinese the following:

"In a conversation between correspondents of TASS and the French Press Agency (AFP) in Washington D. C. the French journalist hinted that the American government was considering the possibility of expanding combat activities to the territory of China through penetration there of armed bands of Guomindang. As the French journalist implied, special assistant to the American President Averell Harriman intends to discuss this issue with MacArthur during his forthcoming trip to Japan"⁴³.

On August 19, 1950 Mao Zedong had a lengthy conversation with Academician Yudin, who came to China to edit Mao's theoretical works (and later became Soviet Ambassador to the PRC). The USSR embassy sent the following account of the above mentioned conversation:

"Talking about events in Korea, Mao Zedong expressed an opinion that there exist two possible scenarios of development of the situation.

1. If Americans continue to conduct the war with approximately the same forces as today, then they'll be pushed out of Korea in the near future and they won't interfere in Korean affairs again. Of course, Mao stressed, it is the best scenario possible.

2. If Americans decide to win in Korea at any cost, they'll need 30-40 divisions. Under such circumstances, Koreans won't hold on their own, they'll need Chinese assistance. If assistance is provided, it will be possible "to mince" those 30-40 divisions. In

⁴² Roshin's cable to Moscow, July 13, 1950.

⁴³ August 6, 1950, Moscow's cable to Roshin.

case such a scenario is fulfilled, then the dates of the Third World War will be postponed. And it is, of course, favorable for the USSR and the PRC.

Mao Zedong emphasized that it is necessary to intensify considerably international propaganda against American participation in the Korean War..."⁴⁴

On August 28, 1950 Academician Yudin attended a dinner, hosted by Mao Zedong. The Soviet Embassy reported to Stalin the following comments Mao made about Korea:

"... Mao Zedong stressed that, judging by the latest developments, Americans have decided to considerably increase their forces in Korea. Because of this one cannot exclude the second scenario of development of the Korean situation, which he, Mao Zedong, had described to Yudin in their conversation on August 19. If it is true, it means that Americans will be sending more and more troops to the Korean peninsula. They even provoke China now, shelling border areas of China, adjacent to Korea..."⁴⁵

On September 2, 1950 Zhou Enlai briefed Soviet Ambassador Roshin on the advice, given recently by Mao Zedong to the North Korean leadership. In a cable to Stalin, Roshin said the followings:

"The main idea of Mao Zedong was that the events in Korea can develop according to two scenarios. In the first, the KPA will defeat the Americans and will throw them out into the sea. In the second case, events will take on a prolonged character. Under such circumstances, Americans will use all their forces to hold onto the Taegu-Pusan area. In this way they'll be engaging the main force of the KPA and get a free hand for landing and other operations in various directions.

Mao Zedong recommended that Koreans be prepared for the second scenario, create sufficient reserves and pay close attention to the areas of Inchon-Seoul, Chinnampo-Pyongyang as main focusing points which have to be covered from a possible attack.

The Chinese leader explained that judging from the experience of the Red Army and the PLA of China, Koreans commit a mistake by distributing their forces evenly along all the front and

⁴⁴ A cable from the Soviet Embassy to Stalin, August 20, 1950.

⁴⁵ A cable from the Soviet Embassy to Stalin, August 28, 1950.

not attempting to eliminate the adversary, but to push him out and to seize the territory. Because the KPA did not set up the reinforced attack groups and reserves, the adversary easily “read” the entire composition of the Korean orders and could arrange counter-measures in time.

That’s why Americans could withdraw and turn to the well-organized positional defense in the Taegu-Pusan area. As for the KPA, it’s been already over one month that the Korean army has been fighting on the same spot without noticeable success and incurring excessive losses.

Mao Zedong put special stress on the necessity to avoid pulling into combat activities all forces of the KPA. Besides, a future quick retreat, in case of need, has to be thought over. It is also necessary to be ready for the regrouping of forces at the new front line. People should be prepared for long, difficult fighting...”⁴⁶

On September 18, 1950 Roshin reported to Stalin from China: “Today Zhou Enlai invited me and two military advisers, Kotov and Konnov to meet with him. At the meeting Zhou Enlai, who looked very distressed, asked us if we knew anything about the landing of American troops in Inchon on September 15, 1950. Zhou Enlai complained that the Chinese leadership did not have any data on the landing besides newspaper reports and the broadcasts on Pyongyang radio.

Zhou Enlai stressed that unfortunately contacts with Korean comrades on the military issues are very weak. The Chinese know about the North Korean requirements for cadres, but they know absolutely nothing of the operational plans of the KPA. An attempt was made to send to the DPRK important Chinese military figures from the border military districts for on the spot observation of the combat activities. However, up to now there has been no reply from Pyongyang.

Zhou Enlai also bitterly complained that North Korean leadership ignored all advice and forecasts, offered earlier by Mao Zedong. According to Zhou Enlai, even the Chinese Ambassador in Pyongyang does not receive operational information about the military situation, so he is unable to inform Beijing properly.

⁴⁶ A cable from Roshin to Stalin, September, 3, 1950.

As a result the Chinese government does not know the real situation in Inchon and cannot take a coherent position on the developing situation. A few days later Zhou Enlai offered some recommendations, based on the official reports about fighting in Korea. Zhou stressed the following:

1. If North Koreans have reserves of 100.000 in the area of Seoul and Pyongyang, they can and must liquidate the enemy forces that landed. If they don't have such reserves, then it is necessary to withdraw the main forces from the front to the North, leaving at the front a portion of the troops, which would be able to hold the adversary. It would be advisable to push the Americans out of the defense areas, make them disperse along the front and destroy part by part with maneuvering operations.

2. It is necessary to create the main attack group and keep it secret up to the decisive battles.

After this Zhou Enlai, on behalf of Mao Zedong, asked the Soviet government to share all available precise information about the situation in Korea.

Zhou Enlai characterized the latest development in Korea as extremely important in the political sense. Everybody knows, Zhou Enlai said, that the USSR and PRC stand for a peaceful solution of the Korean problem and that's why they insist on China's admission to the United Nations. At this point the Chinese leadership wants to consult with the Soviet Union on how to act under the present circumstances. From Beijing's point of view, until the end of the presidential elections Americans will continue to prevent China's representation at the UN. However, if this changes, then the Chinese delegation will be ready to participate at the UN session.

Zhou Enlai added that the U.S.A., Britain and France are extremely worried about the possibility of the entrance of the USSR and the PRC into combat activities in Korea. They are not ready to conduct a long and full-scale war in Korea. It would be good to use this fear and take steps to reinforce such fears. For example, if China moved some troops from its Southern provinces to Manchuria, then the governments of Britain and the United States would get very worried.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Zhou Enlai requested an urgent relay of his remarks to the Soviet government and an urgent reply from Moscow to the questions that had been raised by the Chinese side.

I assured him it will certainly be done. I also suggested that in order to overcome misunderstandings between Chinese and Korean comrades it is worthwhile to send a responsible comrade to Korea on a fact-finding mission⁴⁷

On September 20, 1950 a reply came from the Kremlin to the questions raised by Zhou Enlai. The cable said:

“... Of course, it is not normal and correct that the North Korean leadership does not properly inform their Chinese comrades about the development of combat activities in Korea. We don’t think, however, that Kim Il Sung did not want to inform Chinese comrades about the developments. Rather, this information was not provided, due to the lack of the proper communications with the front. To be frank, Moscow also received from its Ambassador in Pyongyang only sporadic and outdated data about the front. All this is rooted in the shortcomings of the KPA. It is a young and inexperienced army; its command has very weak communications with the troops. Information from the front moves badly and is not analyzed on time.

It is not, however, and we’d like to stress it again, a real fault of the KPA. The army, as well as the “Communist Party” of Korea, are very young. The army has just 3 months of war experience. Under such circumstances one can only be surprised that Koreans have scored such impressive successes in a war against perfectly equipped foreign troops.

The defeat at Inchon can be explained that the KPA had to deal not only with Syngman Rhee, but with the Anglo-American army. If North Koreans fought only with Syngman Rhee, then they would not have lost Inchon and Korea would long ago have been cleansed of the reactionaries.

We agree with our Chinese comrades on their assessment of the overall war situation in Korea. Here we’d like to add the following:

1. In the present complicated situation in the areas of Inchon and Seoul, the tactics employed by the KPA (pushing out the

⁴⁷ Roshin’s cable to Stalin, September 18, 1950.

adversary, using separate battalions and regiments) are wrong. It leads only to the elimination of engaged units, without solving the problem as a whole.

2. The problem can be solved only in case of withdrawal of serious forces from the main front and creation of a strong line of defense to the east and north of Seoul.

3. Peaceful solution of the Korean problem looks even more unachievable after the complication of the military situation, due to the landing of American troops in the area of Inchon. The Soviet delegation at the UN General Assembly will be defending proposals of the Soviet Union and China on the peaceful solution.

4. The Soviet side, like the Chinese side, believes that Americans will continue the policy of non-admittance of China to the UN. The Soviet delegation will continue to demand expulsion of Guomindang representatives from the UN⁴⁸

On September 21, 1950 Roshin delivered Stalin's reply to Zhou Enlai. Roshin reported to Moscow on his new meeting with Zhou Enlai:

"... Zhou Enlai thanked him for the information and expressed satisfaction that Chinese and Soviet appraisals of the situation in Korea did not differ. The Chinese representative said that on September 19, 1950 a cable went to Pyongyang with recommendations, which are practically identical to those expressed in the Soviet cable. On the same day the Chinese Ambassador in Pyongyang cabled back to Beijing that Kim Il Sung said that "the Korean people are ready for a long war." As Zhou noted, no other information has come from Korea...

... I asked Zhou Enlai what was the attitude towards events in Korea, among Chinese politically active circles of the population. Zhou Enlai explained that "in its essence the attitude is correct." Leaders of the democratic parties believe that the U.S.A. and Great Britain are not prepared to launch World War III. However, there are some democratic personalities who express dissatisfaction that after the landing operation at Inchon the war will be expanded and it will require certain sacrifice on the part of China"⁴⁹

⁴⁸ Cable from Stalin to Roshin for Mao Zedong, September 20, 1950.

⁴⁹ Roshin's cable to Stalin, September 21, 1950.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On September 21, 1950 Soviet Ambassador Roshin attended a dinner hosted by Liu Shaoqi in honor of Academician Yudin. Before the dinner Liu Shaoqi gave a detailed analysis of the attitudes of various circles of the Chinese society towards the Korean war.

On September 22, 1950 Roshin sent Stalin a summary of this analysis by Liu Shaoqi:

“... According to Liu Shaoqi former Guomindang activists live with the hope that the war in Korea will inevitably evolve into World War III. Americans will be victorious and Chiang Karshek will return to China. Of course, Liu Shaoqi emphasized, this, the most reactionary part of population, represents a clear minority

... Latest developments in Korea have scared big bourgeoisie. The influx of its money from Hong Kong to the PRC has slowed down. They are afraid of World War III and prefer to stay away from trouble spots. Even Hong Kong can become a trouble spot, so some of the money is now leaving Hong Kong and goes in various directions, outside of China.

A majority of workers, peasants and revolutionary intelligentsia believe that since North Koreans helped the Chinese revolution over a long period of time, now China must, in case of need, help North Korea. A majority of these people hate American imperialism.

Leaders of the democratic parties have assumed a wait-and-see attitude. They vote for the decisions of the government... but behind the scenes they express fears that World War III will start and China will have to suffer a lot again. After pervasive political propaganda in the armed forces, a majority of officers and soldiers have a positive attitude; their fighting spirit is high and they are ready, if necessary, to fight against the American imperialists. There is a prevailing view in the Chinese army that the combat readiness of American troops is not too high. In any case, it is lower than in the Japanese army. So Americans will be definitely defeated.

At the same time, there are those who think that China should not get involved in Korea. These people dream of leaving the army and of going back to their families after so many years of fighting. Some young soldiers are preoccupied with the solution

of personal problems. However, Liu Shaoqi noted that this mood is typical for only a small minority of soldiers and officers.

In the ruling circles of the CCP, there is a strong understanding that the Chinese revolution is not yet completed. The completion of this process will require a few more years. A fight with the American imperialists will only expedite the final victory, because Americans will be definitely defeated in the course of this fighting. The leading comrades believe that if Americans threaten North Koreans with a defeat, then the Chinese will have to help their Korean comrades.

Summarizing Liu Shaoqi stressed that on the whole Chinese society is hostile to American imperialism and it will be capable, in case of need, of successfully defeating the Americans. Enemies inside China, who will be against it, will undoubtedly be crushed"⁵⁰

On the same day, September 22, 1950, Academician Yudin had a conversation with Mao Zedong. The contents were reported by Roshin to Moscow on the same day.

"... Mao Zedong stressed that Truman made a grave mistake when at the end of June he talked about sending American troops to Korea and Taiwan in the same statement. Thus Truman expanded the framework of American aggression and put the British in an awkward position. On the one hand, they must support the American line in Korea. On the other hand, London had recognized People's Republic of China and could not support American aggression against that country. It seems that the British are trying to convince the Americans to look for a way out of the present situation in Asia. The development of military activities in Korea demonstrates that Americans are not ready now to conduct a protracted, large-scale war in Korea. It is a test of forces' an attempt to feel out how the USSR and China will behave; what will be the reaction of world public opinion?

Mao Zedong does not exclude that American imperialists will try to find a way out of the situation without serious repercussions, to achieve a compromise in Korea. In this connection it can be predicted that the Americans and British at the UN sessions will look for some possibility to allow China to be in the

⁵⁰ Roshin's cable to Moscow, September 22, 1950.

UN. This is only a supposition, but it can be justified by the fact that non-admittance of China to the UN and American aggression against Taiwan would turn Asian countries such as India and the Philippines against American imperialism.

Mao Zedong emphasized that Americans realize that until China is admitted to the UN, and until Chinese-American diplomatic relations are established, Beijing has a free hand and can openly take various steps against American imperialism in Asia...⁵¹

On October 1, 1950 Stalin came to the conclusion that China had to come to the rescue of the collapsing Kim Il Sung regime. On that day he sent a cable to the Soviet Ambassador in China for immediate delivery to Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai. The cable said:

"I am on vacation in a place far away from Moscow and I am a bit out of touch with events in Korea. However, judging by the information I received today from Moscow, I can see that the situation of the Korean comrades is becoming desperate.

Moscow, back on September 16, warned Korean comrades that the landing of Americans at Inchon had a significant meaning — that of cutting off and pursuit with the aim of cutting off, the first and second groups of North Koreans from their rear guards in the north. Moscow warned to withdraw immediately from the south at least four divisions, create a front to the north and east of Seoul, gradually pull a majority of Southern troops to the north and in such a manner secure the 38th parallel. However, the command of the 1st and 2nd army groups has not fulfilled the order of Kim Il Sung about pulling units to the north. This gave Americans the opportunity to cut off the troops and encircle them. In the area of Seoul, Korean comrades don't have any troops capable of resistance, and the road in the direction of the 38th parallel can be considered open.

I believe that if you, in the present situation, consider it possible to send troops to aid the Koreans, then you should without delay move them to the 38th parallel, at least 5–6 divisions in order to give Korean comrades a chance to organize, under protection of your troops, military reserves to the north from the 38th parallel. Chinese divisions could figure as volunteers, to be sure, with the Chinese command above them.

⁵¹ Cable from Roshin to Stalin, September 22, 1950.

I did not inform and I don't intend to inform Korean comrades about this, but I have no doubt that they'll be glad when they learn about it.

Waiting for your reply

Regards,

Philippov"⁵²

It did not take Mao Zedong long to react to this cable. On October 3, 1950 Soviet Ambassador forwarded to Stalin the following reply:

"I am reporting Mao Zedong's answer to your N 4581.

"Your cable of October 1, 1950 has been received. Initially we planned to deploy several volunteer divisions to North Korea to extend aid to Korean comrades, when the adversary starts moving to the north from the 38th parallel.

However, after thoroughly thinking it over, we believe now that such actions can bring about extremely serious repercussions.

First, with several divisions it is very difficult to solve the Korean issue (equipment of our troops is quite weak I there is no guarantee of the success of the military operation against American troops) and the adversary can force us to retreat.

Second, it is most possible that it will provoke an open clash between the U.S.A. and China, as a result of which the Soviet Union may also be dragged into a war. Thus the problem would become extremely large.

Many comrades in the CC/CCP believe that here prudence must be displayed.

Surely, not to send our troops for extending aid is very bad for our Korean comrades, who are now in such a complicated situation. We ourselves are quite concerned with this. If, however, we move several divisions and the adversary makes us retreat, and besides it will provoke an open clash between the U.S.A. and China, then our whole plan of peaceful construction will be completely ruined; very many people in the country will be unhappy (wounds, inflicted on people by war, have not been healed yet, peace is needed).

⁵² Stalin's cable to Beijing, October 1, 1950, State Archives, P 97-98. Coded message N 4581.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Therefore, it is better now to persevere; don't engage troops, prepare forces; it will be more favorable during the future war with the adversary

As for Korea, temporarily having been defeated, it will change the method of struggle, will rely on the guerrilla war.

We are summoning now a CC meeting, where responsible comrades from various CC bureaus will be present. No final decision has been adopted yet on this issue. This is our preliminary cable. We want to consult with you. If you agree, then we are ready to immediately send by plane comrades Zhou Enlai and Lin Biao to the place of your vacation, to discuss with you this matter and report the situation in China and in Korea.

Waiting for a reply,

Mao Zedong
October 2, 1950

1. Response of Mao Zedong from our point of view demonstrates a change in the initial position of the Chinese leadership on the Korean issue. It is the opposite of the previous appraisal, repeatedly expressed in conversations of Mao Zedong with Yudin, Kotov and Konnov; of Liu Shaoqi with me, about which we reported in due time. In those conversations they pointed out that the people and the New Liberation Army are ready to help the Korean people, the fighting spirit of the NLA is high and it is capable, if it is necessary, to deliver a defeat to the American troops, considering them to be weaker than Japanese.

2. The Chinese government undoubtedly could send to Korea not only five to six combat-capable divisions, but more. To be sure, these Chinese troops need some technical upgrading with anti-tank means and partially with artillery.

Reasons for the change in the Chinese position are not clear for us as yet. It can be guessed that in this particular case the present international situation and the worsening situation in Korea have influenced the Chinese. As well as tricks of the Anglo-American block through Nehru, calling for the Chinese to be patient and persevere in order to avoid a catastrophe. Roshin"⁵³

⁵³ Coded message N 25199, the 2nd Chief Directorate of the G-S of the Soviet armed forces, October 3, 1950.

On October 8, 1950 Stalin sent a letter to Kim Il Sung concerning China's participation in the Korean conflict⁵⁴ The letter said:

"The delay in responding to your request has been caused by Soviet-Chinese consultations on the matter.

On October 1, I asked Mao Zedong to send right away to Korea at least 5-6 divisions to cover Korea's efforts to form reserves. Mao Zedong reacted negatively to the request with a number of pretexts' that he did not want to pull the USSR into the war; that the Chinese army was weak in the technical sense; that the war could provoke strong opposition inside China.

I replied to Mao, pointing out that leading Chinese comrades had made a number of statements expressing their readiness to move several armies to Korea's support if the adversary crossed the 38th parallel. The readiness of Chinese comrades to send troops to Korea is rationalized by China's interest in preventing the transformation of Korea into a military springboard of the U.S.A. or for the future militaristic Japan against China.

I gave Mao Zedong my reasons for advising China's participation in the Korean war:

1) The United States, as events in Korea showed, is not ready now for a big war;

2) Japan, whose militaristic forces have not been restored as yet, is not capable of extending military assistance to the Americans;

3) The United States, because of this, will have to give in to China on the Korea issue, which is backed by its ally, the Soviet Union. The U.S.A. will agree on such conditions of the settlement of the Korean issue, which will be favorable for Korea and which won't allow the enemies to turn Korea into their military springboard;

4) Due to the same reasons, the United States will have to abandon not only Taiwan, but also forsake a separate peace with Japanese reactionaries, forsake their plans to restore Japanese imperialism and to turn Japan into its military springboard in the Far East.

⁵⁴ A letter from Stalin to Kim Il Sung, sent through the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang, October 8, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 65.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

China could not get all these concessions by waiting passively, without a serious struggle and a new impressive demonstration of its forces. Without all this, China will not get even Taiwan, which Americans are holding in their arms, not for Chiang Kai-shek, who does not have a chance of success, but for themselves or for the future militaristic Japan.

Even if the United States, not being ready for a big war, gets into such a war for prestige considerations, one should not be afraid, because China is connected to the USSR by the pact on mutual assistance. Together we'll be stronger than the United States and England. As for other capitalist European states, without Germany which cannot now extend any assistance to the United States, they don't represent any serious military force. If the war is inevitable, let it take place now rather than a few years later, when Japanese militarism will be restored by its U.S. ally, and when the U.S.A. and Japan will possess a ready military springboard on the continent in the form of Rhee's Korea.

Mao Zedong finally agreed with major points of our arguments. In a letter to me on September 7, 1950 Mao Zedong assured that he would send to Korea not six, but nine divisions; however, not now, but a little bit later, after a visit to Moscow of Chinese representatives for thorough discussions on the matter.

I agreed to receive the Chinese delegation. Meanwhile I call upon you to hold firm to every piece of your land, to strengthen resistance to the American invaders and to build up reserves, using military cadres of the Korean People's Army, who are getting out of the encirclement"⁵⁵

On October 12, 1950 Stalin informed Kim Il Sung of the following:

"The Chinese have again refused to send troops. Because of this you must evacuate Korea and retreat in the northern direction in the shortest possible period"⁵⁶

However, on the 13th new information from China came. Soviet Ambassador Roshin reported:

⁵⁵ A letter from Stalin to Kim Il Sung, sent through the Soviet Ambassador in Pyongyang, October 8, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 66.

⁵⁶ Stalin's cable to Kim Il Sung, October 12, 1950.

"Mao Zedong told me that the CC of the CCP discussed the Korean issue once again and decided to extend military aid to the Korean comrades, disregarding the insufficient armament of the Chinese troops.

Mao Zedong said:

"Our leading comrades believe that if the Americans get to the border of China, then Korea will remain for us a dark spot and the northeast will be constantly under a permanent threat.

Previous hesitations of our comrades existed because they did not have a clear picture of the international situation, as well as questions of provision of weapons from the side of the USSR and of cover from the air.

At the present time all these questions have been cleared."

Mao Zedong pointed out that now it is convenient to send troops to Korea. Chinese don't have a right not to send troops there.

At this point the first echelon consisting of 9 divisions, though poorly armed, can fight against Syngman Rhee's units. Meanwhile, Chinese comrades must speedily prepare the second echelon.

The main thing that is necessary for us, Mao Zedong said, is aviation, which must cover us. Its arrival we hope to get as soon as possible, not later than in two months.

Further on, comrade Mao Zedong pointed out that for the provided weapons the PRC cannot pay in cash at the present time. They hope to get the weapons on credit.

Thus the budget of 1951 will not be touched and we'll easily explain it to democrats.

In conclusion, Mao Zedong stated that leading comrades of the CC/CCP believe that the Chinese must help their Korean comrades in their difficult struggle, so Zhou Enlai must again discuss the issue with comrade Philippov. We are sending new instructions to Zhou Enlai.

Roshin

October 13, 1950⁵⁷

Stalin immediately informed Kim Il Sung:

⁵⁷ Coded message N 25629, Roshin to Stalin, October 13, 1950.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

“Just now I received a cable from Mao Zedong. He informs me that the CC of the CCP discussed the situation once again and finally decided to extend military aid to the Korean comrades, disregarding insufficient armament of the Chinese troops. In this connection I ask you to postpone temporarily evacuation of and retreat of Korean troops to the north”⁵⁸

On October 14, 1950 Stalin sends Kim Il Sung another cable on the matter, stating:

“After hesitation and a number of temporary decisions, Chinese comrades have made the final decision to help Korea with troops.

... In this connection recommendations of the proposed meeting of Chinese and Soviet leading comrades has to be considered cancelled. The issues of coordination and cooperation connected with the movement of Chinese troops you'll have to solve together with the Chinese comrades. The necessary equipment for the Chinese troops will be supplied by the USSR”⁵⁹

On October 15, 1950 Zhou Enlai, in Moscow on a secret mission, reported to Mao Zedong:

“Comrade Philippov (Stalin) did not express his objections against the decision of the Politburo of the CC of CCP not to get involved militarily in Korea”⁶⁰

On October 25, 1950, a member of the Chinese leadership, closely connected to the Russians, Gao Gang, told the Soviet Consul General in Mukden, Ledovsky, and General Vazhnov of the controversy in the Politburo of the CC of CCP over sending Chinese troops to Korea. The cable from the Consulate to Moscow said:

“As Gao Gang explained, after Zhou Enlai sent a cable from Moscow concerning the Korean War, a heated discussion started in the Chinese leadership as to Beijing's participation in this war.

⁵⁸ Stalin's cable to Kim Il Sung, October 13, 1950, Archives of the President of Russia, P 74-75.

⁵⁹ Coded message N 4829, October 14, 1950, The Second Chief Directorate, General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces, Archives of the President of Russia, P 77.

⁶⁰ Cited in the cable of Ambassador Roshin to Moscow, who in turn quotes a member of the Chinese leadership, Gao Gang, October 18, 1950.

At a special Politburo meeting devoted to this issue, Gao Gang had a tough argument with Zhou Enlai, who opposed sending Chinese volunteers to Korea.

Gao Gang convinced Peng Dehuai to jointly request Mao Zedong to move ahead in Korea immediately. They stressed that if it were not done, then real danger would occur for China and the whole international situation, because Americans would definitely occupy the entire territory of Korea. Gao Gang and Peng Dehuai emphasized two points:

1) If Americans occupy all of Korea, then China will be denied a pretext to send its troops there;

2) Americans will arm the Guomindang and finally will attack China. What is the usefulness of the victory of the Chinese revolution, if China does not act immediately against American aggression, but waits motionlessly until American imperialists attack China?

The energetic position of Gao Gang and Peng Dehuai was supported by other leaders of the CCP, and the Politburo decided to send troops to Korea"⁶¹

Ambassador Roshin reported to Moscow on October 25, 1950: "On October 24, 1950 a special meeting of the Chinese government, with participation of leaders of democratic parties, took place. The meeting was devoted to the attitude of China towards events in Korea. Zhou Enlai made the official report.

Representatives of the democratic parties in their speeches in general approved the government's position. Some of the representatives noticed that certain people are afraid that the United States is strong and China will be defeated. There even were opinions that China should accept seizure of Korea by the Americans. Even seizure of Manchuria by America should be tolerated. Because, some people said, in this case a war between the USSR and America will start, and China may have a chance to keep out of it.

Questions were asked as to why the USSR does not send troops to Korea together with China.

At the end of the meeting, Mao Zedong took the floor. He explained that Korea was the gateway to China. Japanese in the

⁶¹ Consul General Ledovsky's cable to Moscow, October 25, 1950.

past had occupied Korea and created there a springboard from which they later attacked China. The Chinese government cannot accept occupation of Korea by the Americans, because it would cause a serious threat to the security of China.

Mao Zedong also explained that there was no necessity for Soviet participation in Korean affairs. China and the USSR are allies and have very cordial and honest relations. If Americans attack China, the USSR will fulfill its obligations under the Sino-Soviet treaty, signed on February 14, 1950⁶²

Ambassador Shtykov on October 30, 1950 reported to Stalin that according to Moscow's instructions and agreement with the Chinese, nine army divisions from North Korea are being moved to Manchuria for formation and training purposes. By October 30, 1950, the following units had already crossed the border and were approaching the areas designated for them:

“1. Three army divisions, NN 69th, 68th, 67th, each with 10,000 personnel plus 5,000 personnel for special units, are moving to the area of Kwanku. Altogether there will be 35,000 personnel in that area.

2. To the area of Hailung, divisions NN 32nd, 37th, 75th are approaching, 10,000 persons each. Additionally, 6,000 persons are being sent from Kanggye, including 5,000 persons for special units.

3. Before November 5, 1950, 3 army divisions, 10,000 persons each and 5,000 persons for special units, will be located in the area of Yangtse.

4. In the Tonghwa area there will be an army school for 1,500 cadets.

5. In the area of Phenhwa, there is a training regiment of 1,500 persons. Shortly, it will be enlarged to 3,500 personnel.

6. In the future a fliers' school will be opened in the area of Yangtse for 2,600 fliers⁶³

Further on Ambassador Shtykov points out:

“The overall supervision of the troop training will be handled by the headquarters, with Defense Minister Choi Yong-keun in

⁶² Roshin's cable to Stalin, October 25, 1950.

⁶³ Coded message N 600584/sh, October 31, 1950, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Armed Forces of the Soviet Union, P 2-3.

charge. Officers of the divisions are young and inexperienced in training matters. I strongly request to leave 90 Soviet officers to help in training and formation of the divisions. Without them the Koreans won't be able to train the divisions for combat purposes even within a year"⁶⁴

After the entry of the Chinese "volunteers" into the Korean conflict the mood of Stalin and Kim Il Sung abruptly changed for the better. With every new success of the Chinese on the battlefield the appetites and arrogance of Stalin and his friends grew (though they did know their weak points and exchanged some complaints).

On November 7, 1950 Mao Zedong cabled to Stalin:

"Our forces in Korea rely mainly on weapons captured from the enemy. As a result there is a great variety of types and calibers of weaponry. It has created great difficulties for production of ammunition, especially for rifles and machine guns. The capacity of Chinese factories to produce the required ammunition is very limited...

At this moment the Chinese volunteer army has 36 divisions, organized into twelve armies, but there is ammunition enough for just six divisions. In case of a development of military actions we would encounter "very serious problems" with ammunition. If there is no change in military production, rearmament could be started only in the second part of 1951...

I ask you to supply weapons for thirty six divisions in January-February 1951" (a long list of requested weapons was attached)⁶⁵

On December 1, 1950 Stalin sent the following cable to Mao:

"Thank you for the information about the situation in China in connection with the successful offensive of the CPLA in Korea.

Your successes make me happy, not only for myself and my comrades in the leadership, but for all Soviet people as well. Let me congratulate, with all my heart, you and your friends in the leadership, the CPLA and all the Chinese people in connection with the tremendous success of their struggle against American troops.

⁶⁴ As above.

⁶⁵ Coded message N 26637, November 8, 1950, The Second Chief Directorate, General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces, P 80-81.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

I have no doubt that in a war against a modern and well-armed American army, the Chinese army will acquire a rich experience in modern warfare and will turn itself into a sufficiently modern, well-armed, powerful army, in the same manner as the Soviet army did in the struggle against the superbly-armed German army, and acquired the experience of modern warfare and turned itself into a modern, well-equipped army

Wishing you further successes,

Philippov⁶⁶

On December 4, 1950 Soviet Foreign Minister Gromyko met with Chinese Ambassador Wang Jiaxiang. In the memorandum of their conversation Gromyko wrote:

"... The Ambassador, on behalf of his government, inquired if it would be correct to state that after defeats in Korea disagreements started to grow in the Anglo-American camp and in the ruling circles of the U.S.A., that Washington got into a very precarious situation.

I answered that there were undoubtedly reasons for such a conclusion. I pointed to the publication of reports in the foreign media about disagreements between the British, on one side, and Americans, on the other side. I also mentioned that lately more and more often people voice their criticism of MacArthur and his actions, as well as the policies of Truman. I said that Americans cannot now hide their confusion, due to the unfavorable turn of events for them in Korea.

Wang Jiaxiang wanted to know my opinion about the readiness of the Americans under the present circumstances to agree on negotiations with China and the USSR on the Korea issue.

I answered that one can only guess about this, and that so far there have been no proposals from Americans about a peaceful settlement of the situation in Korea.

Stressing that he talks to me absolutely unofficially and on his own behalf, Wang Jiaxiang asked me if, from my point of view, it was desirable for Chinese troops, from a political point of view — in case of the successful continuation of the offensive — to cross the 38th parallel.

⁶⁶ Coded message N 9768, 8th section, 2nd Chief Directorate, General Staff, Soviet Army, December 1, 1950.

Stressing that it was my personal opinion, I suggested that the Chinese must exploit any opportunities which arose to the full extent. Wang Jiaxiang said that he shared the same view.

Further on, Wang Jiaxiang asked if they should expect new provocations from the Americans, for example, building up assistance to Chiang Karshek and landing operations in South Korea together with Chiang Karshek.

I said that I don't have any information on this account and can make only guesses.

... Quoting letters of soldiers from the Korean front, Wang Jiaxiang cited that Americans are bad fighters and fight much worse than the Japanese"⁶⁷

On December 7, 1950 Stalin advised the Chinese:

"We are completely in agreement with your conditions for a cease-fire in Korea. We believe that without satisfaction of these conditions military activities cannot be stopped.

At the same time, we think that one should not be too frank and open right away, and lay his cards before the representatives of three states, who in fact are agents of the U.S.A. We don't think the time is right for China to show its cards until Seoul is liberated. Moreover, conditions in China can be used by the U.S.A. as a slap at the decisions of the UN. You should not give this advantage to the U.S.A.

Therefore, we believe that at this time we can limit ourselves to the following:

1) The Chinese government, and delegates of England, Sweden, India, would welcome the completion of military actions in Korea. China will do its best to complete as soon as possible the military actions forced on Korea and China.

2) Therefore, we'd like to learn the opinion of the UN and the U.S. on the conditions of the armistice ..."⁶⁸

On January 4, 1951 Mao gave Stalin a copy of Peng Dehuai's cable of January 3, 1951. It said:

⁶⁷ Memorandum of a conversation between A. Gromyko and Ambassador Wang Jiaxiang, December 4, 1950. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-3.

⁶⁸ Coded message N 23343, December 7, 1950, Message of Stalin to Zhou Enlai.

“... Our troops, advancing at the front to Yangyang in the east to Munsan in the west cut the defense line of the adversary. The adversary began to retreat along the entire front. Resistance is not strong; the adversary is running quickly to the south, so its losses are not great. Up to 12:00 January 3, 1951 we've captured 3,000 prisoners, 150 vehicles and tanks and over 100 artillery pieces. However, it is possible that by pursuing the adversary we'll be able to hold and destroy a portion of the enemy troops.

... Main forces of 38th, 39th and 40th armies are actively preparing, and after finding out the situation in the regions of Seoul and Yangpyong, will choose a convenient moment to cross the river of Bukhankang in the area of Chungpyong and Masuguri. The Southern army... is conducting test fighting in the direction of Seoul...

Afterwards, as a result of this operation, we'll occupy the cities of Seoul, Inchon, Suwon, Ichon, Yangpyong and Hongchon. Our troops will stop the offensive and will have a period of rest for reinforcement and restructuring”⁶⁹

On January 8, 1951 Mao passed a cable from the military commanders to Kim Il Sung:

“... 1. 116th infantry division and some troops of the 117th infantry division today (4 January) occupied Seoul. Troops of the adversary retreated to the southern bank of the Han River... It is possible that the adversary, relying on natural frontiers like the Han River and mountainous areas, will collect the remnants of its forces, bide its time and prepare for new combat activities...

2. If we allow the adversary to hold defense along the Southern bank of the Han River, control Kimpo Airport and use the port of Inchon for supplies, then... Seoul will be constantly threatened by the planes and artillery of the adversary, and this is extremely inconvenient for preparation of our troops for the spring offensive.

If... our troops push the adversary from the southern bank of the Han River, then we will not only take over Kimpo Airport and will get control of Inchon, but will get a more favorable position for the spring offensive...

⁶⁹ Coded message N 15120, January 1, 1951. Mao to Stalin.

... If the adversary continues to retreat in the southern direction, and sits on its heels, we must seize Suwon and then wait for further instructions... Peng Dehuai, Kim Woong, Park Il-wu.

24:00. 4 January⁷⁰

Upon having read this cable Stalin wrote the following:

"I've read the proposal of Peng Dehuai and other comrades to Kim Il Sung on January 4. From the point of view of Philippov the proposal is correct; it has to be implemented.

With all my heart I congratulate you on the capture of Seoul. This is a great victory for popular-patriotic forces over forces of reaction"⁷¹

On January 16, 1951 Mao Zedong sent the following cable to Kim Il Sung:

"... Those approximately 100,000 Korean recruits, being trained now in northeast China, in the course of the next 2-3 months ... have to be included into various corps of the People's Army in order that each company has over 100 persons and each division has 10-15,000 persons.

In the Korean army there are too many units of division and brigade size. It is necessary to concentrate all personnel into 15 divisions (approximately) and provide them with Soviet weapons. Then these Korean divisions will be able ... to extend considerable support to the Chinese volunteers during the spring offensive (April/May) with the aim of a final solution of the South-Korean issue.

In the next two-three months Chinese volunteers and Korean troops have to do serious and large-scale work: to complete the units with new soldiers, to make them learn from the experience of the old soldiers, to build-up armament for the troops, to restore railroads, to stock foodstuffs and ammunition ...

One can foresee that the adversary command will have only two options in the future:

1. Under pressure... it will not resist strongly and will leave Korea. It can happen if the adversary learns about our thorough preparatory work and comes to the conclusion that we've become even stronger. Being scared of the difficulties, they'll leave Korea.

⁷⁰ Coded message N 15227, January 7, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

⁷¹ *Ibid.*

2. The adversary will fight doggedly in the region of Pusan-Taegu until it realizes that resistance is futile and only after that it will leave Korea.

If it is so, then we have to get prepared well... Otherwise we may repeat the mistakes committed by the Korean troops from June to September, 1950.

One cannot exclude that objective reasons will make us implement one operation in February and after that we'll need rest and restructuring again in order to get prepared for the final operation...

Chinese and Korean comrades must be patient and make the necessary preparations"⁷²

On January 19, 1951 Peng Dehuai responded to Mao Zedong: "... I am informing you of the results of my meeting with Kim Il Sung.

1. Comrade Kim Il Sung and his comrades believe that for only the North Korean Army to pursue the American and puppet troops retreating to the south is impossible. It will have an adventurist character.

... They argue that rest and restructuring of the troops is necessary for two months in order to start a careful, unhurried advance in the future. Comrade Park Hon-young had a different opinion, but after my second explanation... he was satisfied.

The Soviet adviser also agreed that the new operation would be decisive, therefore with the consent of the Politburo of the Korean Workers' Party, it must be conducted better.

2. The defense of the seashore.

... From the USSR we have received 1,000 sea mines and 20,000 anti-tank and other mines. So far, it has been decided to use 100,000 mines for the defense of the seashore, and to set sea mines in the most important ports. Defense of the seashore to the south of Suwon-Samchok will be the responsibility of the vanguard forces. Defense of the port Yongampo (near Sinuiju) they ask to give to the troops of the military district of northeast Korea (one regiment will be enough)... Please consider the issue.

⁷² Coded message N 15608, January 16, 1951. A copy of Mao's cable sent to Kim Il Sung, forwarded to Stalin through the Soviet Embassy in China.

3. The issue of finishing completion of five corps. It was decided that each corps has to consist of three divisions. At the present time, all five corps, with the exception of the 1st, have 4 to 5 divisions. However, these divisions are not complete; each has 3-4-5,000 persons... I proposed to disperse among five armies 20,000 persons from those South Korean soldiers who had been taken prisoner, but they did not agree with me.

As for my proposal to complete three existing corps with three new corps they have not agreed with it as well...

4. Sufficient numbers of cadres for the work in newly liberated areas have not been prepared.

In Seoul, earlier there was a population of 1,500,000 persons. At present there are possibly still 1,000,000 persons. There are serious shortages of food and fuel. No aid is extended to refugees and the unemployed. KPA and Chinese volunteer troops have minimum foodstuffs. In the areas to the west of Haeju and to the south of Sariwon large bands operate. They've captured some population centers... We've agreed to send... troops to eliminate these bands... Thus, by eliminating these bands, we'll be able to get several dozen tons of foodstuffs.

An agreement was reached on strengthening the areas we control, demoralization of the adversary; preparation for the spring sowing in North Korea; extending aid to refugees; development of a political offensive in the areas temporarily occupied by American and puppet troops; setting up military groups, which will penetrate to the rear of the adversary and will conduct legal and underground forms of struggle, hitting the most reactionary elements; extending aid to progressive elements... How to organize all these activities will be clearer only later"⁷³

By the end of January, 1951, as documents testify, the euphoria of the Communists started to decline and quite soon it disappeared and was replaced with worries, fear, confusion and at times panic. Reading the documents, one also feels growing irritation among the ranks of the Communist allies.

What is also apparent is that Stalin tried to keep the USSR as much as possible from direct participation in the war. If he

⁷³ Coded message N 15994, January 21, 1951. A copy of Peng Dehuai's letter to Mao sent to Stalin.

agreed to send Soviet advisers, pilots and other military personnel to Korea, once in a while, he did it every time only after repeated pleas by Mao and Kim and quite reluctantly Stalin, as well, not always satisfied the requests of his allies for supplies of armament, but for objective reasons (they wanted more than the USSR, still weak after World War II and engaged in the world-wide Cold War, could provide).

On January 28, 1951 Mao Zedong informed Stalin of the changed plans for military action, due to an offensive by the adversary. Mao wrote:

“At the present time American troops are attempting to advance to the Seoul and Inchon areas of the southern bank of the Han River... Consequently, our troops lack an opportunity to continue the rest and restructuring and have to start immediate preparations for the 4th operation. I am sending you a copy of my cable to Peng Dehuai of January 28, 1951.

I ask you to acquaint yourself with the situation and inform us of your opinion, if it is advisable from the international point of view:

“Comrade Peng Dehuai!

1. I have received your cable of January 1, 1951 with your order to all armies on the preparation of the military operation.

2. Our troops must immediately prepare for the 4th operation in order to defeat 20-30,000 American and puppet troops and to occupy the area to the north from the Taejon-Andong line.

3... It is necessary to hold Inchon, the southern bank of the Han River and the city of Seoul... After the start of the operation the main forces of North Korean and Chinese troops must cut the enemy's line of defense in the area of Wonju and continue the offensive in the direction of Yongju and Andong.

4. Retreat of Chinese and North Korean troops for 15–30 km to the north and publication of a report about support for the proposal on the temporary cease-fire is not profitable for us, because the adversary hopes to stop military actions only when our troops withdraw a certain distance to the north and the adversary can blockade the Han River.

5. After the end of the 4th operation, the adversary perhaps will conduct peaceful negotiations with us on the solution of the

Korean issue. Then the negotiations will be profitable for China and Korea.

... 7 After our troops occupy the area to the north of Taejon-Andong, they will again have to conduct two-three months of preparation and then implement the last, the fifth operation of the decisive nature..."⁷⁴

Stalin responded to Mao's cable of January 28 (N 16052):

"I've received your cable of January 28, addressed to Peng Dehuai. I agree with you. From an international point of view it is undoubtedly advisable that Inchon and Seoul are not captured by the adversary, that Chinese-Korean troops give a serious rebuff to the advancing troops of the adversary"⁷⁵

On January 30, 1951 Stalin sends a cable to Kim Il Sung and a copy to Mao Zedong, proposing that both leaders discuss the followings

"1. It is an undeniable fact that present Korean divisions have less fighting capacity than the old divisions had last summer. It can be explained by the fact that at that time the Koreans had 10 divisions, well-staffed with officers and trained more or less well. And now the Koreans have 28 divisions, of which 19 divisions are at the front, and 9 divisions are in Manchuria. It is quite understandable that the Koreans are not capable of staffing so many divisions with officers. It is clear that Koreans still don't have an adequate number of officers. That's why Korean divisions are diluted, unstable and inefficient. Koreans got carried away with the numbers and forgot about quality, which plays the decisive role here.

2. Under such circumstances, it will be advisable to leave in the Korean army no more than 23 divisions. The officer corps of the reduced five divisions can be used to strengthen the remaining weak divisions. The soldiers may be utilized as reinforcements. Such measures will strengthen the divisions, will cut expenditures and save weapons. The same can be said about the four Korean army brigades, which have little fighting capacity and whose officers and soldiers can be used to strengthen other divisions.

⁷⁴ Coded message N 16052, January 29, 1951, Mao's cable to Stalin.

⁷⁵ Coded message N 633, January 30, 1951, From Stalin to Mao.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

3. At this stage it is not advisable to set up the corps' administrations, because there are no (or almost no) officers, capable of commanding a corps. And the army administrations exist already. It is better to organize 5 army administrations, with 4 divisions in each army, so that the army apparatus could directly command its divisions. In such a case, the Korean armed forces could include 5 armies (totally 20 divisions)⁷⁶

The Soviet Ambassador on the following day reported to Stalin:

"I am reporting my own opinion, because with the death of Kim Chaek, Kim Il Sung is very distressed and I'll be able to learn about their views later.

1. Your orders are completely correct and they reflect the level of training of cadres of the KPA as well as raising combat capability and armament of the divisions.

2. Measures are already being taken to reduce the number of divisions...

4. Your criticism that Koreans got carried away with the numbers and forgot about quality is just, but to help now is difficult.

5. ... Situation with the navy is bad, one can see here the lack of any calculations ... Only three ships are left and all of them are based in the USSR. For manning all ships, a maximum 1,000 persons are needed, while we are now training 3,000 persons. In addition, the General Staff of the Korean navy has 1,000 persons. I cannot sort things out with "the large fleet" in 1.5 months...

It is advisable to eliminate navy brigades and send then-personnel to the front because they have too many officers in the reserve.

The above mentioned measures I kept on postponing because neither the Chinese nor the Koreans want to do anything about the sea defense and navy bases.

... Not only the seamen are affected by "gigantomania," but all other military services as well — all of them are trying to copy us.

... 6. Without undermining the confidence of the Soviet military advisers I am trying to reduce the numbers and fight against "gigantomania."

⁷⁶ Coded message N 651, January 30, 1951, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Armed Forces of the Soviet Union.

Here in Korea they have a habit of forming everything without calculations and plans.

7 The corps' introduction is not timely; it is possible only after the war.

... 10. Your orders about a gradual reduction and uplifting of quality will be implemented, but gradually, as we have pauses in the war.

... 13. I have stopped the graduation of officers without 6 months of training.

Officers, who don't have military education, will be transferred step by step to the reserve (it applies to the commanders of platoons and companies)...⁷⁷

Stalin, however, was not happy with the above mentioned reply of the Ambassador. On February 3, 1951 Stalin sent a cable to the Embassy in Pyongyang:

"You have not understood my cable of January 30 about Korean divisions. This cable is not a directive, but my proposal for discussion with Korean comrades. I asked you to give me the opinion of Korean comrades and your own... I ask you again to show my cable to Kim Il Sung and his friends and after that inform me of the opinion of the Koreans"⁷⁸

On February 4, 1951 the Soviet Ambassador informed Stalin about the reaction of the North Korean leadership to his proposal for restructuring the KPA. As could be expected, Kim Il Sung agreed with Stalin's view. His conclusion was:

"1. For raising combat capability of the troops and improvement of their quality, it is necessary to cut the number of army administrations and the number of divisions.

2. Reduction of army administrations and divisions will be implemented after the arrival of three army administrations from Manchuria...

3. Navy brigades are to be kept temporarily for defense of the bases and the coast.

⁷⁷ Coded message N 500316/sh, January 31, 1951, From the Soviet Embassy in Pyongyang to Stalin.

⁷⁸ Coded message N 10031, February 3, 1951, Stalin to the Soviet Embassy.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

For strengthening Navy brigades, a drastic reduction should be implemented of the Navy administration, seamen's school and the staff of the fleet commander.

4. Further reduction is to be conducted after the next operation, which will start February 7-13, 1951.

5. The overall number of army formations and divisions will be in the limits recommended by you"⁷⁹

On February 5, 1951 Peng Dehuai responded to Mao's cable of January 28, 1951, proposing a change in tactics (see above, coded message N 16052, January 29, 1950, Mao's cable to Stalin):

"... Comrade Kim Il Sung fully agrees with the plan, which provides for stopping the present offensive of the adversary with all available means, restoration of the military situation in our favor and conducting intensive preparation for serious military actions over a prolonged period of time. Simultaneously, comrade Kim Il Sung said that the temporarily high morale of the troops, as a result of easily won battles in the previous three operations, has disappeared.

Completion of the corps of the People's Army from the five dissolved divisions will be done after the end of the forthcoming operation.

After the operation comrade Kim Il Sung proposes to go with me to Beijing"⁸⁰

On February 10, 1951 the Soviet navy commander reported to Stalin:

"According to an intelligence report of the 5th Navy fleet on February 9, 1951, starting from February 7 cypher radio exchange between the commander of the U.S. Navy in the Far East and commanders of navy units has noticeably increased. There is an active radio exchange between American ships, patrolling near the western shore of Korea, and the commander of the 2nd group of the 90th formation (this group includes transport for carrying troops and armament for landing operations). Ships

⁷⁹ Coded message N 500361/sh, February 2, 1951, the Soviet Embassy in Pyongyang to Stalin.

⁸⁰ Coded message N 16480, February 9, 1951, Copy of Peng's cable to Mao, sent by Mao to Stalin.

from this group left Yokosuka and at 6:00 a.m. on February 9, 1951 were seen in the Bungo Strait.

On February 9, from the area of the eastern shore to the western shore, moved a number of American battle ships ... All this gives us reason to believe that the Americans are preparing for a landing operation on the western coast of Korea"⁸¹

Situation for the Communists continued to deteriorate. The following cable from Mao to Stalin, sent on March 1, 1951, clearly testifies to this:

"Comrade Philippov,

I am informing you of our opinions, formed during my conversation with comrade Dehuai, when he was in Beijing:

1. The development of the latest military operations in the Korean theater of military activities shows that until a majority of the enemy's troops is defeated, the adversary won't leave Korea. And to defeat a majority of the adversary's troops a certain time will be required. Therefore, it is possible that military actions in Korea will take on an extended character. We must plan the fighting for at least two years.

At the present time, the adversary is trying to engage us in a war of exhaustion. During the last month, the adversary, after completing its troop restructuring, used a convenient moment for offensive battles of an intelligence character. The adversary's aim was, on the one hand, not to allow our troops to get rest and reinforcements; on the other hand, to use its superiority in arms to wage a war of exhaustion. Simultaneously, the adversary's ships actively attacked coastal areas of Korea, and enemy air force incessantly bombed our communication lines. Out of the material reinforcements sent to the front only 60–70% were received, the rest were destroyed by enemy air raids.

Since our new troops have not arrived at the front, and our old troops have not received reinforcements, it is possible that in the course of the next month and a half the adversary will again launch offensive actions in the area of the 38th parallel.

2. In order to frustrate the enemy's plans, to achieve prolongation of military actions for a long time... our Chinese volunteer troops intend to use the tactics of consecutive utilization of its

⁸¹ Coded message N 350 cc, February 10, 1951.

forces. We've already made the decision to set up three groupings of volunteer troops which will conduct military actions one after another. The nine corps (thirty divisions), fighting in Korea now, will be the first group. We are moving six corps now from China to join the three corps, stationed in Korea, ... to create the second group (nine corps, twenty seven divisions).

The second group will replace the first one, fighting near the Han River, in the beginning of April.

The third group, formed also partly from the new troops, based now in China (ten corps, thirty divisions), will be used at the front around June.

... Losses of Chinese volunteer troops in the course of the previous four operations, and peripheral battles, (killed, wounded or disabled for other reasons) have reached over 100,000 persons. To fill the gap we'll use 120,000 old soldiers and new recruits. We believe that now and next year we'll lose an additional 300,000 troops. Thus we'll have to have reinforcements of 300,000 men in order to back up the tactics of subsequent utilization of forces in the war.

As for the Korean People's Army, comrade Peng Dehuai, on the basis of your proposals, advised comrade Kim Il Sung to reduce the present eight corps to six corps. It is advisable to have three complete divisions in each corps, 10,000 persons in each division. Besides, Kim Il Sung was advised to have five brigades to guard the seashore and main cities.

Comrade Kim Il Sung in principle agrees with this. Thus, Koreans will also be able to utilize the tactics of consecutive fighting and assist Chinese volunteer troops.

3. The experience of fighting in January-February showed... that we, without having the reserves, could not hope for the success of the operation. After the adversary sent in reinforcements we could not fight against him. Besides, as we kept on moving to the south, the lines of communications continued to stretch, difficulties with supplies grew and we had to leave troops behind for protection of the rear. Therefore, without destruction of a significant number of the adversary's troops and without any air cover it will be difficult for us to defeat the enemy piece by piece, if the adversary is pushed to the south too quickly

The situation is such that until the arrival at the front of the 9 corps of the second group of volunteers in the beginning of April, superiority in ground troops will be on the side of the adversary, so we must avoid an operational offensive. We should try... to stop the advancing adversary... In the next month and a half, the adversary may seize the opportunity to launch an offensive.

If the adversary captures Seoul and crosses the 38th parallel again, it will create certain chaos; we have to be prepared for this ahead of time.

4. At the present time the difficulties of the war in Korea are many; the adversary has superior fire power; our transportation capabilities are weak; we are losing 30-40% of our supplies as a result of air raids because we don't have anti-air defense; the enemy will periodically receive reinforcements...

We hope in April-May to get the participation of ten aviation regiments in the battles; however, up to now there is no suitable airfield. Since snow is still on the ground, we cannot start repair work.

Comrade Peng Dehuai feels it is desirable that Soviet planes take the responsibility for covering airfields in Korea. For this purpose, it is advisable that Soviet planes move... to airfields in the territory of Korea.

According to comrade Peng Dehuai, if the airfields are not restored... Chinese planes won't be able to fight in Korea and movements of tanks and artillery will encounter serious difficulties. However, it is necessary to solve this problem on the basis of the general international situation. So we don't know if it is allowed to proceed in such a way.

... So our troops must prepare for long-term military actions. Over a period of several years we must defeat...

American troops and force the Americans to move their troops out of Korea. Only then can the Korean problem be solved.

Waiting for your... instructions.

With a Bolshevik hello

Mao Zedong⁸²

Stalin wrote to Chinese leaders on March 15, 1951.

⁸² Coded message N 17255, Mao to Stalin, March 2, 1951.

"As can be seen, Chinese and Korean liberation troops will soon have large scale military operations. Obviously, you'll be in need in of large quantities of planes, both at the front and in the rear... We accepted your proposal to move Belov's planes to Korea, to the rear of your troops, but on the condition that two Chinese fighter-plane divisions be deployed in the area of Antung for cover of this region. However, we see nowadays that due to the forthcoming large-scale operations you'll have to have as many fighter planes as possible. That's why we've decided to transfer from the USSR to Antung an additional big fighter division in order that two Chinese divisions, meant for covering Antung, can be sent to the front...

We hope you won't object"⁸³

Mao replied on the 18th of March:

"Thank you for the decision to transfer two Soviet fighter-plane divisions under General Belov to Korea, and also for an additional big fighter division for Antung"⁸⁴

On March 23, 1951 Zhou Enlai pursued the same subject:

"... Our air-defense artillery is insufficient to cover all important railway bridges and six airfields, which will be built for Soviet and Chinese planes in Korea.

... We propose that railway bridges from Antung to Anju: and four airfields, meant for Soviet planes, should be covered by Soviet air defense artillery units.

All the rest of the railway bridges and airfields on the Korean territory will be covered by Chinese units"⁸⁵

On April 12, 1951, the Soviet General Staff recommended to Stalin:

"To cover airfields by deployment of Soviet air force units in Korea and China with our air defense artillery.

... Since artillery will be used basically to cover our fighters, it is advisable to concentrate their command in the hands of General Belov..."⁸⁶

⁸³ Coded message N 1749, March 15, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

⁸⁴ Coded message N 17834, March 18, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

⁸⁵ Coded message N 17994, March 23, 1951, Zhou to Stalin.

⁸⁶ Coded message N 646007, April 12, 1951, Marshals Vasilevsky, Shtemenko to Stalin.

On May 22, 1951 Stalin informed Mao Zedong:

"Air battles on the border between Manchuria and North Korea have completely convinced us that Mig-9s... are no match to best the jet fighters and moreover Americans and British bombers.

... In order that Chinese fighter-planes could be efficient, it is necessary to change the Mig-9s for the Mig-15s. We'll have to supply you with 372 Mig-15s... We are able to do it now. You'll receive them free of charge, with the payment only for the transportation from the USSR to China through the overall military credit. You can keep Mig-9s for training fliers"⁸⁷

After receiving Mao's thanks for such generosity, Stalin wrote:

"Thank you very much, comrade Mao Zedong, for your gratitude.

... The main thing, though, is that we Russians made a mistake, believing that the Mig-9s could compete with the best jet planes of the Anglo-Americans... The meaning of this mistake is that it can harm the air defense of China, if the mistake is not corrected. Because we are fully responsible for this mistake, we think it is our duty to eradicate the mistake, by changing planes free of charge for China. Having as an aim the strengthening of defense of our ally — China, we could not act any differently"⁸⁸

On May 27, 1951, Mao gives new instructions to Peng Dehuai:

"All previous combat operations demonstrated that in conducting big-scale strategic and tactical operations of encircling several divisions or one division or even one regular regiment of American troops our troops had difficulties. It is because American troops still have a rather high combat spirit and self-assurance (*confidence*).

To squelch their arrogance and achieve their encirclement and destruction, you should not try... to destroy big quantities of the adversary in each operation.

... Tactics of conducting war against Anglo-American troops and puppet troops should not be the same. Against puppet troops large-scale operations are possible.

Against Anglo-American troops a number of small operations will finally lead to reduction of the enemy's combat spirit and self-

⁸⁷ Coded message, N 1713, May 23, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

⁸⁸ Coded message, N 322c. May 26, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

confidence... In order to finish the stage of destroying small forces of the adversary and to turn to mass destruction of the adversary we'll have to conduct several other small-scale operations.

... It is better to conduct these operations as much to the north as possible..., but the adversary should not be allowed north of the Pyongyang-Wonsan line”⁸⁹

On May 29, 1951 Stalin criticized and rejected the plan of military actions proposed by Mao Zedong. Mao's idea was to advance suddenly and quickly to the south, and then, as quickly, to withdraw back to the north.

Stalin said:

“This tactic is a risky one; it can be applied successfully only once or twice. The British and Americans will easily understand the plan; they'll be able to change their tactics and they will not allow you each time to withdraw to the north without damage to the forces.

The tactics could be used once again, but only if the attackers had first-class defense facilities in the rear, where the main forces might be speedily removed. However, as far as I know, there are no such facilities in Korea. That's why there is a danger that the Anglo-Americans, guessing your intentions, will not allow you to maneuver. And it won't be difficult for Anglo-Americans to guess your plan, because it seems you are going to utilize it for the fourth time.

Advancing to the north, the Anglo-Americans will be constructing one new defense line after another. This fact will impede any attack from the north. The Anglo-American front can be cut only with tremendous losses, and this is, of course, undesirable.

I disagree with your references to the civil war of the Chinese Communists against Chiang Kai-shek. Here, first of all, you are dealing with different troops; second, there is no reason to believe that Anglo-Americans are as stupid as Chiang Kai-shek and that they'll permit you to exterminate their battalions one by one according to your choice.

If Pyongyang is surrendered to the adversary once again, it will not only lead to the collapse of Koreans' and Korean troop morale, but it will simultaneously boost the morale of the Anglo-American troops. It seems that you'll have to prepare a very big

⁸⁹ Coded message N 20147, May 27, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

and serious operation, not, of course, for local maneuvers, but for a serious strike against the Anglo-American troops”⁹⁰

In June the mood of the Communists declined further. Peng Dehuai wrote to Mao Zedong on June 4, 1951.

“... At the present time the adversary uses large quantities of artillery, tanks and air power; there are no solid defense positions there... However, utilizing an active maneuvering defense, we can hold on at some points for some time...

... By the end of July we'll probably have more rifles, anti-tank and air-defense weapons, communication lines will be shorter... Then we should actively develop the guerrilla struggle. If the adversary doesn't increase its troops on a large scale and we don't make unpredictable mistakes, then we'll keep control of the advantageous area to the south of the Wonsan-Pyongyang line...

... In light of the fact that the adversary has large quantities of troops... planes, tanks and strong artillery as well as a rather high fighting spirit... up to now the question of tactics for beating the adversary bit by bit has not been solved as yet.

... It is necessary to launch a guerrilla war in the enemy's rear, disperse forces of the adversary... As yet guerrilla units have not been sent to the enemy's rear. It is necessary to wait for the moment when the adversary moves ahead and then send the guerrillas to the rear”⁹¹

On the same day Mao forwarded to Stalin a copy of Peng Dehuai's order to his troops:

“... The front is too stretched; there is a lack of transportation; there are difficulties in food supply and ammunition; our troops are very tired; any advancement in the southern direction is extremely inconvenient for us. That's why we decided to complete the second stage of the 5th operation before the planned time and retreat to where we started the 1st stage of the 5th operation. There we'll need 1.5 to 2 months to put the troops in order, reinforce them and train them for the conduct of new combat activities.

⁹⁰ Coded message N 3282, May 29, 1951, the 8th Directorate of the General Staff, Armed Forces of the Soviet Union, Archives of the President of Russia, P 1.

⁹¹ Coded message N 20406, June 4, 1951, to Stalin from Mao, a copy of Peng Dehuai's cable.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

... During this period of time the headquarters of the volunteer troops intends to conduct the following activities.

... 2. Liquidate a serious rightist mood, which exists nowadays in our troops.

... 4. Acquire enough planes, anti-tank reserves and anti-air artillery to take part in the fighting in Korea.

5. Organize and prepare the guerrilla struggle in the rear of the enemy, expand the front to exhaust and disperse the enemy forces. It will create advantageous conditions for our main forces in the course of further operations.

... Our troops, after advancing 6—7 days, have started to feel the shortage of food and ammunition and they have become tired. The adversary, having prepared in advance a large number of mechanized troops, using the pause in our offensive, and exploiting the retreat of our troops, began a serious pursuit. We had not counted on such a situation.

... Our troops, moving on foot, are not capable of escaping from the advancing motorized troops of the adversary.

That's why, while conducting an active maneuvering defense, it is necessary to have not only the first line of defense, but also the second and third lines of defense so that if the situation deteriorates at the first line, we would be able to deter it at the second and third lines.

... Troops newly arrived in Korea don't have the experience to fight a war against the technically well equipped adversary, especially the experience of conducting defensive battles. The quality of their lower ranking commanders is quite poor...

... At the present time in the fighting against the technically well-equipped adversary, simple courage is not enough; we need courageous and reasonable leadership. Only through this method can we achieve victory...

... Comrade Mao Zedong calls upon us to... defeat the adversary by small-scale battles, make him weak, lower his fighting spirit in order to turn slowly to the mass-scale defeat of the adversary... This is the most expedient tactic for defeating the enemy now, in the period of his adventurist offensive"⁹²

⁹² Coded message N 20412, June 4, 1951, A cable from Mao to Stalin.

Part III

The Conclusion

Encountering growing difficulties at the front, sustaining unbearable human and material losses China and North Korea began in the summer of 1951 to call for an armistice.

On June 5, 1951 Mao Zedong requests advice and instructions from Stalin. In a cable sent on that day he says:

“Comrade Philippov,

In the process of conducting a war in Korea we are confronted with such serious problems as the financial issue, the problem of conducting military operations directly at the front, the issue of a danger of landing operations by the adversary on the coast to our rear

We are considering the possibility of sending by plane Comrade Gao Gang to Moscow one of these days. He will inform you concerning the above-mentioned issues and will request your instructions on resolving these important issues. Presently comrade Kim Il Sung is in Beijing. He wants to go with comrade Gao Gang to discuss all these problems with you”¹

On June 13, 1951 Stalin sent a cable to Mao:

“Today I had a meeting with your representatives from Manchuria and Korea (Gao Gang and Kim Il Sung). Three issues were raised:

First. About an armistice. It was admitted that an armistice is a profitable thing now.

Second. About military advisers. If you need them so much, then we are ready to satisfy you.

Third, about the supply of armament for 60 divisions. There won't be objections from our side.

I won't write details because your representatives will inform you about them.

We believe it is absolutely necessary to use at least 8 fighter divisions out of the 16 Chinese divisions right away. We think that besides 2–3 MIG-15 divisions, you could take to the front from Central and Southern China 5 or 6 divisions of MIG-9s, which are very effective against bombers.

¹ Coded message N 20448, June 5, 1951, the Second Chief Directorate of the General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Eight fighter divisions at your front could completely satisfy requirements for the front. According to our information, your fliers are ready for missions. You should send them into battle as soon as possible so they become not paper but combat fliers... We think that this question is the most important for your front.

After completion of the conversation we got information that the Anglo-Americans intend in the near future to propose an armistice to you and Koreans, on behalf of the sixteen countries fighting in Korea. But before that they want to strike at your troops. Perhaps this is gossip, but quite possibly and probably it is not simple gossip... Therefore, I advise you to keep the defense strong and don't let the adversary get ahead of you"² Mao replied to the above-mentioned cable from Stalin on the same day.

"I've received your cable of June 13. Today I also received a cable from comrades Gao Gang and Kim Il Sung. Our opinion on the question of armistice, we gave to comrade Gao Gang in order for him to pass it to you and receive your instructions. I won't write about this here in detail.

Comrade Peng Dehuai needs Soviet advisers very much for strategy and tactics. It is desirable that you send them as soon as possible.

Concerning participation of eight fighter divisions in the battles, I, according to your advice, gave orders to the General Staff to draft a plan. Besides, I had ordered Peng Dehuai to stay firm at the second and third defense lines and to set up a new defense line. Your advice to create eight shock divisions and to draw up a plan for their actions is being implemented, too.

In June our forces will be relatively weaker than those of the adversary. In July we'll be stronger than in June, and in August we'll be even stronger. We are getting prepared to deliver a stronger blow to the enemy in August"³

On the next day, June 14, 1951 Gao Gang and Kim Il Sung, still in Moscow, forwarded the following to Stalin:

"We have received the response cable from comrade Mao Zedong. We ask you to receive this cable and, if you have time,

² Coded message N 3557, June 13, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

³ The coded message N 20772, June 13, 1951, The Second Chief Directorate, General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces, P 55-56.

receive us today as well. We ask you fervently to bestow upon us this high honor. Then we'll have an opportunity to fly back home tomorrow for solution of all problems according to your instructions.

With a Communist hello!

Gao Gang
Kim Il Sung"

Attached to this note is the cable of Mao to Gao Gang and Kim Il Sung (dated June 13, 1951):

"Your cable of June 13 we've received.

Concerning how to raise the question of negotiating an armistice, we consider it is advisable for Korea and China to raise this question themselves today, because two months from now the Korean army and Chinese volunteer troops must take a defensive position.

This is the best course of action:

1. To wait until the adversary proposes an armistice;
2. It is advisable that the Soviet government on the basis of the statement of George Kennan could make a request to the American government about an armistice.

It is possible to implement simultaneously two mentioned proposals. On one side, the Soviet government makes a request, on the other hand, if the adversary raises the question of armistice, then Korea and China will express their consent to this. What is better? We ask you to exchange views and find a solution with comrade Philipov (Stalin).

3. The condition for armistice: restoration of the border at the line of the 38th parallel; to make a small neutral zone on both sides. It is absolutely impossible that the neutral zone will be only on the side of North Korea.

As for the question of China's entry into the United Nations, we don't think it is necessary to raise it as a condition. Because China may say that the UN has in fact become a tool of aggression, therefore China does not give special significance to the question of entering the UN.

We should also think if Taiwan can be used as a condition. For the sake of bargaining we feel we should raise handling this question. If Americans insist on a separate handling of the issue, then we'll make adequate concessions.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

In the interests of peace let's solve the question of Korea first. Please address yourself to comrade Philippov and ask for his instructions.

4. We gave an order... to firmly hold on the present front line... If the adversary does not send new reinforcements to Korea and does not execute landing operations, then in August we'll become much stronger than nowadays.

5. We are sending aviation units to the front right away
Mao Zedong"⁴

The aviation issue kept bothering Stalin later on. On June 16, 1951 he cabled to the Chief Soviet military adviser in China, General Krasovsky:

"According to our information our fliers are teaching the Chinese extremely slowly and without care. You and General Belov probably intend to make professors out of the Chinese fliers, not combat pilots.

... Is it not time to drop this bad habit? Chinese troops will not fight without air cover. Therefore, it is necessary to send... Chinese fliers to the front as soon as possible. This is now your main task... It is absolutely necessary. It should be done in such a way that the Chinese at the front rely only on their own planes"⁵

On June 21, 1951 Mao Zedong cabled to Stalin:

"1) Comrade Gao Gang came back and informed me about your opinion on various issues.

I think that all of them are right and we must act exactly in such a way.

... 2) 8-months experience of conducting a war in Korea by our forces has clearly shown a big difference between the equipment of our forces and the enemy forces and the extreme necessity for improvement of the equipment of our troops. That's why we asked comrade Gao Gang to request from you the supplies of armament for 60 divisions, with which you have agreed. This is the minimal requirement for our troops in Korea this year.

⁴ A note from Gao Gang and Kim Il Sung to Stalin, June 14, 1951, Archives of the President of Russia, P 57-60.

⁵ Coded message N 3559, June 13, 1951, Stalin to Krasovsky.

... Comrade Gao Gang told us that you had expressed an opinion that our requirements were even higher and had proposed to reinforce each division with tanks and artillery.

I believe it is quite right. It is necessary in a war against imperialists. I've already instructed General Xu Xiangqian to conduct negotiations with your General Staff in accordance with your advice.

3. According to a cable from comrade Xu Xiangqian, your General Staff plans to deliver armament this year for only 16 divisions, and for the remaining 44 divisions armament will be supplied in 1952–1953. This contradicts the requirements and timing of the Korean theater of military operations.

4. To satisfy our... urgent requirements I ask you... to fulfill our requests... from July to the end of this year by a 1/6 portion monthly.

... 6. Our requests were made three months late and thus banned our own interests. Today we suddenly asked you for such large quantities and want them to be delivered in six months. It confronts you with big difficulties, especially in the field of transportation... I ask you to do as much as possible"⁶

On June 24, 1951 Stalin replied to Mao Zedong:

"1. You must know by now from Malik's speech that our promise concerning the raising of the armistice issue has already been fulfilled by us. Perhaps, the cause of armistice will move forward.

2. As for armament for 60 divisions, I want to tell you honestly that to satisfy this request during one year is physically impossible and totally unthinkable. Our industrial people and military specialists consider it absolutely unthinkable to give armament for more than 10 divisions during 1951. Satisfaction of the request for 60 divisions is possible, and with great difficulty, during 1951, 1952, 1953 and the first half of 1954... I tried in every way to speed up the supplies by at least half a year, but it came out to be impossible"⁷

⁶ Coded message N 21039, Mao to Stalin, June 21, 1951.

⁷ Coded Message N 635177, June 6, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On June 30, 1951 Mao gave Stalin his opinion on the supply of weapons from the USSR and possible armistice talks with the adversary:

“I completely agree with your opinion.

a) as for the schedule of arms supplies for 60 divisions, we must take into account the production and transportation capabilities of the USSR. That is, to complete arms supplies for 60 divisions during three years, and in 1951 for only 10 divisions...

2. The speech of Yakov Malik (Soviet representative at the UN) gave us an initiative in the conduct of peaceful negotiations... You propose that each side will be represented at the negotiations by military commanders, not by government officials... I consider it completely right.

Comrade Kim Il Sung sent me a cable asking what should be the answer, if Ridgway requests the beginning of negotiations.

I've already informed comrades Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai that, on one side, we must carefully watch the combat situation in order not to give the adversary an opportunity to use the moment in his favor; on the other hand,... they should be ready, in case the adversary requests negotiations, to send representatives to conduct negotiations.

... After receiving demands from Ridgway, it is necessary to discuss the contents and the form of the answer. What is your opinion on this account?

If negotiations start, it is extremely important that you personally be in charge of them to prevent us from getting into an awkward position”⁸

To his cable to Stalin, Mao attached a cable he had received on the eve from Kim Il Sung. That cable said:

“Comrade Mao Zedong!

A speech by Malik, on the radio June 23, induced American interest on the question of the cease-fire in Korea....

From the circulating news, it is known that as soon as Ridgway receives instructions of the National Defense Ministry of the U.S.A., he'll engage in negotiations with the commander of the North Korean troops....

⁸ Coded message N 21334, June 30, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

How should we react to this? How should we reply, if Ridgway wants to conduct negotiations?

I beg you to inform me urgently about your concrete opinion on the issue.

Kim Il Sung
June 29, 1951⁹

On June 30, 1951 Mao sent Stalin yet another cable:

“... Ridgway made his proposal on negotiations.

... Here’s my opinion...

1. Comrade Kim Il Sung should reply to Ridgway on or about July 2 or 3. In the reply he should express consent... to conduct negotiations on the cease-fire, propose a time, place and numbers of participants of the meeting.

2. As for the place of the negotiations, Ridgway suggests the port Wonsan.

Considering the fact that Wonsan is a reinforced military base of North Korea and the adversary intends to land troops there, it seems to me inconvenient to agree on Wonsan. Can we propose the town of Kaesong on the 38th parallel for the negotiations?

3. To prepare... for the meeting I think we should start it on July 15.

4. Because of the pressed timetable and big importance of this meeting I ask you personally to be in touch with Kim Il Sung, personally direct this meeting and simultaneously inform me.

Mao Zedong¹⁰

Stalin replied to Mao right away:

“Your cable about armistice has been received. We think it is necessary to respond to Ridgway right away on the radio, agreeing to meet with his representatives for the armistice negotiations. This information should be signed by... Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai. If the commander of the Chinese volunteer units does not sign, Americans won’t pay any attention to the Korean signature... You must insist on the meeting at the 38th parallel in the area of Kaesong. Keep in mind that at the present time we

⁹ Coded message N 21336, June 30, 1951, Mao’s cable to Stalin with a copy of the above-cited cable from Kim Il Sung.

¹⁰ Coded message N 21340, June 30, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

are the sponsors of the armistice process, so Americans will have to make a concession on the venue of the meeting.

... In your cable you propose that we, from Moscow, should direct the armistice negotiations. This is, of course, unthinkable and unnecessary. It is you, comrade Mao Zedong, who 'll have to direct the negotiations. We at best can give advice on some questions. We are also unable to be in direct communication with Kim Il Sung. You must have the direct communication with him"¹¹.

On July 3, 1951 Mao sent Stalin a copy of his cable to Peng Dehuai, Gao Gang and Kim Il Sung of July 2, 1951.

"...The period of preparation and conducting negotiations with the adversary will take 10–14 days. I ask you in all seriousness to fulfill the following items'

1. During the 10 days at our disposal do your best to increase the personnel of the units of the first line, and especially complete their stock of armament and ammunition.

- ... 2. Raise vigilance to the limit. Units of the first line must be prepared to rebuff a possible large-scale enemy offensive and intensive bombardments of our rear by enemy planes before and during negotiations. The adversary can do this to make us sign an unfavorable agreement...

3. We must be prepared... to rebuff possible enemy landing operations on the west coast"¹²

Your cable of July 15 has been received.

... We think that your analysis concerning the situation correct.

... We believe that if we don't display activity in the military battles and continue a passive defense, then the adversary will not pay attention to our forces and will continue crazy bombardments to put military pressure on us. That's why we propose the following immediate measures:

1. It is necessary to reinforce air-defense artillery...
2. Intensify air battles of our air force.
3. Improve the command of the air force...

¹¹ Coded message N 3917, June 30, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

¹² Coded message N 21412, July 3, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

4. Air force activities should not be limited to the Yalu River (Chinese-Korean border), but go to the south, as far as Pyongyang...

5. It is necessary to send well prepared bomber units with the night-time operational training to the enemy's rear, boldly engaging in air battles and bombing various air fields, warehouses, military barracks, etc.

6. On the ground we should launch local offensives in some areas to put pressure on the adversary..."¹³

Along with the negotiations, the Communist side tried hard to overcome its military handicaps vis-a-vis the well-equipped adversary.

On August 11, 1951 Mao Zedong wrote to Stalin:

"... Airfields being built now in Korea are constantly bombed by the enemy planes day and night. Because of this we cannot finish construction of the airfields.

... Our anti-air artillery cannot hit targets above 8,000 meters... After air attacks airfields are repaired, then again are destroyed... and this pattern is repeated again and again.

... Thus the previous plan of simultaneous transfer to Korea of Chinese-Korean and Soviet air force regiments must be changed. The date of the participation of the air force in military actions, set for September, must be postponed.

... We propose starting to build airfields to the north of Pyongyang as the initial springboards for the gradual advance of a Sino-Korean air force.

... That region is comparatively far away from the enemy air bases... If the adversary launches air attacks, we can easily deter them.

Thus we'll be able to introduce a Sino-Korean air force into combat operations and put it on its feet... later we'll start covering airfields in the area of Pyongyang and to the south of Pyongyang, which will allow us to use a large number of planes.

... We'd like the Soviet government to study the question of transferring to Korea from Antung three Soviet anti-air artillery regiments to cover the additional airfields built in Anju, near the Chinese border...

¹³ Coded message N 21646, July 18, 1951, Mao to Stalin, copies of two cables.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

I request your instructions”¹⁴

On August 17, 1951 the CC of the All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik) cabled Mao Zedong:

“Your cable of August 11 concerning construction of airfields and moving air units to Korea has been received.

We consider your decision to be correct concerning construction of these airfields in the region of Anju (to be built before October 20) and moving to the Korean airfields the Sino-Korean air units before November this year for participation in military actions”

Moscow agreed as well to send two Soviet anti-aircraft artillery regiments to cover construction of the airfields near Anju. These regiments, the cable specified, would be taken from forces covering the region of Antung¹⁵

Mao was constantly worried about the adversary’s air force and available measures to counter it.

Stalin replied to Mao’s cable of August 11, 1951 (N 22764) in the following way:

“Your decision on the construction of... airfields we consider to be correct... For the direct cover of the construction of airfields in Anju: we agree to send two Soviet anti-air artillery regiments from the Antung area”¹⁶

On September 8, 1951 Mao sent a cable to Stalin:

“In my cable of July 27, 1951, addressed to you, I informed you that we intend to request that the Soviet government send your military advisers to work with the Chinese volunteer troops in Korea.

After studying the question and after consultations with the chief military adviser comrade Krasovsky, we believe that it is necessary to invite 83 advisers:

1. We should have advisers for the headquarters of volunteer troops, in total ten persons, including a chief adviser — 1, adviser to the chief of staff — 1, adviser of operational issues — 1, intelli-

¹⁴ Coded message N 22764, Mao to Stalin, August II, 1951.

¹⁵ Coded message N 4757, August 17, 1951, Concerning item 152 (the special file) Politburo N 83. Archives of the President of Russia, P 82.

¹⁶ Coded message N 4757, August 17, 1951. Decision of the Soviet Politburo, P. 152, N 83.

gence adviser — 1, ammunition adviser — 1, artillery adviser — 1, tank adviser — 1, engineering adviser — 1.

Besides, I ask you to send advisers to five armies (in total 10 persons), and to twenty one corps (in total 63 persons). It would be desirable if those advisers went to Korea via Beijing in September–October 1951¹⁷

On September 10, 1951 Stalin replied:

“Comrade Mao Zedong!

Your cable of September 8 has been received. We agree to send the chief military adviser and a group of military specialists as military advisers to the headquarters of volunteer troops in Korea.

About military advisers to the armies and corps we think it is advisable to talk after the chief military adviser studies the situation on the spot...

In the capacity of the chief military adviser we could send five-star General Zakharov¹⁸

On September 12, 1951, Stalin satisfied some of the requests of Mao Zedong, concerning military advisers for the Chinese troops in Korea as well as another request about an additional military credit of 600 million rubles.

On September 20, 1951 Mao thanked Stalin for his positive reply. However, the Chinese leader implied:

“... In addition to five advisers (instead of ten) that you agree to send to the headquarters of the volunteer troops, we would like to have at least one military adviser from the Soviet Union in the headquarters of each of the five armies (on September 8, 1951 Mao requested two advisers for each army). If you agree with this proposal, then I hope that ten military advisers will be able to arrive in Beijing by the end of September of this year or in the first part of October with the subsequent posting of them to the front”¹⁹

In the same cable Mao informed Stalin:

¹⁷ Coded message N 23703, September 8, 1951, The Second Chief Directorate, General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces, P 98-99.

¹⁸ Stalin to Mao, September 10, 1951.

¹⁹ Coded message N 24110, September 20, 1951, The Second Chief Directorate, General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces, P 125.

"We adopted a plan of military training for ten divisions, formed according to the new organizational structure. The plan has been in place since August 1951. I hope that you won't change the schedule, which was agreed upon earlier, for supplies of ammunition and equipment for the ten divisions.

We will finish training the ten divisions by March 1952 and send them to Korea, if the war there continues. I ask you to deliver as soon as possible additional weaponry for the Korean front, especially cannon shells, anti-aircraft guns, ammunition" (a long list of required weaponry was attached to the cable)²⁰

Stalin rejected Mao's requests concerning advisers and an additional and speedy supply of large quantities of weaponry and ammunition. On September 26, 1951 the Kremlin chief said:

"We are ready to send 5 military advisers to be attached to the main headquarters of the Chinese volunteer troops in Korea (in the first part of October). At the same time we are against having advisers at the army level, because, learning responsibility for the combat activities, they'll invariably try to substitute for the commanders of the formations, which is intolerable"²¹

On October 5, 1951 Mao Zedong cabled his acceptance of Stalin's terms. However, he was adamant about demanding satisfaction of at least some of his additional requests for weapons and ammunition. The Chinese leader stressed:

"We badly need anti-aircraft guns, artillery ammunition and anti-tank grenades"²²

Mao also insisted:

"I ask you not to postpone the program of arming all sixty divisions. Originally you promised to finish the process in the first half of 1954, now you mention the end of 1954. I request you stick to the agreement, reached by Gao Gang in June 1951, under which all mentioned supplies had to be covered by a military credit, due to be repaid in eight years"²³

In a cable on October 7, 1951 Stalin shows his irritation with Mao Zedong:

²⁰ Ibid., P.126-127.

²¹ Coded message, N 5542, September 26, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

²² Coded message N 24547, October 4, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

²³ Ibid.

"Comrade Mao Zedong!

Your cable of October 4 has been received.

... You raise the question of including vehicular equipment into the military credit.

... The order of accounting (payment) that you are talking about would contradict the agreement in force... Our financial and military organs don't find reasons to revise present conditions and reject changes. We've agreed with them"²⁴

On October 24, 1951 Mao Zedong forwarded this cable to Stalin:

"1. At the present moment the main effort of enemy planes is directed at the destruction of the communications of our forces. The air unit, commanded by General Georgi Lobov, and Chinese air units have achieved big successes in the air battles. Anti-aircraft units of the Soviet Union and China have also achieved good results in the anti-aircraft fire. Their role is equally important in protecting communication lines. However, the size of our forces is insufficient, and they cannot reliably assure transportation. Therefore, please study the possibility that the government of the Soviet Union will send to North Korea another anti-aircraft artillery division (with three regiments) to reinforce the air-defense of railroads, supplies and airfields in the region of Anju.

2. The Chinese air units, which have finished their combat training, are concentrated in their majority in northeast China and they are waiting to go into action in Korea. As a result, there is a shortage of air-defense means inside China. Besides, in November–December 1951, 463 fliers will finish a training course in Chinese aviation schools to fly YAK-11s.

According to the plan, ordered by you earlier, it is decided to form three fighter divisions of IL-10s, two intelligence regiments of LA-11s, a fighter regiment of LA-9s, one transport regiment of LI-2s, and one transport regiment of LI-2s.

Considering the present state of our air force, Chinese comrades by themselves cannot cope with the task of training personnel to fly combat planes in the desirable period after formation of the above mentioned divisions and regiments. Therefore, I ask

²⁴ Coded message N 2332, October 7, 1951, Stalin to Mao Zedong.

the government of the Soviet Union to extend the following assistance:

a) To send to China three jet fighter divisions and three aviation technical battalions, with equipment to train three Chinese fighter divisions and six groups of technical personnel for MIG-9s. They may also be used to reinforce air defense of the regions of Beijing, Shanghai, and Canton.

b) To send to China the personnel (without equipment) for one regiment and one aviation-technical battalion with equipment to train two Chinese intelligence regiments and two groups of technical personnel for LA-11s” There were other similar requests in this cable²⁵

On November 13, 1951, new signs of Stalin’s discontent with Mao could be seen. In a cable to Kim B Sung the Soviet leader said:

“Comrade Kim Il Sung, for some time I’ve been far away from Moscow. That’s why response about supplying armament for 3 Korean divisions is coming late.

At our meeting in Moscow we decided to provide armament for 30 Chinese divisions. Out of this armament they were supposed to provide weapons for 3 Korean divisions. Comrade Gao Gang agreed to this.

Later it was decided that Chinese comrades would get armament not for 30, but for 60 divisions. I think that considering this fact, Chinese comrades have all the more possibilities to share with you armament for three divisions.

If, however, the Chinese comrades for some reason refuse to satisfy your request, please inform me about this”²⁶

Kim Il Sung hastened to vindicate Mao Zedong. The Soviet Ambassador reported on November 14, 1951.

“In a private conversation Kim Il Sung said that he had addressed the Chinese comrades with this question, hoping to get armament for three divisions, on account of Chinese friends, directly from the Soviet Union.

²⁵ Coded message N 25187, October 24, 1951. The Second Chief Directorate, General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces, P. 141-142.

²⁶ Coded message N 102522, November 13, 1951, Stalin to Kim Il Sung.

... Today Kim Il Sung sent a cable to Mao Zedong with a request to provide weapons for three divisions”²⁷

Stalin wrote on November 14, 1951.

“Comrade Mao Zedong!

Your cable of October 24 has been received. As I am far away from Moscow, my reply comes late.

1. We believe that the defense of communications in North Korea should be executed mainly by forces of attack aircraft, for which we recommend strongly that you speed up construction of the airfields...

... Anti-air artillery must cover only the main big facilities. That’s exactly what is being done now by two anti-air divisions of the Soviet Army...

To reinforce this cover,... the Chinese should provide... 180 guns and several anti-air stationary machine-guns from the armament... provided by the USSR.

In December, as agreed, we will provide you, in the limits of the additional military credit, 120 more anti-aircraft guns (85 mm caliber).

2. As for sending from the USSR to China three jet fighter divisions of MIG-9s with pilots and three technical battalions, we cannot meet this request, because we don’t produce MIG-9s anymore and we don’t have them... If you still need to use our flying personnel for training Chinese flyers on MIG-9s, you can use for three months the instructors from the Soviet fighter divisions, deployed in China...

Only for the Chief Soviet military adviser Krasovsky, through whom Stalin sent this cable, the Soviet leader added:

“We order you to make sure that our fliers, temporarily remaining in China to train Chinese on MIG-9s, return home exactly on time”²⁸

Armistice negotiations in 1951 were directed by Mao Zedong personally, who regularly informed Stalin of the proceedings and occasionally asked for his advice (on the most important issues).

²⁷ Coded message N 503396/sh, November 14, 1951, To Stalin from the Embassy.

²⁸ Coded message N 6648, November 14, 1951, Stalin to Mao through Krasovsky.

Stalin, as a rule, agreed with the positions, views and ideas of Mǎo. Kim Il Sung played only a secondary role in the negotiations and expressed his views only to Mao, who then chose to forward them to Stalin or not.

Right from the start Communists decided to put up maximum demands to the opposite side (withdrawal of all foreign troops, military disengagement on the 38th parallel), partly as a demonstration of their self-confidence, partly to gain at least some concessions from their opponents.

It was obvious, though, that at least the Chinese and North Koreans were really interested in ending the conflict, having realized that they could not win the war and not wishing to make further sacrifices.

On July 1, 1951 new Soviet Ambassador Razuvaev in the DPRK sent a cable to Moscow:

"1... Response of Kim Il Sung about a meeting on the negotiations is intended to be given on July 2–3, 1951.

Immediate consent of Moscow is needed.

... 3. It is intended that Korean delegate Nam Il will announce the following:

- a) Timing of cessation of fire and combat activities,
- b) Withdrawal of troops from the 38th parallel to the north and south for 5–10 km;
- c) With the cessation of fire, flying over and passing over the 38th parallel is prohibited;
- d) Withdrawal from Korean territorial waters of the U.S. Navy and the lifting of the naval blockade;
- e) Removal of all foreign troops from Korea over a period of two months;
- k) Exchange of the prisoners of war and repatriation of citizens, removed by force.

Comrade Kim Il Sung is waiting for appropriate counsel from Comrade Philippov"²⁹

Stalin responded on the next day:

"... Tell Kim Il Sung that the Korean government must agree on the issues mentioned in the cable with the Chinese government and work out joint proposals.

²⁹ Coded message N 501869/sh, July 1, 1951, to Stalin from Razuvaev,

From the cable received, it is not seen that proposals of Kim Il Sung have been agreed upon with Mao Zedong³⁰

Before the start of the meeting of military representatives of the two sides, Mao asked Stalin's advice on what should be the Communist position at the meeting. Mao responded: "... We intend to advance the following five basic points:

1. The two sides must simultaneously order cessation of fire... It is possible that this point will be accepted by the adversary without objections.

2. Military forces of both sides must move to the distance of 10 miles from the 38th parallel and establish a buffer zone within 10 miles of the 38th parallel.

... Perhaps the adversary will have some objections; we consider this proposal really just, so it will be difficult for the adversary to reject it.

3. The two sides must stop movement of armament, troops and reinforcements... from the outside to Korea as well as to the front line on the territory of Korea.

We feel that the adversary will himself advance a proposal on this issue; that's why we want to show initiative. Maybe it is better to drop the last part of our proposal?

4. Create a control committee of the neutral states... We think the adversary will advance a similar proposal, that's why we intend to show initiative. However, in the execution of this point we'll encounter numerous difficulties.

"Members" of the control committee, proposed by the adversary, will be watching our military transports on the Chinese-Korean border and important communication centers of Korea. Or we should not take initiative, wait until the adversary advances it and then we'll accept it?...

5. The two sides must repatriate P. O. W.s...

Perhaps the adversary will propose an exchange of P.O.W.s one to one. We must insist on repatriation of all P.O.W.s. However, the adversary has captured more North Koreans, which have been already included in the South Korean Army. Therefore, this fact will create a dispute.

³⁰ Coded message N 101529, July 2, 1951. From Stalin to Razuvaev.

From our point of view the above-mentioned five points must be solved at the meeting of military representatives.

Besides, there are some other points:

1. All foreign troops... must by a certain time (for example, during 3—4 months)... completely leave North and South Korea.

This is also an important issue. However, the representatives of the adversary may feel that this is a political issue and does not belong to our meeting. Please say if our side must raise this issue.

2. Refugees... must return to their original regions of habitation by a certain time" (for example, during several months).

Comrade Kim Il Sung insists on advancing this point. However, it is very difficult to implement it... There will be a lot of disagreements and disputes on this issue, which might influence solution of other important problems.

Or should we come up with this proposal?

... Yesterday we sent Deputy Foreign Minister Li Ko-nung and his aides to Korea... he'll be in the vicinity of Kaesong, secretly directing the negotiations..."³¹

Stalin's reply came immediately, on the same day:

"... About the first two points we don't have objections. The second part of the third point you can eliminate, but if Americans advance it, you can accept it. The fourth point you should not propose. If Americans start talking about the control committee from the UN, you should reject the proposal, explaining that the UN is a fighting side, you can then propose the committee consisting of neutral countries... The fifth point should be advanced and you should insist on it.

As for the remaining two points (about withdrawal of foreign troops and refugees), both these proposals should be advanced and you should insist on them"³².

Then reports from Li Ko-nung about the meeting in Kaesong started to come to Mao, who promptly readdressed them to Stalin. On July 9, Li Ko-nung sent the following report on the session on July 8 (we give here extracts of the report that might have interest for the reader):

³¹ Coded message N 21405, July 3, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

³² Coded message N 3950, July 3, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

"... Communication officers of the adversary thanked us for the care taken for their personal security and provisions... They expressed the hope that the conference would also be prepared as well. During the meeting, officers of both sides did not salute each other. After the meeting Americans greeted us with a military salute we responded in kind.

... During the meeting at around 10:00 a.m., 24 American planes in two groups flew over Kaesong for demonstration of force, but we did not pay any attention. One plane was making circles over us. It probably communicated with the ground personnel and took pictures.

When American officers, who had just arrived left their plane, they looked very tense... Syngman Rhee's communication officer, giving room at the table for an American officer, fell down.

... During the first two hours the atmosphere at the meeting was rather tense, but just before the recess it started to relax. In the second part it was calm... There were some disagreements, but not important... Our communication officer offered them help and explained what was needed. Relations were good"³³

On July 13, 1951 Mao described the situation at the negotiations on the cease-fire. Here are some of the more significant points of Mao's cable to Stalin:

"... During the two sessions, the Americans in order to stall for time, instigate public opinion and find out our plans, on purpose raised the question of the presence of correspondents at the conference. This is a stupid trick, and we'll easily reject it.

... If the Americans arrive arrogantly at the next session with correspondents, we will not give in an inch.

... During discussion of the agenda for the negotiations it is necessary to get American consent to talk about withdrawal of all foreign troops from Korea. Then we may agree not to include in the agenda the question of the 38th parallel demarcation line and leave it for later discussion... Comrade Kim Il Sung made it clear to Li Ko-nung that if an agreement on the 38th parallel is achieved eventually, then the question of withdrawal of all foreign troops may be postponed.

³³ Coded message N 21632, July 10, 1951.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

We feel... that both these questions should be solved...the parallel and foreign troops... It can be done by stages.

... As for refugees, comrade Kim Il Sung came to the conclusion that it is not favorable to North Korea, so we dropped it.

Is everything mentioned correct?

I ask you to give your instructions after you have examined [everything].

... We are continuing a tough struggle with the adversary and are preparing for battles if negotiations fail"³⁴

Stalin responded to the cable on the following day:

"... We came to the unanimous conclusion that your point of view... is completely right"³⁵.

On the same day Mao gave more instructions to Li Ko-nung, Kim Il Sung, Peng Dehuai:

"... In order to take the initiative into our hands, we've decided to agree with the proposal about the neutral zone and the inclusion of correspondents into their delegation. Thus we'll eliminate all obstacles put up by the adversary.

... In order to provide security for representatives of both sides, think about possibilities to evacuate the population out of the neutral zone (in case of evacuation we have to do it in such a way that the population does not suffer material losses)"³⁶

Li Ko-nung sent the following report on July 14, 1951.

"... At this session we decided to deliver a blow to the adversary's tactics of threats and deceit... We once again stressed our unchanged platform concerning the 38th parallel.

... Their representative [Admiral C. Turner] Joy blamed us for attempts to divide Korea politically (because it proved to be impossible to do it militarily)... and continued to praise the strength of their air power and fleet...

Tomorrow we'll continue to insist doggedly on our positions and to attack the adversary in order to make him change his proposal in our favor"³⁷

³⁴ Coded message N 21756, July 13, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

³⁵ Coded message N 4153, July 14, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

³⁶ Coded message N 21813, July 14, 1951. A copy of this cable sent by Mao to Stalin.

³⁷ Coded message N 22945, July 15, 1951, Li Ko-nung's reply to Mao's cable.

On July 15, 1951 Li Ko-nung sent the following to Mao:

"... Today an agreement was reached on the creation of the neutral zone around the town of Kaesong.

... To the population centers around the highway we'll send unarmed guards in civilian clothes.

... Near the meeting hall the population should be checked, and at night armed guards must be sent out.

... The new situation will help spies to intensify their activities, so... methods of strengthening protection should be studied..."³⁸

On July 15, 1951 Li Ko-nung informed Mao:

"At today's session... the two sides in principle solved the issue of the neutral zone... The adversary continued to reject our proposal about the 38th parallel. He said:

"You claim that because the war started at the 38th parallel it must be completed there. Your logic is not correct. We are decisively against including the 38th parallel issue into the agenda. The adversary, it seems, said these words to get from us some concessions.

... Atmosphere at today's session was comparatively good... 30 correspondents behaved themselves decently, not counting accidents when rules were not observed during photography sessions"³⁹

On July 17, 1951 Kim Il Sung sent the following cable to Stalin:
"To Dear Comrade Stalin,

I consider it necessary to report to you the following: judging from the general analysis of the situation in Korea we cannot exclude a possibility that armistice negotiations may drag on for an indefinite time. During the expired year we practically stopped military actions and turned to a passive defense.

Because of this the adversary, almost without any losses, constantly delivers to us enormous losses in killed and material valuables.

Thus, the adversary lately destroyed all electrical stations in Korea and does not give us an opportunity to restore them.

³⁸ Coded message N 21890, July 16, 1951, Li's cable, sent by Mao to Stalin.

³⁹ Coded message N 21890, July 16, 1951. A copy of this cable, sent by Mao to Stalin.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Just during one day of barbarous bombardment of only one city — Pyongyang — (July 11 and the night of July 12, 1951) over 6,000 peaceful residents were killed or wounded.

The adversary, using this situation, makes unacceptable demands on us.

Naturally, Chinese comrades refuse to accept these conditions. We share the views of comrade Mao Zedong on this issue.

However, to rid the DPRK and its people of suffering and excessive losses, it is necessary for us to reliably defend the most important facilities and turn to active actions.

For this purpose it would be desirable:

1. To strengthen air defense. Additional armaments for 10 air defense regiments are required...

It is desirable that 50% is provided by the Chinese comrades, and the rest is directly from you.

2. Intensify night-time actions of the Air Force. It is necessary to cover in the day time... North Korea at least to the line of Pyongyang. The Korean air force is ready any time to engage in military actions...

3. Conduct a series of noticeable ground operations in order to take away enemy attention from our rear guard and influence negotiations in Kaesong.

... To raise combat capabilities of our army we require from you in the near future technical equipment and materials...

4. In Kaesong simultaneously we should decisively call for the speedy conclusion of the armistice, cessation of hostility and exchange of P.O.W.s on the basis of the Geneva Convention. These demands will be supported by all peace-loving people and push ahead the stalemate in Kaesong.

Our people will support any real move to peace...

A similar cable has been sent to Mao.

The Korean people are limitlessly grateful to you for the tremendous assistance provided to the DPRK.

We are waiting for your instructions and advice on the above-mentioned issues⁴⁰.

On July 18, 1951 Mao sent the following instructions to the delegates at Kaesong:

⁴⁰ Coded message N 502597/sh, July 17, 1951, Kim to Stalin.

"... You must emphasize that withdrawal of all foreign troops from Korea is a necessary condition of guaranteeing absence of resumption of hostile activities in Korea.

We have all the reasons to propose such a thesis. Various countries sent their troops to Korea for conducting military actions, not for a promenade. Why isn't the conference on cessation of military actions entitled to discuss the question of the withdrawal of foreign troops from Korea? Obviously, it cannot be explained...

... During the last days we made a certain concession concerning creation of a neutral zone and correspondents as well as on the military disengagement line and organs for implementation.

Perhaps, the adversary got a wrong impression that we'll eventually give in on the issue of the withdrawal of foreign troops from Korea. So don't be afraid of the adversary's position on the troops.

... During two-three days... you should try to make the adversary give in on the troop issue. For example, if the adversary agrees after the cease-fire to call at once a conference on the withdrawal of foreign troops from Korea. If the adversary does not make this concession, we must continue our demands"⁴¹

On July 20, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

"... Chances of the American concession on the withdrawal of foreign troops from Korea are very small.

... At tomorrow's session we intend on our own initiative to raise the question of troops... If the adversary repeats only old words and does not make any concessions, we'll propose a recess for 3 days.

After the recess we'll be repeating the same position almost up to the end of the session. Then we'll hint that we need only the consent of the adversary to include the troops question into the agenda. In such a case the question of troops may be passed for solution to a different conference"⁴²

On the same day Mao sent his own proposal to Stalin:

⁴¹ Coded message N 21960, July 18, 1951, A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁴² Coded message N 22073, July 21, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

"The adversary is not in a mood to give in on the withdrawal of troops from Korea. Our idea is to drop the demand for now..."⁴³

On the next day Stalin responded:

"Your cable of July 20 has been received. We consider correct your point of view that you should not insist any longer on the inclusion into the agenda of the topic on the withdrawal of foreign troops. The thesis has been rather well used by you in the negotiations as a demonstration of your peaceful intentions, and the lack of desire of the U.S.A. to speed up the cause of peace. Now we can, without harm, put this subject away for the future and agree not to include it into the agenda"⁴⁴

On July 25, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

"... It looks like the adversary is worried about a possibility of wrecking the conference and he intends to study our proposal seriously

... At tomorrow's session we are going to insist on discussion, first of all, of the question of the 38th parallel as the military disengagement line. Only on the day after tomorrow, in the morning or afternoon session, we'll make a certain concession.

We believe that the adversary will not make a concession on the 38th parallel right away. This issue can be solved only after a struggle during 3—5 days..."⁴⁵

On July 28, 1951 Mao instructed Li Ko-nung:

"I received the text of the last presentation of Admiral Joy. His presentation sounds absurd and groundless. He is not conducting negotiations to end military actions, but rather shouting at the battlefield.

In your next speech you should ask Joy: does he really want to achieve an armistice, or he is looking for a pretext to expand the war?

... If the adversary wants to continue the actions of the navy and air force after ground troops stop actions, it means that he does not have any honest intentions.

⁴³ Coded message N 21439, July 20, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

⁴⁴ Coded message N 4277, July 21, 1951, Stalin to Mao.

⁴⁵ Coded message N 22209, July 26, 1951. A copy from Mao to Stalin.

... Our side must stick to the 38th parallel issue and under no circumstances give in on its positions. Only by rejecting the groundless demand of the adversary can one break the mistaken view that we will make one concession after another"⁴⁶

On July 29, 1951 Li Ko-nung informed Mao:

"At today's session the struggle over the military disengagement line continued. The adversary again rejected the 38th parallel, saying that the line must take into consideration the real military situation....

... At present we are preparing for the further denunciation of the groundless theory of the adversary. We think that the struggle over the 38th parallel will go on for several days"⁴⁷

On July 31, 1951 Li Ko-nung wrote to Mao:

"1. The struggle over the 38th parallel has been going on already for six days. The conference is deadlocked...

... We should be on guard that the adversary will try to jump to the third point of the agenda (about control organs), achieve there a favorable decision, and then propose to return to the second point (the disengagement line).

2. It can be seen from media materials, that the adversary is conducting delaying tactics in Korean negotiations. The adversary is very afraid that after achievement of an agreement on the Korean question, a whole series of political issues concerning internal and external problems of Korea may be raised, and it will put America in an awkward position.

... It should be noted that during negotiations Americans excluded the British. There are no British in their delegation at the negotiations. Americans don't give them any information on the negotiations.

3. In order to get out of the deadlock and promote our interests, I propose:

a) to mobilize the mass media to show the hypocrisy of the adversary...

b) to arouse the public opinion and launch a campaign of criticism in the media of Beijing and Pyongyang.

⁴⁶ Coded message N 22265, July 28, 1951. A copy from Mao to Stalin.

⁴⁷ Coded message N 22318, July 30, 1951. A copy by Mao to Stalin.

c) to intensify military actions in order to respond to the beastly actions of the enemy air force and navy. Please explain if my point of view is correct?"⁴⁸

On August 1, 1951 Mao responded to Li Ko-nung:

"... It cannot be excluded that the adversary will propose to switch to the discussion of the 3rd point of the agenda in order to get profit and to achieve better conditions for mobilization in its own country, to fight against its own internal contradictions more successfully.

Whatever the intentions of the adversary are we must as before insist on solution, first of all, of the 38th parallel issue. If we continue to remain in a deadlock at the negotiations, it is good for us. Because we propose the 38th parallel... openly and justly as the basis for conducting negotiations, while the adversary can not advertise its positions and can only passively object to the 38th parallel.

If the deadlock continues... there is a great possibility that the adversary will direct public opinion against himself. The adversary is afraid of it.

... After a delay, a breakthrough should come if the adversary does not want to wreck the conference.

... We agree with your instructions on the correspondents. Please think how to use the correspondents of both sides to demonstrate the unjust nature of the enemy's proposals"⁴⁹

On August 11, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

"At today's session, again there was no progress. The main thesis of our delegate Nam Il was devoted to the denunciation of yesterday's speech by the adversary.

The adversary had said that determination of the so-called military disengagement line 'must be based on the present front line' and 'that the buffer zone must be created in the area of the approximate front line.'

... The adversary has an interest in our thesis that after determining the 38th parallel, it will be easy to discuss the concrete question of the buffer zone.

⁴⁸ Coded message N 22446, August 2, 1951. A copy from Mao to Stalin.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*

... In the afternoon the adversary, with the purpose of intimidating us, said:

I hope that delaying this conference, which will lead to new bloodshed for the Korean people, will create in you a new desire to stop hostile actions..."⁵⁰

Mao responded to Li Ko-nung on the same day: "... It is obvious that the adversary on purpose creates an impression among people that the American side ... has already expressed a desire to determine the present front line as the military disengagement line to solve the issue, and our side refuses to discuss anything but the 38th parallel.

... If the adversary admits that basically the present front line can be determined as the military disengagement line and if he takes away his former proposal,... then you can say that the 38th parallel is the best solution of the present front line. It generally corresponds to the present military situation.

... So our side proposes to make the 38th parallel the basic military disengagement line and, relying on this line, set up the buffer zone. Troops on both sides don't have to withdraw for 10 km in all cases...

... We may show that we are making a concession. Thus we can wrestle from the adversary a few more days, pretending that we are studying his proposals and criticizing wrong proposals. Let's see how the adversary reacts, and then we'll decide if we need to come up with the earlier prepared proposals"⁵¹.

On August 12, 1951 Mao gave the following instructions to Li Ko-nung:

"... As for the tactics of the negotiations at this time, you must focus on the struggle against the former proposal of the adversary (concerning the determination of the military disengagement line and establishment of the buffer zone in the deep rear of our troops). You should restrain from advancing your own proposals... Just criticize the proposal of the adversary and his unclear formula. We'll do it in order for the adversary to withdraw his own proposal or change it.

⁵⁰ Coded message N 22805, August 11, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁵¹ Coded message N 22787, August 11, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

... In the disputes you should combine the 38th parallel with the present front line, as well as combine the military disengagement line with the buffer zone, hinting in such a way at our next earlier determined compromise proposal. Using such tactics will make the adversary come closer to our proposal (which we intend to advance later) and will make the adversary lose the initiative in the propaganda field”⁵²

On August 13, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

“... The adversary at the last session stuck to the groundless and senseless idea of having the buffer zone to the north of the 38th parallel where our troops are deployed now.

... Our representative’s presentation was not strong enough and perhaps because of this could not make the adversary change the wrong views. Therefore, tomorrow we intend to strike hard at the enemy’s stupid theory and defend our platform in order, first of all, to break the mistaken views of the adversary”⁵³

On August 15, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

“... The adversary again repeated his old words and proposed a new form of conducting negotiations...

The adversary proposed to create a joint committee with one representative and two assistants on each side...

We intend to agree with this proposal.

... Tomorrow we want to clarify the possibility of solution of the buffer zone question... It will show our flexibility, and besides will promote the work of our representatives in the committee...”⁵⁴

On August 18, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

“Yesterday and today at the sessions, again there was no progress, mainly because the adversary insisted on the so-called advantage of its air force and fleet and demanded in exchange compensation on the ground.

During the last two days the adversary did not make any concessions, he kept on following his old proposal and arrogantly tried to find out our plans.

⁵² Coded message N 22829, August 13, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁵³ Coded message N 22963, August 17, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁵⁴ Coded message N 22985, August 17, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

According to the instructions of August 11, 1951 we advanced a concrete proposal, but the adversary did not show any interest in it.

... He does not want to give us positions to the north from the 38th parallel.

... If in the next 1–2 days the adversary won't make any concession, we won't give in either, that's to say that we won't advance the second proposal. Because in such a case the adversary, biting a finger, will want to bite off the whole hand. It will delay the agreement"⁵⁵

On August 27, 1951 the situation at the negotiations in Kaesong got more complicated and Mao Zedong decided to consult with Stalin. In his cable to the Soviet leader he said:

"... Due to the deadlock over the military disengagement line, the adversary undertook a whole series of provocations.

On August 19, 1951 enemy troops, disguised in civilian clothes, attacked our armed guards in the neutral zone in Kaesong... The adversary, to defend himself, said that it was a South Korean guerrilla unit operating in our area. The adversary refused to bear responsibility for this.

After this, at night on August 22 an enemy plane dropped 9 bombs on the territory of the neutral zone in Kaesong and shelled the house of our delegation... The adversary claimed it had been done by an unidentified plane...

... Surely, a plan of wrecking negotiations by the South Korean agents is plausible. However, the South Koreans could hardly send a plane without the consent of the Americans...

... We announced a temporary halt of negotiations until the adversary admits responsibility for those incidents...

... We believe that delaying the negotiations can have two scenarios for continuation.

First, the delay may result in the wrecking of negotiations. We seriously prepare ourselves for a possible enemy offensive on the front. Second, the adversary... will find a way out of the deadlock and on the issue of the military disengagement line a way out will be found.

⁵⁵ Coded message N 23048, August 20, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

At present we want to use the pause for conducting the Cold War in order to uncover arrogant, provocative actions of the adversary. I believe, though, that the adversary will not admit his provocations.

What do you think about this? I am waiting for your instructions on the above-mentioned”⁵⁶

On October 18, 1951 Mao sent a cable to Li Ko-nung:

“... At the present time at the meeting of liaison officers our side must stick to the position which will help to resume the conference. We should not be in a hurry, but we should not stall either.

In order to solve some secondary issues we must be timely with our initiative and offer methods with which both sides might agree.

... We should not introduce changes right away, and we should not... present our point of view as unchangeable. On the contrary, we should prepare the ground for the future transformation of our position, so when the transformation takes place it does not look sudden, like we are making a big concession.

Your intention... to present our proposal on the reduction of the neutral zone... as a big concession is absolutely inadvisable.

Our proposal is not some kind of a serious concession... From the point of view of the adversary, he has not gotten anything useful from moving the conference to Panmunjom, the responsibility of the two sides for the guarding procedures, widening of the neutral zone up to Munsan.

... We must act carefully in order not to betray our plans.

However, from the four proposals, advanced by the adversary, it can be seen that the adversary is not fully inclined to reject the resumption of the conference”⁵⁷

On October 22, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported:

“At 14:00 October 22, 1951 the liaison officer of the adversary delivered... a memorandum... on the date of the resumption of the conference.

⁵⁶ Coded message N 23256, August 27, 1951. From Mao to Stalin.

⁵⁷ Coded message N 25025, October 19, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

This prompt confirmation... took place because the adversary is afraid that we'll raise questions about their recent provocations.

... If we don't raise the question of the irregular incidents and instead talk about creation of the joint staff of liaison officers, they will hardly object.

However, taking into account their strong nervous tension, during raising this issue, we must in advance think of changing the subject, in case the adversary does not agree to discussion of the above-mentioned issue..."⁵⁸

On the next day Li Ko-nung continued:

"Considering recent changes in the line of engagement of our troops with the troops of the adversary, we decided to introduce certain changes in our proposal about the demarcation line. The purpose is to show the adversary that our draft reflects the present military situation as well as to achieve a breakthrough in the negotiations.

... According to our proposal, the areas which the two sides will leave are approximately equal. The southern border of the buffer zone will take into account the defensive line of the "Kansas." The landscape there is good, so the adversary won't be able to claim that the area is not convenient for defensive purposes..."⁵⁹

On October 24, 1951 Mao sent a reply to Li Ko-nung:

"... The adversary has already admitted two cases of violation of the neutral zone.

Whatever tricks the adversary takes, he is already in an unfavorable light in the public opinion of the peoples of the world.

... We agree with your proposal that... after the resumption of the conference you should be the first to initiate creation of the joint staff of liaison officers to secure the implementation of the agreement.

As for the irregular incidents, which took place during the last two months, temporarily you may not mention them.

... In this way we'll preserve a weapon, which can be used to accuse the adversary at the proper moment.

⁵⁸ Coded message N 25226, October 25, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁵⁹ Coded message N 25231, October 25, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

... If the adversary continues to insist on its previous military disengagement line, deep in our rear guard, and if he does not agree with the idea that the two sides initiate new proposals on the issue, than we must not hurry with our new proposal. Instead we should wait for a few days... Perhaps through struggle, we'll be able to achieve the demarcation line on the basis of the current front line with a few changes. However, we are dealing with a very cunning adversary"⁶⁰

On October 29, 1951 Li Ko-nung reported to Mao:

"... As can be seen from latest developments, our resistance... will not make the adversary agree on serious concessions in adopting our draft proposal.

Therefore, it is favorable to remain in such a situation for a long time.

We believe that after the universally recognized line of engagement of our troops is recognized, we can propose on our initiative the armistice on the basis of the revised proposal, that is to say to interrupt the military actions there, where the current front line is"⁶¹

On October 30, 1951 Li Ko-nung's cable to Mao said:

"... We think, that without waiting for determination of the line of engagement of troops of the two sides, we should propose a slightly changed draft for cessation of military actions at the present front line.

... This draft should be the following:

- 1) It is necessary that it will be acceptable for the adversary;
- 2) The territory, that the two sides are leaving, should be more or less equal. Therefore, it should be just for both sides.

... Concerning territories jutting from the front line to both sides... we have to agree with the adversary

I believe that on the question of the disengagement line of the troops of the two sides there still be some disputes, but changes will not be big"⁶²

On October 31, 1951 Mao cabled to Li Ko-nung:

⁶⁰ Coded message N 25224, October 25, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁶¹ Coded message N 25406, October 31, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁶² Coded message N 25474, November 1, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

"... I agree with your proposal that at the session on October 31, our side, on its own initiative, should announce that cessation of the military actions should occur at the present front line with some adjustments.

If the adversary starts objecting to this... we must severely criticize him, publish a communique and information for correspondents...

... If the adversary agrees with our proposal, we can at the session on November I advance our concrete draft and thus take the whole initiative into our hands..."⁶³

On November 21, 1951 Li Ko-nung informed Mao:

"The subcommittee held a meeting on November 21, 1951

... We advanced our draft... The adversary had some ions, but minor... We gave the appropriate explanations... The agreement so far... has not been reached"⁶⁴

On November 21, 1951 Stalin cabled Soviet Ambassador Razuvaev in Korea:

"On November 20 we forwarded the following instruction to Ambassador Roshin in China:

Explain to Mao Zedong, as well as to Kim Il Sung through Razuvaev, that truly there is a difference between the demand of Andrei I. Vyshinsky about an immediate withdrawal of American troops beyond the 38th parallel and the present position of Sino-Korean comrades about declaring the existing front line as the demarcation line. Vyshinsky could not act differently in order to demonstrate the unfairness of the American position of refusal to withdraw their troops beyond the 38th parallel.

Such a position by Vyshinsky is good for Sino-Korean comrades, because it demonstrates, on one side, the greediness of the Americans and, on the other side, the flexibility and peace-loving feelings of Sino-Korean comrades, who are making serious concessions to achieve peace."

Since Roshin does not have a direct communication line with you, the Foreign Ministry instructs you directly to inform Kim Il Sung of this by order of Stalin"⁶⁵

⁶³ Coded message N 25465, November 1, 1951. A copy sent by Mao to Stalin.

⁶⁴ Coded message N 26214, November 22, 1951.

⁶⁵ Coded message N 26044, November 21, 1951, Moscow to Razuvaev.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On January 31, 1952 Mao gave Stalin a thorough analysis of the negotiations during the period of December 1951-January 1952. Mao said:

“For the expired period of time, because of purposeful delaying tactics of the adversary at the armistice negotiations in Korea, no final agreement has been achieved so far.

However, on the basic issue of a cease-fire an agreement has been reached: on three points of the demarcation line issue, in principle on the exchange of P.O W.s.

... Because of this the negotiations cannot be delayed for a long time. It is true that the adversary tries to delay the negotiations using the senseless demand of limitations on restoration of airfields... and freeing of P.O W.s on a voluntary basis... However, our side resolutely objects to their proposals. Besides, it is very difficult for the adversary to mobilize public opinion to support continuation of the war in Korea. The U.S.A. and its satellites themselves wish to stop the war in Korea. As a result the adversary has proposed to table the airfields issue and discuss minor details of the agreement.

... It is clear that possibilities for achieving a final agreement are growing. However, we are not counting (and we've never counted before) solely on these possibilities.

Simultaneously we are vigilantly watching the tricks of the ruling circles of the U.S.A. which, because of the growth of internal and external contradictions, continues the policy of delaying and even wrecking the negotiations in order to worsen the international situation even more. But we are ready in the military and political fields to strike resolutely at the enemy in order to undermine his plans. At the present time the two sides at the negotiations have already begun detailed discussion of the issues...”⁶⁶

On February 3, 1952 Stalin cabled to Mao:

“Your cables of January 31 concerning negotiations on the armistice have been received.

We agree with your intended plan and with your appraisal of the negotiations. Your firm position has already given positive results and must make the adversary agree to further concessions.

⁶⁶ Coded message N 16008, January 31, 1952, Mao to Stalin.

We think we should talk about comrades from Poland and Czechoslovakia, including their representatives to the observers' commission, and they, of course, will agree with this"⁶⁷

Negotiations dragged on and such a trend corresponded with the mood of Stalin. After having decided to start the war the Soviet leader consistently wanted prolonged hostilities as favorable to the communist side. It can be observed in the following documents.

On December 7, 1950, the Politburo of the CC of the Bolshevik Party confirmed instructions to the Soviet representative at the UN rejecting his peaceful approach to the Korean War. The instructions said:

"Your proposal about termination of military actions in Korea we consider as wrong in the current situation when the American troops are being defeated and when the American side more and more often is advancing proposals about termination of military actions in Korea in order to win time and prevent a total defeat of the American troops.

The draft of the Soviet delegation must include the following:

- 1) An immediate withdrawal of all foreign troops from Korea.
- 2) Solution of the Korean problem must be left to the Korean people themselves"⁶⁸

On June 5, 1951 Stalin sent a special message to Mao. In it Stalin, pretending to share Mao's views, clearly imposes his interest in the continuation of the Korean War. He said:

"I share your view that the Korean War should not be ended in a hurry, because, first of all, a prolonged war will allow Chinese troops to learn about modern warfare on the battlefield and, secondly, the war shakes up Truman's regime in America and downgrades the military prestige of Anglo-American troops.

Now about allegations concerning the rather high morale of Anglo-American troops and the emergence of serious rightist tendencies among Chinese soldiers. I think it is caused by your local maneuvers with a certain advancement of troops and then their

⁶⁷ Coded message N 709, February 3, 1952, Stalin to Mao.

⁶⁸ Politburo of the CC of the All-Union Communist Party (Bolshevik), Decision of December 7, 1950, N P 79/189. Extract from the minutes N 79 of a Politburo meeting. Item 189, P 1.

retreat. This has been repeated several times and has created inside your armies an impression of weakness of the Chinese and Koreans while inside the Anglo-American armies has been created an increased confidence in their own might. I am afraid it will undermine the morale of the Sino-Korean troops. I think in order to counter these unhealthy tendencies you'll need the preparation and execution of a serious offensive against the adversary accompanied by the elimination of three or four enemy divisions.

Surely, it will not be a large-scale and far-reaching offensive; it will be just a short strike at the enemy, but it will be such a strike which will sober the adversary and raise the fighting spirit of the Sino-Korean troops. Besides, it will open for you a possibility to conduct successful local maneuvers later, on a large scale, which are necessary to wear the enemy down"⁶⁹

On July 20, 1951 Mao gave Stalin the following analysis of the Korean situation, from which his interest in achieving peace in Korea is clear:

"... Concerning the withdrawal of all foreign troops from Korea the adversary is resolutely against putting it on the agenda... insisting that its solution has to be postponed till peaceful negotiations.

... As can be seen, the adversary wants only to stop hostilities in Korea in order to avoid further losses and delays. As for other questions, including withdrawal of foreign troops from Korea, the adversary prefers to maintain the tensions of today in order to be more successful in coercive mobilization back home and expansion abroad.

So-called 'peaceful negotiations' is an empty phrase... Even if a peaceful conference takes place, the adversary... still will be able to leave the question of troops unresolved.

If the hostilities in Korea are really finished, then, it is possible that the adversary at some time, on his own initiative, will withdraw a portion of his troops. At the same time a decision on withdrawal, included in the future agreement, will not necessarily be implemented.

⁶⁹ The coded message N 3410, June 5, 1951, Archives of the President of Russia, P 17-18.

However, now when the adversary has politically lost an important base for heating up tensions in the Far East, he will never agree to withdraw troops. So, we probably should revise our stand on the foreign troops in Korea. Earlier, for the sake of restoration of separate North and South Korea we agreed to stop hostilities at the 38th parallel. We agreed to this mainly because our military forces are capable of chasing the enemy out of North Korea, but they are not sufficient for chasing him away from South Korea.

In case of a prolonged war, we may inflict even bigger harm to the adversary, but we'll severely undermine our finances' it will be difficult to increase our defense construction.

If we stall for 6-8 months then we'll be able to chase away the adversary from South Korea, but the price will be too high; we'll have a crisis.

... If negotiations fail because of the withdrawal question, then in the future, when we resume negotiations, the adversary, quite possibly, will reject our demand again ... If the war resumes again, we'll have to continue a long war with the purpose of achieving an unachievable aim of chasing the adversary out of Korea.

Having done such analysis, I believe it to be necessary to express my new opinion on this difficult question-' it is better to stop raising the question of withdrawal ... than to try to solve it by conducting long military actions without hope for success'⁷⁰

On August 13, 1951 Mao Zedong forwarded to Stalin a cable from Li Ko-nung where an explicit desire to end the hostilities was obvious:

"The adversary refuses to discuss at the armistice talks the issue of the 38th parallel. The adversary displays his desire to achieve the military disengagement and create the buffer zone on the basis of the current front line and the current military situation. It is done in order to avoid a defeat in the propaganda field and to hint that the adversary may change his proposal. Simultaneously the adversary puts all the blame on the Sino-Korean side.

Judging from the proceedings of the whole conference and the general situation outside the conference, it is clear that it is

⁷⁰ Coded message N 22054, July 20, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

impossible to convince the adversary to accept our proposal about the 38th parallel. On one hand the adversary is applying pressure on us in an effort to make us offer the concessions first, on the other, the adversary is getting ready for a possible breakdown of the conference.

The adversary would hardly abandon his present position on the line of the military disengagement. I recommend to clarify our intentions' if our final aim is to have the military disengagement along the 38th parallel and we are prepared only for certain adjustments in this respect, then we must keep in mind the breakdown of negotiations.

I and my colleagues (he named in the cable Deng Hua, Se Fang, Qiao Guanhua are opposed to the continuation of hostilities. Having studied, on the basis of the limited materials that are available, the general international situation, requirements of our state and the fact that at the present time Korea cannot carry on the war, we believe that it would be better to consider the possibility of ceasing military actions along the existing front line than to fight for the 38th parallel and bring the conference to the breaking point"⁷¹

On August 29, 1951 Stalin wrote to Mao:

"...As before, we act on the assumption that the Americans need to continue the negotiations.

We don't see any use in inviting, on your initiative, the representatives of neutral states to participate in the negotiations as controllers and witnesses of the present negotiations. The negative impact of such a proposal will be that the Americans may consider it as a sign that the Sino-Korean side needs a speedy conclusion of the armistice agreement. And it is not so"⁷²

On August 30, 1951 Mao replied to Stalin:

"Your cable of August 29, 1951 has been received. I agree that we should not display an initiative in inviting representatives of

⁷¹ Coded message N 22834, August 13, 1951. The Second Chief Directorate, the General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces. Archives of the President of Russia, P 56-58.

⁷² Coded message N 4954, August 29, 1951 Stalin to Mao. See also Decision of Stalin's Politburo: N P 83/280, August 28, 1951 the letter (N 4954) based on the decision.

neutral states as controllers and witnesses at the present stage of the negotiations.

I've told already comrade Kim Il Sung this"⁷³

As can be seen from this cable, Mao did not comment at all on Stalin's thesis that the adversary needs peace more than the Communist side.

On September 17, 1951 Stalin wrote to Mao:

"Americans, being unsuccessful in military actions, are trying to achieve success by the approval of their positions at the UN.

... Our position should be based on the assumption that the longer the Americans are bogged down in the war in Korea, the better for our own interests..."⁷⁴

On November 11, 1951 Mao wrote to Stalin:

"... Due to large losses at the front during the last two months and the growth of demands inside America and outside to stop military actions, a chance of adoption by the American side of conditions of the armistice has grown. However, ... the American government still attempts to keep the international situation tense. Conducting active intelligence and a policy of appeasement during the negotiations, the Americans nevertheless try to delay the negotiations.

... The adversary demands to make the hue of the present day front as the demarcation line. We are against it, but we are ready to postpone the question of the 38th parallel as the demarcation line until convocation of the political conference... We do it because we don't want to lose the western coastal valley to the south of the 38th parallel. It has a large population and it is rich in agricultural products and the area can be used as a spring-board to take Seoul.

... We try to achieve cessation of military actions during this year. At the same time we are making necessary preparations in case the adversary delays the negotiations and wrecks them. Believing that negotiations will stretch on for another half year or year, we are saving... our human and material forces and pursue the tactics of a long active defense in order to hold today's

⁷³ Coded message N 4858, August 30, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

⁷⁴ Coded message September 17, 1951. Stalin to Mao.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

positions and deliver the adversary large losses... and to win the war.

... It is true that achievement of peace through negotiations is favorable to us, but we are not afraid of delaying negotiations. At the same time we'll be able to have successful stabilization inside the country and further development in the spheres of politics and economy"⁷⁵

On November 19, 1951 a decision of Stalin's Politburo was transmitted to Soviet Ambassador Razuvaev in Pyongyang: " ... We don't understand why and on whose initiative appeared the question of the appeal by the DPRK to the General Assembly and Security Council concerning speeding up the solution of the Korean problem.

In your cable you say that the Korean government intends to appeal on the following issues' about immediate cessation of military actions in Korea, withdrawal of troops from the front line and creation of a 2-kilometer demilitarized zone and about prosecuting culprits for dragging on the war in Korea.

Such an appeal can be received in the present situation, under conditions of the blackmail by Americans, as a sign of weakness of the Sino-Korean side. And this is politically bad.

Therefore, not having the text of the appeal, not knowing the opinion of our Chinese comrades and not knowing the motives of the Korean friends, we feel it is necessary that you advise our Korean friends to postpone solution of the question on the appeal until everything is cleared up.

We are waiting for a more detailed answer from you"⁷⁶

On November 19, 1951 Stalin's Politburo adopted the following letter by Stalin to Mao (it was sent to Beijing on the same day):

"We've received your cable of November 14, 1951 concerning armistice negotiations in Korea.

We agree with your appraisal of the present situation at the negotiations.

The whole course of negotiations lately shows that though the Americans are delaying negotiations, nevertheless, they are in a

⁷⁵ Coded message N 25902, November 14, 1951, Mao to Stalin.

⁷⁶ Politburo decision N P 84/422, November 19, 1951.

bigger need of their speedy conclusion. It derives as well from the international situation.

We consider it correct that the Chinese-Korean side continue flexible tactics at the negotiations, stick to the tough line, without showing any hurry and displaying an interest in the speedy completion of the negotiations... The adversary needs peace much more than we do"⁷⁷

On November 20, 1951 Stalin's Politburo adopted and sent the following devastating letter to Soviet Ambassador Razuvaev in Korea:

"We draw your attention to the inadmissibility of your actions in connection with the appeal of our Korean comrades to the UN on the question of speeding up the peace process in Korea.

You informed us only on November 18 about the intentions of our Korean friends to address the General Assembly and Security Council with the following demands' an immediate cessation of military actions in Korea, withdrawal of troops from the front line and creation of a 2-kilometer demilitarized zone and about prosecuting culprits for dragging on the war in Korea. And you asked us if this Korean appeal would not contradict our official position.

Without waiting for the reply to your telegram of November 18 with elaboration of the Korean intentions, you simply informed us that on the same day (November 19) the statement of Park Hon-young would be read on the radio. After our repeated inquiry concerning the origin of the new Korean proposal you simply repeated them... and said that it would broadcast over the radio.

Thus... our Korean comrades advanced this harmful appeal without getting our approval.

... You acted extraordinarily recklessly Your guilt is aggravated by the fact that you did not even go to the trouble of finding out from the Koreans if they had consulted with our Chinese friends on the issue...

Take all this criticism to heart and learn lessons for the future"⁷⁸

⁷⁷ N P 84/421, November 19, 1951. Stalin's Politburo decision.

⁷⁸ Coded message N 334/99 November 20, 1951, Politburo to Razuvaev.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On December 25, 1951 Stalin's Politburo took the following position:

"Comrade Vyshinsky (Soviet representative at the UN) initiates a proposal that the Korean-Chinese command on the eve of expiration of the agreement on the demarcation line (December, 27) publish a communiqué on the course of negotiations denouncing the American position aimed at delay and destruction of the armistice talks in Korea.

... Dissemination of such a document at the UN will not yield any practical results, and the request of Koreans and Chinese about this will be perceived as a manifestation of their weakness.

Our Foreign Ministry is against giving any such advice to the Korean and Chinese governments"⁷⁹

The following instruction was sent to Vyshinsky:

"... Your recommendations for Chinese and Koreans to publish the communique as a document of the UN cannot be accepted. It will be taken as a sign of weakness of North Koreans and Chinese, which is politically unadvisable"⁸⁰

On January 16, 1952 North Korean Foreign Minister Park Hon-young paid a visit to Peng Dehuai. In a cable to Mao Zedong the Chinese commander reported:

"Park stressed that the Korean people throughout the country demand peace and do not want to continue the war. If the Soviet Union and China consider it profitable to carry on the war, then the General Committee of the Workers Party will be able to overcome any difficulties and hold fast to the present position.

... I explained the favorable conditions of our side in the present military situation and the growing difficulties of America. That's why the armistice can be achieved; however, in the military field we are conducting active preparations of our forces for further continuation of military actions.

I managed to influence the position of Mr. Park. Upon concluding the conversation the Foreign Minister said that he agreed with my point of view on the general situation. Park also emphasized the fact that he simply wanted to talk and that his opinion

⁷⁹ N 87/AG, December 25, 1951.

⁸⁰ Coded message N 812, December 25, 1951.

was not the opinion of the CC of the Workers Party and the Korean government; it was purely his personal opinion”⁸¹

On March 5, 1952, the Soviet Foreign Minister sent a note to the Politburo of the CC of Stalin’s Communist Party:

“Ambassador of the USSR in Korea. Comrade Razuvaev, suggests to advise Kim Il Sung to publish an interview... concerning negotiations in Pyongyang.

In the proposed draft by Comrade Razuvaev, he mentions three questions: delaying of negotiations by the American side; invitation of the Soviet representatives to the neutral body observing the implementation of the armistice conditions; position of the Korean side in case the American side undermines the negotiations.

From the point of view of the Foreign Ministry, the proposal of Comrade Razuvaev is totally unacceptable. Publication of such an interview can be interpreted as a sign of nervousness and fussing of the Korean-Chinese side”⁸²

On the 7th of March, the Politburo made the following decision:

“We should not hurry up the process of negotiations. It is not in our interests... The proposal of Razuvaev is unacceptable”⁸³

On July 18, 1952 Stalin received a cable from Mao Zedong. The cable said:

“I am sending you the text of my cable of July 15 to comrade Kim Il Sung and the text of the reply from comrade Kim Il Sung of July 16 to me:-

“We’ve received your cable of July 14.

... Our comrades are unanimous that at the present time, when the adversary conducts wild bombardments against us, acceptance of the adversary’s proposal which is provocative and dishonest, without any real concessions, is extremely unfavorable to us.

Let’s look at positive and negative sides of this question:

⁸¹ Coded message N 16293, February 8, 1952. The Second Chief Directorate, the General Staff of the Soviet Armed Forces. Archives of the President of Russia, P 81.

⁸² Coded message N 36/33, March 5, 1952. Foreign Minister to the Central Committee.

⁸³ Coded message N P 86/33, March 7, 1952.

Non-acceptance of the adversary's proposal will bring about only harm, further losses for the Korean people and Chinese volunteers. However, since the war began, China has been helping Korea, and Korean people are now honestly standing at the front line of defense of the camp of peace for the whole world.

At the price of sacrifices by the Korean people we have achieved reinforcement of positions in the area of the 38th parallel. North Korea and northeast China have been defended.

Peoples of Korea and China, especially their armed forces, have had an opportunity to temper themselves and to acquire experience in the struggle against American imperialism.

In addition to this, in the course of this struggle Korean and Chinese peoples have built up their might, which inspire peace-loving peoples of the world in the struggle against the aggressive war and promotes development of the movement for the defense of peace all over the world. It also ties up the main forces of imperialism which suffer constant losses in the East. At the same time the foundation of world peace, the Soviet Union, can intensify its construction and can influence development of the revolutionary movement of all peoples of the world. It will mean delay of the new World War.

The existence of these great achievements says that the Korean people are no longer alone.

First of all, the Chinese people want to do their best to guarantee that the Korean people will overcome their difficulties. That's why at present we ask you not to hesitate in addressing us with questions, connected with the speedy solution in Korea. If we are not able to solve your problems, we'll jointly ask Comrade Philippov for help. As to the adoption of the adversary's proposal it will bring great harm.

The adversary will definitely use our weakness to put further pressure on us. There will be new provocations by the enemy... Then we'll possibly suffer even bigger defeats ... It will be an unfortunate move, leading to the loss of the whole game.

If the adversary does not make concessions and ends negotiations, we'll have to continue the military activities... to solve the problems, and change the international situation..."

The response of Kim Il Sung to me:

"Dear comrade Mao!

Your cable of July 15, 1952 has been received.

... We came to the unanimous conclusion that your analysis concerning the present situation is correct.

... We believe that we have to intensify military actions in a long struggle against the adversary. If we don't display activity in military actions and continue the passive defense, then the adversary won't respect our forces and will continue the crazy bombardments in order to put military pressure on us ..."⁸⁴

In a meeting with Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai on August 20, 1952, Stalin once again showed his inclination to continue the war in Korea.

The conversation went like this:

"Zhou said that from May 1951 the war became positional. The strength of the two sides is more or less equal ... Both sides refrain from large-scale offensives ...

Stalin asks what's Mao's position on the P.O.W.s: to give in or to stand firm?

Zhou Enlai stresses that the Chinese have differences with their Korean comrades on this issue. The Americans agreed to return 83,000 P.O.W.s and the Koreans almost agreed to this. But they did not take into account the fact that the Americans are conducting a clever game, because among 83,000, 6,400 persons are Chinese and the rest are Koreans. In reality, the Americans must return in addition 13,600 Chinese volunteers, but Americans don't want to do it, being, however, prepared to return 76,000 Koreans... They are playing a provocation game, trying to create animosity between the Chinese and Koreans.

Turning to the necessity for continuation of the war Zhou Enlai suggested:

"We must not make any concessions to the Americans at the negotiations"

Stalin's reply was: "If the Americans give a bit, we can accept it, and continue negotiations about other problems"

Zhou Enlai: "We must be prepared to continue the war for at least one more year."

Stalin: "I agree"

⁸⁴ Coded message N 21646, July 18, 1952.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Zhou Enlai: "You are absolutely right in saying that the Korean War makes trouble for the Americans and that the Americans are not ready to start a World War. Playing the vanguard role in this war, China helps to postpone a World war. If we are able to stop the American offensive in Korea, the World War will be postponed for 15-20 years. Then the United States won't be able to unleash World War III at all"

Staling "It is correct, but with one addition. The Americans in general are not capable of conducting a big war, especially after the Korean War. All their strength is in air raids, in the atom bomb. America cannot defeat a small Korea. Firmness is required in dealing with America. Chinese comrades must know that if America doesn't lose this war, then the Chinese will never get Taiwan.

The Americans are merchants. Each American soldier is a speculator; he is engaged in selling and buying. It took the Germans thirty days to conquer France. It's been already two years that the United States cannot overpower a small Korea. So what kind of force is this? The main weapons of Americans are stockings, cigarettes and other goods for sale. They want to conquer the whole world, but cannot overpower a small Korea. No, Americans cannot fight. Especially after the Korean War they have lost ability to stage a big war. They count on the atom bomb and air raids. But a war cannot be won in such a way. Ground troops are required, but Americans have few of them and their ground troops are weak. They are fighting with a small Korea, and they are already crying in America. What will happen if they start a big war? Then, it seems, all of America will be crying"

Zhou Enlai inquired on behalf of the North Koreans if they should start bombing South Korea: "North Koreans are not sure, Zhou explained, that would be a right decision"

Stalin gave a negative answer: "The air force belongs to the state; the Chinese volunteers should not use a state-owned air force"

Again on behalf of Pyongyang, Zhou Enlai asked if the North should begin a new offensive. According to Zhou, the Chinese government told Kim Il Sung that he could not launch a strategic offensive.

Stalin: "When negotiations about an armistice are taking place, one must not conduct either strategic or tactical offensives.

No offensive must take place"

Zhou Enlai: "The Chinese government deems it necessary you continue negotiations in Panmunjom. At the same time China is preparing itself for the possibility that the war may go on for another 2-3 years. China requests supplies from the USSR of planes, artillery and ammunition, since China cannot produce all this itself"

Stalin: "Whatever we can, we'll give you" After this Stalin inquired about the prevailing mood among Koreans: "Isn't there a feeling of confusion?"

Zhou Enlai confirmed it.

He said "There is a lot of destruction in Korea, especially as a result of bombardments of electric stations along the Yalu. The destruction affects the mood of our Korean comrades and promotes a desire to achieve peace as soon as possible"

Stalin pointed out that the favorable tactic of Americans was intimidation. However, they have not intimidated the Chinese. Stalin asked, if Washington had succeeded in intimidating Koreans. Zhou Enlai believed that the Koreans were a little bit unstable. Their mood was not completely balanced. A certain group of leading Korean figures is even in a state of panic.

Stalin admitted that he was aware of such a mood from the cable, sent by Kim Il Sung to Mao Zedong"⁸⁵

On November 2, 1952 Stalin's Politburo passed another decision, stressing the advisability of continuing the war. The decision said:

"... Gossip is being spread about secret talks between Moscow and Washington on the Korean war... Americans don't deny them, trying to project a good impression on the world public opinion... We must publicly reject these attempts... because the continuation of hostilities in Korea in fact is favorable to the cause of the anti-imperialist struggle"⁸⁶

⁸⁵ Quoted from "The Memorandum of Stalin-Chou conversation on August 20, 1952," written by A.Vyshinsky and N.Fedorenko. Russian State Archives, P 54-72.

⁸⁶ NBP 2/19, N 2, November 3, 1952.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

On December 17, 1952 Mao gave a thorough analysis of the course of the war in Korea to the Soviet leadership:

“Because of the interruption of negotiations on the cease-fire in Korea, and because losses of Americans are not big enough to make them stop the military action, we believe that the combat activities during a certain period (maybe a year) will continue to intensify.

At present Eisenhower is preparing for the military activities, which will be implemented after his coming to power... First of all, one should expect landing operations in our rear rather than an advance at the front, where our positions are well reinforced... All facts show that at present the adversary is intensively preparing and increasing the puppet troops of Syngman Rhee; the naval units of, the adversary incessantly maneuver in the waters of North Korea; agents are actively collecting information in the areas of west and east coasts

... Landing operations can, perhaps, be undertaken by the adversary in the spring of next year, or earlier — in February To facilitate landing operations... the adversary may take holding operations against continental China...

However, the war in Korea remains for us the key question. If we successfully defend western and eastern coast areas in our rear in Korea, break the enemy's plan of the landing operation as well as conduct tactical attacks at the front, and inflict big troop losses on the adversary, then the situation in Korea will stabilize and will develop favorably for us.

Before I answer how these tasks can be fulfilled, let me report to you the present military situation and its peculiarities.

After defeat of the enemy's autumn offensive last year, the situation... has become relatively stable. Our troops used that period for reinforcing defensive lines at the front and in the coastal waters...

Our troops were the first to start tactical attacks and as a result 58 strongholds were taken from the adversary's units... In September and October, we inflicted on the enemy huge losses — 110,000 killed and wounded, including over 40,000 Americans.

In the middle of October the adversary using over two divisions launched a continuous offensive at two strongholds... However, we kept the positions in our hands...

Due to such fierce positional fighting the artillery fire... was especially concentrated... During the last three months we've used over two million four hundred thousand shells... One of the most important factors of our victory in the autumn was the strong artillery fire and the precision of our artillery personnel.

As for the balance of the artillery means, the adversary has 14,000 guns..., we have 13,000. However, on our side light artillery means predominate. The adversary has many more heavy guns and tank guns. Our big difficulty is a shortage of artillery ammunition, including the Soviet type. And our units have 2,000 Soviet guns...

If the adversary learns the real situation with our artillery and starts its offensive earlier, we'll get into a very complicated position.

... The request to supply Soviet artillery shells is one of the most urgent requests I put before you in this cable.

In order to complete the volunteer troops we started a new draft in China and plan to send next year 250,000 soldiers to Korea

... Due to the difficulties of our Korean comrades in maintaining this war, besides constructing railways, highways and various facilities with our money, we decided to supply Korea free of charge with goods and foodstuffs worth 60 million American dollars annually over the next three years, as well as to receive in China big numbers of Korean orphans, refugees, workers and clerks to ease the burden of Korea.

To solve positively these questions it is necessary to conduct good military operations in Korea. We are ready to apply our efforts to win the war; however we'll achieve this not without difficulties.

The biggest difficulty at present is that in 1953 we will not be able produce all kinds of cannons of the Soviet type, extremely necessary for the Korean front and especially Soviet artillery shells of different calibers...

... In connection with this quite serious situation, I strongly urge you to satisfy our request for the military equipment for the Korean front for 1953..."⁸⁷

⁸⁷ Coded message N 26499, December 17, 1952, Mao to Stalin.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

Stalin sent a response to Mao's cable of December 17. The cable said:

"... Your considerations about a possible advance of Americans in the spring 1953 reflect plans of the present American command in Korea, led by the Truman government. It is quite possible that these plans will be changed by the Eisenhower Administration in the direction of lesser tension at the front in Korea. However, you act correctly by thinking about the worst and assuming the possibility of an Americans offensive.

We've examined your request for military equipment for 1953 and the request for urgently needed military equipment.

The quantities you request ... are beyond our capacities in 1953.

... Taking into account the situation you are describing in your cable, we, with great difficulty, can supply you in 1953, beyond the armament and ammunition for 20 divisions planned, with only 1/4 of the quantity you request..."⁸⁸

On January 12, 1953, two Russian military commanders, Marshals Vasilevsky and Sokolovsky, on behalf of Mao Zedong, requested additional amounts of weapons from Stalin. They said:

"On December 17, 1952, Mao asked for various weapons, ammunition, military and technical equipment for the Korean front. First of all, Mao wanted in January-April 1953 624 pieces of artillery, 2,355,000 rounds of ammunition.

In your reply you explained that such a request was beyond Soviet capacity, as simultaneously the USSR had to continue supplying 20 army divisions. You consented to provide 332 artillery guns and 600,000 rounds of ammunition in the course of a year. In the second cable on the matter, Mao asked to make these additional quantities of guns and ammunition available in the first four months of 1953. As for supplies for 20 army divisions, Mao suggested to start them in March 1953 at the rate of two divisions per month.

Mao wanted the following schedule of overall including 20 divisions:

⁸⁸ December 27, 1952. A cable from the Kremlin to Mao, P. 330.

(monthly)	Ammunition	Artillery
January	200,000 rounds	166 guns
February	200,000 rounds	166 guns
March	180,000 rounds	132 guns
April	180,000 rounds	132 guns
May–December	80,000 rounds	132 guns

In our cable of December 27 we had recommended steady monthly supplies of 1,665,000 rounds of ammunition and 138 artillery pieces. We ask you to supply the additional quantities, requested by Mao, in January–April, and to start supplies of the 20 divisions in May, 1952⁸⁹

Immediately after the death of Stalin the Kremlin changed its line on the war in Korea. The new Soviet leaders took a firm decision to end the war in Korea. The Chinese and North Koreans right away agreed (though Mao on one or two occasions said that he could fight a little bit longer).

On March 19, 1953 the Council of Ministers of the USSR made a decision to change their position on the Korean War and to inform the Chinese and North Koreans about this.

The Council sent the following letter from the USSR government to Mao Zedong and Kim Il Sung:

“We insist on an immediate implementation of the following actions:

1. It is necessary that Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai give a positive answer to the proposal of General Clark of February 27 concerning the exchange of sick and wounded P.O.W.s.

2. Right after the response of Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai is published, an authoritative representative of the PRC (the best choice would be Zhou Enlai) should make a statement in Beijing, in which he should stress a positive attitude toward the proposal concerning the exchange of sick and wounded P.O.W.s, and he should point out as well that the time has come to solve the entire issue of the P.O.W.s and, consequently, assure the termination of the war in Korea and the signing of an armistice.

⁸⁹ A report to Stalin, N 738343, January 12, 1953. Archives of the President of Russia, P 1-2.

3. Simultaneously with the above mentioned statement in Beijing, the head of the DPRK government, Kim Il Sung, should make a political speech in Pyongyang in which he should declare his full support for the above mentioned statement of the representative of the P.R.C.

4. We also consider it advisable that right after the statements in Beijing and Pyongyang the Soviet Foreign Minister should make a speech expressing full support for the speeches in Beijing and Pyongyang.

5. In accordance with the mentioned four actions, the Soviet delegation at the General Assembly of the United Nations in New York must do its best to provide adequate support and advancement for the new political platform, which was elaborated above.

Here we'd like to make some additional clarifications:

First. About the answer to Gen. Clark. We believe that in the response of Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai to Gen. Clark a full agreement must be expressed with the proposal of Gen. Clark to conduct an exchange of the sick and wounded P.O.W.s.

Resumption of negotiations in Panmunjom between the chief representatives of the two sides at the armistice negotiations should be proposed.

In negotiations concerning an exchange of wounded and sick P.O.W.s keep in mind that the task is not only the achievement of the solution to this issue, but also the achievement of a solution to the whole issue of the P.O.W.s, and, consequently, the removal of obstacles in the way of termination of military actions and the conclusion of the armistice agreement.

Second. About the statement in Beijing. It is advisable to say that the government of the P.R.C. has discussed together with the government of the DPRK the issue, raised by Gen. Clark... A unanimous conclusion has been reached that it is necessary to instruct their representatives in Panmunjom to start negotiations with General Clark....

... The statement should specify that in the course of negotiations between the two sides in Kaesong and Panmunjom, agreement was reached on all issues, with the exception of the issue concerning P.O.W.s ...”

In the following sections of the documents, approved by the Soviet government on March 19, 1953, the Kremlin pointed out

that statements, which should be made in Pyongyang, Moscow and at the United Nations in New York, have two main purposes:

"1) to achieve real progress in the peaceful solution to the Korean problem; 2) to demonstrate to the world and to deepen in reality the "solidarity and concert of actions among the USSR, the PRC and the DPRK on the issue of the war in Korea"⁹⁰

On March 25, 1953, Molotov sent the following cable to Kim Il Sung:

"On March 21, the French government requested the Soviet government to assist in the liberation of 14 French citizens, interned by the authorities of the DPRK...

... We believe that, under the present conditions, it would be politically desirable to answer positively to the French request"⁹¹

On the morning of March 29, Soviet special envoys Kuznetsov and Fedorenko delivered to Kim Il Sung Moscow's decision to change the strategy in Korea: from war to peace. The cable to Moscow said:

"Kim Il Sung heard our comments and became very agitated. He said he was happy to hear the good news and asked to have an opportunity to examine our document thoroughly and meet again"⁹²

On June 3, 1953 Foreign Minister Molotov met American Ambassador Charles Bohlen. Among other things Molotov said:

"... We can state with satisfaction that ways to complete successfully the negotiations in Panmunjom have been identified"

Bohlen expressed hope that negotiations in Panmunjom will be completed successfully, because such a result will produce universal satisfaction.

Molotov agreed with Mr. Bohlen"⁹³

On July 3, 1953 a Chinese representative delivered to the Soviet Charge d'affaire in Beijing an analysis by the Chinese government of the current situation of the armistice talks in Korea and

⁹⁰ The Council of Ministers of the USSR decision, March 19, 1953. N 858-372cc.

⁹¹ Cable N 6352, March 23, 1953. Molotov to Kim Il Sung.

⁹² Cable N 8265, March 29, 1953. From Pyongyang to Moscow.

⁹³ Memorandum of Conversation, Molotov-Bohlen, June 3, 1953, P 132-133.

planned activities in connection with the letter of General Clark of June 29, 1953. The analysis said:

"Situation at negotiations:

During the last 12 days, when Syngman Rhee freed P.O.W.s and expanded the campaign against the armistice, the U.S.A., being deadlocked in the Korea War, is mainly preoccupied with calming down Syngman Rhee. They are trying to weaken Syngman Rhee's anti-armistice campaign and reach a compromise with him.

... However Syngman Rhee is trying to drag Americans into his plans... His demands contradict the resolution of the U.S.A. to end the war. As a result, two weeks of negotiations between the U.S.A. and Syngman Rhee are now in a deadlock. Americans are getting inclined to put pressure on Syngman Rhee.

Under these conditions. General Clark suddenly, on June 29, responded to the letter from Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai. The purpose of this answer was, first of all, to show Syngman Rhee that there was a limit to concessions and the U.S.A. would not make new concessions' to try, regardless of Syngman Rhee, to sign the armistice agreement; second, to show to us what limits he (General Clark) can go in his guarantees; by signing the armistice agreement he hopes to strengthen his position in the negotiations with Syngman Rhee (after the armistice it will be easier to limit supplies of weapons to Syngman Rhee) and to drop the question of 27,000 P.O.W.s; third, he wants to show to the whole world that the U.S.A. wants to end the war.

It can be predicted that Syngman Rhee, thoroughly understanding the weakness of the U.S.A., will not compromise.

However, the main player in the Korean War is the U.S.A., and, for the sake of their own interests, they'll probably at a certain moment increase pressure on Syngman Rhee. Therefore, though there are some big differences between the U.S.A. and Syngman Rhee on the armistice issue, still it is possible to talk about possibilities of achieving an armistice in Korea. At the same time it can be stated that Syngman Rhee, after achieving an armistice, will continue small-scale provocations.

Countermeasures.

Judging from the above-mentioned situation, and also taking into account fluctuations in American policy, triggered by com-

plicated internal and external disagreements in regard to South Korea, we propose to stick to the following line.

To hold the initiative in achieving the armistice, to concur with the American point of view on the armistice question in order to isolate Syngman Rhee and deliver him a blow, and, besides, to make Americans put pressure on Syngman Rhee and deepen internal and external American disagreements. In connection with this line of reasoning, we propose to take the following steps:

1. To prepare and send on July 5 the response of Kim Il Sung and Peng Dehuai to Clark. In the response to agree on resumption of negotiations, criticize the American side and to underline the possible repercussions of the American policy of appeasement.

2. Prepare and deliver a blow to the puppet troops of Syngman Rhee before signing the armistice in order to move the front line in the southern direction. After resumption of sessions, to mention to the opposite side that due to the guilt of Syngman Rhee the signing of the agreement was delayed, the situation has changed and, on the basis of the understanding that settlement of the issue should reflect the real situation, propose once more to correct the demarcation line.

It may be predicted that the opposite side will agree with this proposal because of the complications in its relations with Syngman Rhee at the present moment. However, it is also quite possible that the opposite side will not make concessions and will employ propaganda tricks. In such a case we are ready, having chosen the right moment, to finally give in and determine the demarcation line as it was before ...

... We think that the signing of the agreement should take place on July 15. It is necessary to announce that... delegations will arrive in Beijing on July 10.

... After delivering official documents Chinese representative Deputy Foreign Minister Wu Xueqian, on behalf of Zhou Enlai, orally added the following.

In the opinion of the P.R.C. government, the latest provocations of Syngman Rhee are explained, on the one hand, by his desire to extract from the U.S.A. as much aid as possible, and, on the other hand, his fear of Chinese volunteers in Korea and fear

of China in general. Precisely because of this Syngman Rhee insists on signing with the U.S.A. a mutual defense pact. If the Americans don't concede, Syngman Rhee says he will order South Korean troops to fight until the end. We think it is an empty threat.

The government of the P.R.C. believes that the United States will extend to Syngman Rhee only limited assistance. The United States is afraid that if they give Syngman Rhee aid on a large scale, then he can plunge into serious adventures and drag the U.S.A. along, too. As for Americans, they, however, don't want to be dragged into any large-scale adventures in the Far East. In this respect Americans have certain disagreements with Syngman Rhee.

There are disagreements as well between Syngman Rhee and the U.S.A. concerning the line of behavior at the future political conference. Syngman Rhee believes that if the conference does not accept his demands, then they should depart from the conference and resume large-scale offensive actions against North Korea up to the Yalu River, that is to the Chinese-Korean border. The Americans, on the other hand, believe that negotiations at the political conference should be stopped only if it is obvious that the Korean-Chinese representatives at this conference will achieve what North Korea and China could not achieve using weapons.

Considering all of the above, the government of the P.R.C. considers it necessary in the interests of peace to agree on the signing of the armistice agreement. In this case, Wu Xueqian said jokingly, we are facing a paradoxical situation when U.S.A. and China stand in a way together against Syngman Rhee...

Wu Xueqian also said that from the point of view of the P.R.C. government, Syngman Rhee will be able to organize small acts, but he will not be able to undertake anything serious"⁹⁴

On July 24, 1953 the Presidium of the CC of the Communist Party of the USSR passed a resolution on Kim Il Sung's participation in the signing ceremony in Panmunjom. The following instructions went to the Soviet Ambassador in North Korea:

"Inform Kim Il Sung and our Korean friends of the following: The CC of the CPSU endorse the signing of the armistice in

⁹⁴ Coded message N 17286, July 3, 1953, Soviet Embassy to the Kremlin.

Panmunjom from the Korean-Chinese side by one of the deputy Prime-Ministers of the DPRK and Peng Dehuai. Kim Il Sung as Prime-Minister, is not obliged to sign the armistice. The decision on the issue of who signs the document from the Korean-Chinese side belongs completely to the governments of the P.R.C. and DPRK and must not depend on pressure by the Americans etc.

At the present moment, the trip of Kim Il Sung to Panmunjom involves a certain risk, due to the behavior of Syngman Rhee's camp, which can make some kind of provocation against Comrade Kim Il Sung. The interests of our cause demand avoidance of the slightest possibility of such a provocation..., and it can be achieved only if Kim Il Sung does not personally participate in the signing of the armistice in Panmunjom. On this issue the CC of the CPSU does not advise to give in to any arguments, because these arguments in the current situation have only secondary significance. But, to be sure, refusal of Kim Il Sung to arrive in Panmunjom should not look offensive. Moreover, precisely because Kim Il Sung will not go to Panmunjom it is very important that comrade Peng Dehuai is there and signs the armistice personally together with a deputy Prime-Minister of the DPRK.

The CC of the CPSU does not think that Americans will use the absence of Kim Il Sung at Panmunjom to delay the signing ceremony. Such an act will not get support from the international community.

We don't think that you should be afraid of the unfavorable impression on the Korean and Chinese people, if Kim Il Sung does not participate personally in the signing. We hope that Korean and Chinese comrades will be able to give appropriate explanations, if it is necessary.

... We hope that our views will be taken into consideration"⁹⁵

On July 28, 1953, the Soviet Ambassador delivered the response to the Chinese analysis of the Korean situation of July 3, 1953. In his report to Moscow the Soviet Ambassador said:

"I told comrade Mao Zedong that the Soviet leadership completely agrees with the Chinese analysis that the situation is now ripe for ending hostilities in Korea. The opposite side does not

⁹⁵ Presidium of the CC of the CPSU decision N P 19/9, July 24, 1953.

The War in Korea 1950—1953

want and is not capable of continuing the war due to military reasons.

Mao Zedong asked to send his deepest appreciation to the Soviet leadership. Then he noted that the adversary had to agree on the armistice not only due to the military, but also political and economic reasons.

In the military sense, last year showed that the adversary was not capable of advancing on the ground, and he was not capable of holding firmly and defending the front line. As for the Chinese troops they've learned not only to conduct a positional war, but to execute the breaking of the front.

Among the political reasons, which influenced the adversary to agree on the armistice, Mao Zedong noted the military contradictions in the camp of imperialists and considerable surge of world public opinion against the war. Economically the war has also become unprofitable. During the first two years of the war American monopolies reaped enormous profits through military orders from the government, but then, because of approaching negotiations on the armistice and intensification of the anti-war movement, their profits sharply dwindled.

Going back to the military aspect, Mao Zedong said that from a purely military point of view it would be good to continue to strike at Americans for about a year in order to occupy more advantageous positions on the Han River

Further movement to the south would be risky "we would stretch our wings at the western and eastern shores of Korea. In this case the danger of enemy landing operations in the rear of the Chinese-Korean troops would grow"⁹⁶

On August 5, 1953 Kim Il Sung sent a personal note to the Soviet leadership:

"The government of the DPRK, starting to solve tasks in connection with restoration and construction of our Republic, has decided to invite Soviet specialists (expert brigades) for drafting restoration work and construction of the most important enterprises of the country"⁹⁷

⁹⁶ Coded message N 8019, July 29, 1953. From Soviet Ambassador in China to Moscow.

⁹⁷ Coded message N 20609, August 6, 1953.

On August 7, 1953, the Soviet Ambassador in Korea reported to Moscow:

“... We instructed our specialists to recommend that Koreans, while planning restoration of industry, concentrate on the most urgent needs of the economy and rely as much as possible on utilization of internal capabilities.

... However, as can be seen from the already drafted plans, the main emphasis is being put not on utilization of internal capabilities, but on getting the maximum aid from the USSR and countries of people's democracy.

It has to be pointed out as well that plans for economic restoration stress heavy industry, while light industry and agriculture are neglected.

According to the available information, the DPRK government intends to stop using our advisers at the ministries and greatly increase their numbers at industrial enterprises.

We think that Kim Il Sung should be invited to Moscow to discuss all these questions”⁹⁸

⁹⁸ Coded message N 20775, August 7, 1953.

Afterword

As could be seen from my documented narrative the Korean war was a product of ideological hatred both inside Korea, between two Korean regimes, and on the international arena, between two antagonistic camps, Soviet and American.

It is true that the communist side attacked first but the opposing side was as much ready for fighting and elimination of the adversary. What started in June 1950 was destined to start sooner or later.

The war inflicted countless wounds to the Koreans and turned the Korean peninsula for the rest of the 20th century into a powder keg ready to blow any second. The conflict had also made the Cold War between Moscow and Washington irreversible and this poisoned international relations for many decades to come.

This is the first conclusion which can be drawn from the study of the war in Korea. The second obvious conclusion should become our determination to finish with confrontational policies on the Korean peninsula, with attempts to defeat the opponent. Instead the two Korean sides must learn to live in harmony with each other, to cooperate and to strive for a peaceful, smooth unification of the Korean nation.

Conditions for such scenario are finally ripe: leaders of the DPRK and the ROK have begun a dialogue and all great powers traditionally involved in Korean affairs support the detente and successful solution of the Korean problem.

Moscow
September 3, 2000